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EC rejects reports of internal rift

INDIA bloc parties likely to meet on September 30 to discuss the strategy

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Facing criticism and a political onslaught over reported fissures within the Election Commission over the nationwide Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, the poll body came out on Saturday to counter reports of dissent within and issued a point-by-point clarification on allegations about its functioning, saying all decisions are taken unanimously.

The three Election Commissioners also met for the first time since the controversy broke out three days ago and announced some decisions. The poll body said it approved all decisions on the SIR of electoral rolls, including the nationwide exercise, unanimously. It announced measures to simplify the process for voters facing notices over discrepancies.

The poll panel said the Supreme Court upheld the declaration attached to Form 6 for the SIR. The poll body said those who receive notices during the ongoing



Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi during a meeting at Nirvachan Sadan in New Delhi

SIR for being unmapped or having logical discrepancies will not ordinarily have to appear before the electoral registration officer (ERO).

BLOs will visit the homes of such persons to collect documents and then upload them on the ECINET for the ERO's decision. Such persons need not be called

for a hearing at the ERO/AERO office.

The detailed clarification or rebuttal also came after three key NDA allies on Friday urged Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar to come clean on the allegations and restore public confidence in the institution. The main opposition

Congress held a nationwide protest on Friday demanding Gyanesh Kumar's resignation. Three BJP allies — LJP (Ram Vilas), TDP and RLM — have also sought a clearer explanation from the EC. This is the first time the Commission has outlined its internal functioning and laid out its position in a letter to

the Cabinet Secretary. The Opposition parties, which have been against the SIR, are preparing for a coordinated response, with the INDIA bloc parties likely to meet here on September 30 to discuss the strategy.

On the Form 6 issue, questions were raised over a declaration attached to the form during the SIR process, asking prospective voters to map to the previous SIR via their parents' names. The EC said the Supreme Court has upheld the declaration attached to Form 6 for the SIR. For non-SIR periods, forms prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, will be used.

In a letter to the Cabinet Secretary, the EC said the letters sent by the two commissioners — Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi — to the Cabinet Secretary were not related to any policy matter of the Commission or its IT division, but to the work of an officer on deputation to the poll panel.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

India lashes out at Pak over terrorism at United Nations

YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

Describing Pakistan as a "puppet" regime, India has ripped into the country's "falsehoods" and "deceit" at the United Nations (UN), warning that continued terrorism by Islamabad will have consequences.

India exercised its Right of Reply on Friday night after Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif used the UN General Assembly podium to credit US President Donald Trump for his "timely intervention" in the 2025 conflict with India, as he again raked up the Kashmir issue in his address at the world organisation.

First Secretary in the Permanent Mission of India to the UN, Petal Gahlot, said, "We heard some hypocritical homilies about democratic rights and human values from a regime whose capital at this very moment is being fortified against its own people." "And that...is happening because this is a regime of the army, by the army, and for the army. Their puppets may come and go but let us have no illusion who calls the shots. The reality of Pakistan is expressed in its 27th Amendment and the lifelong immunity granted to its real ruler," Gahlot said.

She was referring to the 27th Constitutional Amendment passed in November last year by the Shehbaz Sharif Government, which grants Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces and Chief of the Army Staff Field Marshal Asim Munir lifelong immunity from any legal prosecution.

"We are confident that this Assembly will recognise Pakistan and its policies for what they really are; not



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar co-chairs an event on 'AI in the Context of International Peace & Security, with an Emphasis on Maritime Security' in New York

Terror sponsors cannot escape consequences, says Jaishankar

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar delivered a strong message on terrorism and cross-border violence at the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), warning that countries supporting terrorism cannot expect immunity from its consequences.

Without directly naming Pakistan in his UN address, Jaishankar described the country as a "serial practitioner of terrorism". He rejected attempts to use the international forum to normalise or justify terrorism.

"A serial practitioner of terrorism has misrepresented facts before this

Assembly, seeking to normalise terrorism and claim immunity from its consequences. That will not stand," Jaishankar said.

The External Affairs Minister asserted India's right to respond to terrorism and stressed that diplomatic goodwill cannot coexist indefinitely with continued terrorist attacks.

"We will exercise our right to defend ourselves against terrorism. Friendship and goodwill cannot coexist with terrorism. Understandings based on them will naturally be called into question. It is for the perpetrator of terrorism to change its ways," he said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

PIONEER IN SHORT

CHOUHAN PROMISES AID TO FLOOD-HIT FARMERS

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Saturday said the Union Government will provide all possible support to the farmers affected by drought and floods in various States.

Speaking at an event, he said his ministry was in constant contact with the Maharashtra Government regarding the drought situation. The Maharashtra Government earlier in the day declared drought in 74 per cent of the State. Chouhan said contingency plans for the affected districts were ready.

"We will provide every possible support to the farmers in coordination with the State Government," he said.

While some States in the country were dealing with floods, others have drought, the Union Agriculture Minister noted, adding, "We are witnessing adverse effects of climate change, and we have to deal with them."

"We are doing two kinds of things. First, for areas facing drought, our institutes like ICAR (Indian Council of Agricultural Research) and other concerned institutions have prepared contingency plans for each district. We have shared those with the State Governments and informed the districts. If rainfall is low, the plans tell farmers which crops can be grown in a shorter time, which crops require less water, and what measures should be taken," Chouhan said.

As to the flood-affected areas, he said farmers need not worry. "The situation is serious, but we will get through it," he said.

SIR controversy sparks fresh BJP-Opposition clash

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

The BJP and the Opposition sparred over the Election Commission's statement on the ongoing controversy during the SIR exercise. The ruling BJP and its NDA partner TDP seized the EC's statement, turning an institutional row into a blunt political attack.

The ruling BJP on Saturday said that the ECI statement on the SIR row has "clearly established" that the decision to conduct a SIR of elec-



Ravi Shankar Prasad

toral rolls was taken with the full consensus of CEC Gyanesh Kumar and the two election commissioners.

Soon after the EC's statement, the Congress hit back, claiming they're in "damage control mode" and adding

that the EC didn't deny the media report claims and gave a "wishy-washy" statement which "avoids answering the questions regarding the deliberate targeting of Gen Z voters."

After the EC's statement, senior leader Ravi Shankar Prasad said Rahul Gandhi had run "malicious propaganda" on a "factually wrong" media report. "Rahul Gandhi was lying and running malicious propaganda. He is a non-serious politician," Prasad said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Heavy rain disrupts life; Char Dham Yatra halted

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ranchi/Lucknow/Dehradun

Heavy rain disrupted normal life in Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand and Uttarakhand, forcing authorities to suspend the Char Dham Yatra until September 27.

UP bore the brunt of the depression over northeast Madhya Pradesh and adjoining north Chhattisgarh. The weather system, moving north-northwestwards towards southeast UP, brought heavy showers. As many as 63 districts recorded rainfall above normal, with some areas facing a moderate risk of flash floods.

Six people were killed in separate rain-related inci-



dents, with all the casualties reported from Lakhimpur Kheri, Amethi and Barabanki districts.

The heavy rain, thunderstorms and strong winds also damaged standing crops in rural areas and over 100 houses across the state, as it received 19 times the normal rainfall in the past 24 hours, according to officials.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Reddy's 'Gandhi Parivar' remark sparks BJP attack on Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Saturday accused the Congress of treating the Gandhi family as the centre of Indian politics rather than as one party leadership among others.

The charge followed remarks by Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Friday, in which he described the national contest as a struggle between the "Sangh Parivar" and the "Gandhi Parivar."

Reddy spoke in Nilambur, Kerala, after receiving the Aryadan Muhammed-2026 Best Public Servant Award.

Reddy called the Sangh Parivar the biggest threat to the country and to democ-



racy. He alleged that it was trying to divide India based on caste, religion, region and language.

He said the Gandhi family stood for sacrifice. He said Mahatma Gandhi, Indira

Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi had given their lives for the nation, while Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi had given up posts and power.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Gold double: India's men and women rule Asiad kabaddi

AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

India's supremacy in the Asian Games Kabaddi competition remained intact as both the men's and women's teams outwitted familiar foes, Iran, in their respective summit clashes to defend their gold medals here on Saturday.

The men's team prevailed 40-34, while the women clinched a 37-34 win to extend their dominance at the event. This was the ninth gold for the men and fourth for the women. The men's win came without their most experienced player, Pawan



India's players pose for photographs after winning gold medals in the men's and women's kabaddi finals against Iran at the 20th Asian Games in Tokai City, Japan, on Saturday (Related reports on P11)



PTI

Sehrawat, even stepping on the mat. With the defending champions struggling for control midway through the contest, it was the compo-

sure of raiders Arjun Deswal and Devank in the decisive phase that tilted a gripping final in India's favour.

Iran fought for every point

as if it were the last, matching and even exceeding India's physicality, refusing to let the defending champions settle into a rhythm. At half-time,

Iran held a slender 18-17 lead, and India had every reason to be concerned. The Iranian side's relentless approach had put the Indians under

pressure. But India did not panic. Instead, they changed the tempo of the game, trusted their raiders, and let experience take over. Arjun and Devank repeatedly ventured deep into the Iranian half, picked their moments and returned with crucial points, gradually forcing Iran onto the back foot.

The tactical adjustment wasn't limited to the raiders. Aslam Mustafa, who had struggled early after venturing too deep and being pinned, was moved into defence, where he found a more effective role.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Spurious liquor claims 19 lives in Nagaland

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mokokchung (Nagaland)

At least 19 people have died allegedly after drinking spurious liquor in Nagaland, with police forming a team to trace the supply chain of suspected adulterated liquor in the state where a prohibition law has been in place since 1990.

Police said Mokokchung district reported eight deaths and Tuensang district 11 over the past two days following consumption of suspected illicit liquor.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT), headed by Additional Superintendent

cause of deaths, he said. "We have obtained some leads, but it is too premature to disclose details." Following the deaths, police conducted multiple raids and arrested 19 people and seized close to 3,000 bottles of liquor. The Tuensang police on Saturday had also confirmed that methanol was found in the illicit alcohol that was seized.

A press release from the Tuensang police, citing the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL), Dimapur, said, "Quantitative estimation of methanol could not be carried out due to non-availability of the required instruments."



of Police I Bunglang Chang, has been constituted to investigate the deaths and trace the source and supply chain of the suspected adulterated liquor. Senior Superintendent of Police, Vesupra Kezo, said on Saturday.

Samples have been sent to Guwahati for forensic examination to ascertain the

Police have advised people to refrain from consuming unidentified, unlabelled or suspected illicit liquor and urged anyone developing symptoms such as dizziness, blurred vision, breathing difficulties or loss of consciousness after consuming alcohol to seek medical care immediately.

PUC enforcement from October 1, cameras at all centres: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday said the Delhi Government will launch an enforcement drive for valid PUC certificates from October 1. She also said the Delhi Government is installing cameras at all PUC centres issuing the certificates.

The Chief Minister said the system of PUC) centres in Delhi would also be made more effective and reliable. "The enforcement system related to valid Pollution Under Control certificates will be implemented in Delhi from October 1. At the same time, work will also be undertaken to strengthen the mon-



itoring and functioning of PUC centres through technology," the chief minister said after inaugurating a state-of-the-art Automated Testing Station (ATS) in Burari area. "We want to ensure that

every person in Delhi gets clean air to breathe. This enforcement will check whether Pollution Under Control (PUC) certificates are valid. Delhi Government is working round the year to reduce air pollution; this is one step towards that," she said, addressing a crowd.

The chief minister said it was a matter of pride for Delhi that one of the country's largest Automated Testing Stations had been established in the capital. The facility is an important step towards making Delhi's vehicle fitness testing system modern, transparent and technology-driven. The five-lane Automated Testing Station in Burari can conduct

fitness tests for one lakh vehicles every year.

"More commercial vehicles will be tested and checked for pollution norms through this," she added.

The Burari ATS will test 40,000 heavy motor vehicles and 60,000 light motor vehicles annually. The five-lane facility is an important step towards making vehicle fitness testing scientific, transparent and technology-driven. Fitness tests will be carried out through a fully automated process, covering parameters such as braking efficiency, suspension performance, headlight condition, side-slip, emission levels and the underside of vehicles.

Gurugram Police order strict adherence to excise timings for pubs, bars and restaurants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

Gurugram Police have ordered pubs, bars, and restaurants in the city to follow the operating hours set by the Haryana Excise Department. Police Commissioner Sibash Kabiraj warned that any business breaking these rules will face quick action. Senior officers will also be held responsible if they do not enforce the rules properly.

The instructions were sent to all Deputy Commissioners of Police, Assistant Commissioners of Police, and Station House Officers through video calls and written messages. An official statement said the Commissioner expects



both discipline and personal responsibility from the police in following these rules.

Under the new rules, every licensed business must clearly display its approved operating hours at the entrance. They must close at the set time, and no outlet can stay open past the hours allowed by the Excise Department. Kabiraj said that strict compliance

with these timings will be enforced, and no business will be allowed to stay open late.

To ensure compliance, DCPs, ACPs, and SHOs have been told to conduct random, unannounced inspections in their areas. These checks should happen often enough to stop businesses from staying open late. DCPs and ACPs are personally respon-

sible for ensuring orders are followed in their zones.

The Commissioner stressed that these orders must lead to real action, not just paperwork. Kabiraj warned that any business breaking the rules will be dealt with quickly. Police officers who fail to enforce the rules will also face serious consequences, including legal or departmental action if found negligent. By focusing on both business compliance and police accountability, the aim is to stop venues from staying open after closing time, as has happened in the past.

The move comes against the backdrop of Gurugram's well-known nightlife, especially in places like Sector 29, Golf Course Road, MG Road, and other busy areas.

DDA holds investors' meet to push In-Situ slum rehabilitation under Master Plan 2047

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) organised an investors' meet on September 25 to take forward its In-Situ Slum Rehabilitation Programme under Master Plan of Delhi 2047, officials said.

The meeting brought together developers to discuss opportunities under the programme and seek their views on a practical framework for implementing rehabilitation projects across Delhi.

The MPD-2047 envisages in-situ rehabilitation of approximately 17 lakh JJ

cluster dwellers.

"The Master Plan seeks to transform the national capital into a city that creates opportunities for all while leaving no one behind. It provides an enabling framework to unlock redevelopment potential while promoting inclusive and sustainable urban



growth. In-situ rehabilitation is an important component of this transformation," the DDA said in a statement.

The programme aims to improve housing and living conditions for eligible residents at their existing locations, while enabling integrated neighbourhood develop-

ment, better urban infrastructure and more efficient land utilisation.

Its objective is to create sustainable neighbourhoods alongside the provision of quality housing, it added.

"The Investors' Meet provided an interactive platform for developers and other

stakeholders to share their views on project structure, implementation mechanisms, risk allocation, financing considerations and approval processes. The feedback received will assist DDA in further refining the proposed framework," the authority further said.

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority
Administrative Building, Sector-96, Noida 201301 (U.P.)
Website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited from eligible contractors/firms for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official Website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) Fresh-Tender Work:

Sl. No.	Jobs No.	Name of the work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
1.	72/GM/SM(WC-10)/ET/2026-27	P/F Signage Boards for Village inside & Internal Gali in Village Momnathal Noida	54.03
2.	59/GM/SM(WC-8)/ET/2026-27	M/o Building (Annual Maintenance of Staff House Type of EWS, LIG, MIG & HIG in Sector-82 & 93) Noida	45.04
3.	51/GM/SM(WC-6)/2026-27	Development and maintenance of Village (Barricating work of Noida Land with RCC Standard post & coil fencing work in village Sorkha, Jahidabad), Noida	36.05

The above tenders can be uploaded from **dated 28.09.2026 to 13.10.2026** up to **5.00 PM**. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated **14.10.2026 at 11.00 AM**.

B) Re-Tender Work:

Sl. No.	Jobs No.	Name of the work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
4.	20/GM/SM(WC-07)/ET/2025-26	M/o Road (Annual Maintenance of road, Central Verge and footpath in Work Circle-7 area) Noida	95.31
5.	23/GM/SM(WC-07)/ET/2026-27	M/o Road (R/o Pot Holes in various Sector's of Work Circle-7 area) Noida	76.42
6.	66/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	Emergency Work (Fencing with RCC post vacant Noida land for safety of land of different village and Sector of work Circle-9) Noida	64.40
7.	72/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	M/o Road (C/o RCC Central Verge on 45.00 mtr. wide road in Between Sector-131&133) Noida	92.10
8.	77/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	D/o Village (Repair and maintenance of boundary wall 5% plot, CC road MS Jaal work in village Sultanpur) Noida	72.92
9.	78/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	D/o Village (Maintenance of Sports Ground and Boundary wall in Village Raipur) Noida	31.49
10.	03/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	Theme Painting of walls in Noida for Swachh Survekshan 2025-26 WC-08 and 09 Area, Noida	55.86
11.	52/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	D/o Village (P/F Reflective Signage Boards in Village Internal Gali in Village Raipur) Noida	31.85
12.	60/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	D/o Sector-94 & 94A (C/o Cremation Platform, Shed and renovate of wooden storage hall and other maintenance work in Antim Niwas Sector-94A) Noida	89.00
13.	50/GM/SM(WC-07)/ET/2026-27	D/o Village (C/o Verandah, Room and Toilet in Shamshan Ghat of village Yakubpur) Noida	31.93
14.	57/GM/SM(WC-08)/ET/2025-26	Strengthening of Road (P/L B.C. work on internal road of Sharmik kunj Flats in Sector-110) Noida	48.08
15.	81/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	D/o Village (R/o Community Center, Boundary Wall & other maintenance work in village Nagli Wazidpur and P/L direction board in Sector-130) Noida	78.27
16.	83/GM/SM(WC-09)/ET/2026-27	D/o Village (M/o Community Center in Gali No. 44 in Village Chhapoli) Noida	79.21
17.	24/GM/SM(WC-06)/2026-27	M/o Roads (Thermoplastic Road Marking Paint and road safety work on main roads of Sector-74, 75, 76 & 77), Noida	95.99
18.	25/GM/SM(WC-06)/2026-27	Engagement of Agency for Manual Based Night Sweeping and Housekeeping Services in Commercial/Market/Vending Zone/Public Area WC-6, Noida	39.23
19.	30/GM/SM(WC-06)/2025-26	M/o Road (Re-Construction of footpath and other Misc. work on 24.00 mtr. wide road in front of Mahadev Apartment in Sector-73) Noida	97.01
20.	31/GM/SM(WC-06)/2026-27	D/o Village (C/o Two Rooms in Baba Bhimrao Ambedkar Ground in Village Sarfabad) Noida	45.87

The above tenders can be uploaded from **dated 28.09.2026 to 05.10.2026** up to **5.00 PM**. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated **06.10.2026 at 11.00 AM**.

General Managar (Civil)
Noida

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E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

30 DAYS AUCTION SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 8(b) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002. On account of the amalgamation between Aditya Birla Finance Ltd. and Aditya Birla Capital Ltd. vide the Scheme of Amalgamation dated 11.03.2024 duly recorded in the Order passed by the National Company Law Tribunal-Ahmedabad on 24.03.2025, all SARFAESI actions initiated by Aditya Birla Finance Ltd. in relation to the mortgaged property mentioned, stands transferred to Aditya Birla Capital Ltd., the amalgamated company. Accordingly, the **Authorized Officer of Aditya Birla Capital Limited** / Secured Creditor had **TAKEN POSSESSION** of the following secured assets pursuant to notice issued under Sec. 13(2) of Securitisation & Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (SARFAESI) for recovery of the secured debts of the secured creditor, for the dues as mentioned herein below with further charges and cost thereon from the following Borrowers and Co-Borrowers. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrowers and Co-Borrowers that e-auction of the following property for realization of the debts due to the **Aditya Birla Capital Limited** will be held on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" basis.

DATE & TIME OF E-AUCTION : 30.10.2026, BETWEEN 11:00 A. M. TO 01:00 P. M. LAST DATE OF RECEIPT OF KYC & EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT (EMD) : 29.10.2026				
Sr. No.	Name of the Borrowers & Co-Borrowers	Description of Properties / Secured Assets	Reserve Price (in Rs.)	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (in Rs.) / Incremental Value) (in Rs.) Demand Notice Date & Total Amt. (in Rs.)
1.	M/s. Empire Plywood Through Its Proprietor Ayaz Ahmad, Mr. Ayaz Ahmad, S/o. Irshad Ahmad	All That Piece & parcel of A Residential Triple Storied House Nagari Palika No. W/13/86, Having An Area 137.33 Sq. Yards i. e. 114.86 Sq. Meters, Constructed On Plot No. 48, Consisting of Khasra No. 561 Situated At Mohalla Trilokipuram, Hapur, Tehsil & Dist. Hapur; Measurement & Boundaries Of Which Are As Under - East : 24 Ft. / House On Plot No. 33; West : 24 Ft. / Rasta 15 Ft. Wide; North : 51 Ft. 6 Inch / House of Masoom Ali S/o. Bundu Khan On Plot No. 49; South : 51 Ft. 6 Inch / House of Shabnam, W/o. Abrar Ahmad On Plot No. 47	Rs. 83,20,000/- (Rs. Eighty Three Lacs Twenty Thousand Only)	07.04.2026 & Rs. 70,55,593/- (Rs. Seventy Thousand Five Hundred Ninety and Three Only) as on 07.04.2026
1.	Mrs. Sayra Bano, W/o. Irshad Ahmad LAN : ABNDST300000823087 & ABNDST300000823104		Rs. 25,00,000/- (Rs. Twenty Five Thousand Only)	

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in Aditya Birla Capital Limited / Secured Creditor's website i. e. <https://abli.adityabirlacapital.com/Pages/Individual/Properties-for-Auction-under-SARFAESI-Act.aspx> or <https://BidDeal.in> Contact Nos.: Aditya Birla Capital Limited, Authorized Officer, Parnet Singh : (97200 29337), Vedprakash Mishra (9004026790), Mohit Sharma (9873913855), Komal Pali (9667895795), Kundan Singh (7506702669), Narendra Giri (9654108805), Jahirul Laskar (9706003075), Apoorva Danthi (9930909725). Place : Hapur, Uttar Pradesh, Date : 27.09.2026 Sol^d Authorised Officer, Aditya Birla Capital Limited

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आवेदन 30 सितम्बर 2026 से 29 अक्टूबर 2026 तक खुले रहेंगे।

OFFICER ENTRY

Online applications are invited for Technical Graduate Course (TGC-145) (scheduled in July 2027).

Applications will remain open from 30 Sep 2026 to 29 Oct 2026.

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मुख्य कार्यालय - साकेत भवन, आई.टी.आई. चौक, कोरबा (छ.ग.)
मु.का. दूरभाष : 221288, 222672, फैक्स : 07759-221929, मो. निवि.सं. - 12 पिन कोड - 495677
Website : www.korbamunicipal.in, korba.urbansecg.gov.in, Email : corporationkorba@gmail.com
फा.क्र./1498/जल प्रदाय/2026/ कोरबा, दिनांक:23/09/2026

Gem Portal Bid Invitation

नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा के जल आपूर्ति कार्य हेतु इच्छुक सेवा प्रदाता से अकुल ऑफ़ (एसमेंट) प्रदाय हेतु जेम् पोर्टल के माध्यम से बिड आमंत्रित किया जाता है, जिसका विवरण निम्नासूत्र है :-

Gem Bid No./Issue date	Description	Estimate Amount	Earnest Money	Bid due date	Due date for Submission of Sealed envelope
GEM/2026/ B/8068462 Dt 23.09.2026	Selection of Placement Agency For Manpower Outsourcing Services Under Minimum Wages For Water Works At Municipal Corporation Korba.	102.43 Lakh	01 Lakh	15.10.2026	21.10.2026

बिड की विस्तृत जानकारी **GEM Portal** पोर्टल <https://gem.gov.in> के साथ ही विभागीय वेबसाइट <http://korbamunicipal.in> एवं <https://uad.cg.gov.in> में देखा एवं डाउनलोड किया जा सकता है।

अधीक्षण अधिकारी
नगर पालिक निगम
कोरबा (छ.ग.)

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is informed to the public at large that my client, Sh. Sanjay Khanna S/o: Late Sh. R. K. Khanna, R/o: House No. 90-A, DDA LIC Flat, Jhilmil, O. East, Delhi-110095, hereby disown and sever all relations with his son, Mr. Abhishek Khanna and wife Mrs. Vandana Khanna, due to their conduct causing mental harassment. They has no claim over my client movable or immovable properties, present or future. My client shall not be responsible for any of his acts or deeds henceforth.

AAYUSH BAJPAI ADVOCATE
A-14 Tower 21(111), Kidwai Nagar East, New Delhi-110023 PH:+91 7275893423

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Nirjja Masak Yalg is the owner of A House area 450 sq. fts., i.e 41.8 sq. mtrs., comprised of Khasra No. 40, situated at Shanti Nagar, Village Shanti, Pargana-Loni, Tehsil & Dist. Ghazabad, U.P. Same is owned by Sale Deed Dated 20.05.2024 Document No 6207, That Chala document (1) Sale Deed dated 13.12.2013, Doc. No. 11943, (2) Sale Deed dated 08.04.2015, Doc. No. 2558 (3) Sale Deed dated 21.08.2015, Doc. No. 6495, (4) Sale Deed dated 18.01.2019, Doc. No. 588, has been lost that Mr. Sanjeev informed to D.P. Police on dated 25.09.2016 vide I.A.R. No. 66290/2026. All Persons are hereby informed that if anybody has found this documents or Any Person, Corporation, company, financial institution & others has any claim/charge/interest/title in the said property or any kind of dispute kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Rohit Kumar Advocate
Medhawi Enforcement & Legal Service
Office No 314, Third Floor, Rishabh Court 9, Sector-41 Vaishali Ghaziabad U.P. Mob no: 730601626, 9818171626, Email: medhaswienforcement@gmail.com

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CHANGE OF NAME

I, Kishore Kumar Rathour, S/O Sh. Jagdish Rathour and father of Utkarsh Rathour and R/O 6667, Block 9, Street 6, Dev Nagar Karol Bagh, New Delhi, my child's (Utkarsh Rathour) School Record (10th and 12th Markeheet) my name is mentioned as Kishore Kumar Rathour I have changed my name to Kishore Rathour for all future purposes.



Speeding car kills auto driver, injures one; racing suspected

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 45-year-old auto-rickshaw driver was killed and another man injured after an allegedly speeding car rammed into two vehicles in southeast Delhi's Sukhdev Vihar area on Saturday morning, with an eyewitness claiming that two cars were racing moments before the crash, police said.

The incident occurred at around 7 am. The deceased was identified as Md Kalam, a resident of New Friends Colony, whose auto-rickshaw was involved in the accident, they said. The injured man was identified as Md Bablu, a vagabond residing near Sukhdev Vihar Metro station, police said.

Jeet, an eyewitness who was on his way to work, told PTI that he had stopped for tea and was leaving at around 7 am when he heard a loud noise. "I turned to see that an accident had happened."

"Two cars were racing each other, and one car rammed into the auto. By that time, the other car fled at high speed," he said.

The auto-rickshaw driver died on the spot, while the car subsequently hit a cycle rickshaw, causing another man to fall and sustain



A damaged vehicle being towed from the site after an allegedly speeding car rammed into two vehicles, leaving a 45-year-old auto-rickshaw driver killed and another man injured at Sukhdev Vihar area in New Delhi PTI

injuries, he said. "The car was coming from the flyover side and going towards Shaheen Bagh. You can guess the speed by the impact on the auto. There were three to four men in the car. They fled as soon as the incident happened (leaving behind the vehicle)," Jeet said.

A tea seller at the spot said he reached the area around 8-9 am, after the accident had already taken place. "Someone was saying that the car had rammed into the auto," he said.

A video recorded by a passerby showed the extent of the damage caused in the crash. The car was found extensively damaged, with its airbag deployed and glass and bonnet broken. Items

inside the vehicle were also seen damaged, while the occupants had apparently abandoned it and fled.

The auto-rickshaw was severely crushed, and a bleeding Kalam could be seen lying unconscious on the road in the video. According to preliminary information, the car first rammed into the auto-rickshaw before hitting a cycle rickshaw, police said.

Kalam was taken to Escorts Hospital, where doctors declared him dead. His body is being shifted to AIIMS for postmortem examination, police said.

Police are examining CCTV footage and other evidence to establish the sequence of events and identify the car's owner and occupants.

Drunk man rams SUV into parked cars, injures community dog; FIR filed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A man allegedly driving under the influence of alcohol rammed his SUV into several parked vehicles and injured a community dog in south Delhi's CR Park, following which an FIR was registered, police said on Saturday. The incident took place around 9.30 pm on September 24 in Alaknanda, they said.

According to police, a PCR call was received regarding rash and negligent driving, following which a team reached the spot and found the vehicle with three occupants, of whom the driver was found inebriated.

Proceedings under Section 185 of the Motor Vehicles Act were initiated, and the vehicle was seized, they said. The residents, in

their joint complaint on September 25, alleged that a black SUV rammed into several parked vehicles before hitting the closed gate of a residential society.

The security guards and some residents apprehended the car occupants, who then allegedly argued and hurled abuses at them before attempting to leave, the complaint stated.

The complaint further alleged that a community dog was seriously injured in the incident and suffered a fracture. The dog was undergoing treatment at a private hospital.

Following the complaint, an FIR was registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, police said. Further investigation is underway, they added.



Govt forms 3 panels to oversee Ramlila, Durga Puja and Chhath preparations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ahead of the festival season, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday formed three separate special committees under two ministers to improve coordination and preparations for the upcoming Ramlila, Durga Puja, and Chhath Puja celebrations.

Art and Culture Minister Kapil Mishra will head the committees for Durga Puja and Chhath Puja, while Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh will oversee the committee for Ramlila arrangements. Delhi is estimated to have 600-700 Ramlila organisers, 400-500 Durga Puja organisers and 1,300-1,500 Chhath Puja organisers.

The committees will review and finalise venues for the respective festivals and play an important role in



monitoring and coordinating essential arrangements at the venues, including civic facilities, security, traffic management, sanitation, electricity and medical services.

After setting up three committees, the Chief Minister said the Delhi Government's objective is to ensure that devotees and organising com-

mittees face no inconvenience during these major religious festivals in the capital and that all necessary arrangements are completed on time.

In a statement, the Chief Minister's Office said the committee constituted to review and finalise venues and preparations for Ramlilas being organised across Delhi will be

headed by Minister for Social Welfare, Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes Welfare, Cooperation and Elections, Ravindra Indraj Singh. MLAs Ashok Goel, Anil Kumar Sharma, Shyam Sharma, Sanjay Goel and Sandeep Sehrawat will be other members of the committee. The Secretary, Revenue-cum-Divisional Commissioner, will be its Member Secretary.

Art and Culture Minister Kapil Mishra will head the committees for Chhath Puja and Durga Puja celebrations. MLA Shikha Roy, MLA Neeraj Basoya, social worker Anjali Bhattacharya, Devdutt Bhardwaj and Arun Mukherjee have been included as members in the Durga Puja committee. The Secretary, Revenue-cum-Divisional Commissioner, will serve as the Member Secretary. MLAs Abhay Kumar Verma,

Chandan Kumar Chaudhary, Sandeep Sehrawat and Deepak Chaudhary, along with social worker Santosh Ojha, will serve as members of the Chhath Puja committee. The Secretary, Revenue-cum-Divisional Commissioner, will be its Member Secretary.

The committee's key responsibilities will include facilitating the issuance of necessary NOCs through the concerned District Magistrate's office under the single-window system. It will also ensure adequate arrangements for drinking water, medical assistance, ambulance services, fire services, security, mobile toilets, traffic management, cleanliness, and fogging at puja venues. It will also ensure electricity connections and uninterrupted power supply at the venues.

Artificial skeleton found during cleanliness drive; forensic test rules out human remains



An artificial skeleton is seen in a wooden box after it was found during a cleanliness drive near Kali Mata Mandir on DDU Marg in New Delhi PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An artificial skeleton was found inside a wooden box during a cleanliness drive near Kali Mata Mandir on DDU Marg in central Delhi on Saturday, with a forensic examination confirming that it was made of artificial bones and not human remains, police said.

Police received information about the suspected skeleton-like material during a cleanliness drive by Delhi BJP and reached the spot, where they found the wooden box containing an old assembled skeletal structure.

No bloodstains or other apparently suspicious material were found on or around the box, the police said.

During a preliminary inquiry, it emerged that the material had been purchased as scrap from Government Boys Senior Secondary School on Mata Sundari Road, along

with other old and broken articles. The school principal told police that the institution had shifted to a new building in 2023 and the old and broken articles from the earlier building were disposed of as scrap in July 2026 during a cleanliness drive.

The forensic and crime teams examined the material at the spot. The preliminary assessment by the forensic expert indicated that the structure comprised artificial bones and was not human skeletal remains, the police said.

The structure could have been used for educational or study purposes, including in a school laboratory, they said.

The artificial skeleton was found inside a box of a scrap dealer, Mohammad Shakeel, near Kali temple, Delhi, BJP vice president Rajesh Bhatia said. The police said there is no prima facie indication of any criminal offence in the matter.

Govt to set up police posts under flyovers, at subways to boost women's safety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In view of the recent incidents of violence against women in the national Capital, the Delhi Government has expedited its plan to set up police posts at pedestrian subways, beneath flyovers and near foot overbridges.

Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Saturday directed officials to finalise the project in coordination with the Delhi Police and implement it as soon as possible.

"With the Delhi Police and the PWD completing formalities, directions have been given to issue tenders and start work on the ground. In the initial phase, we plan to set up police posts at around 50 locations. The Government will set them up from its own



budget, while the Delhi Police must provide manpower and manage the area. Tenders for the project will be floated soon," Singh said.

Through the project, the Government aims to improve the safety and utilisation of public infrastructure, he added.

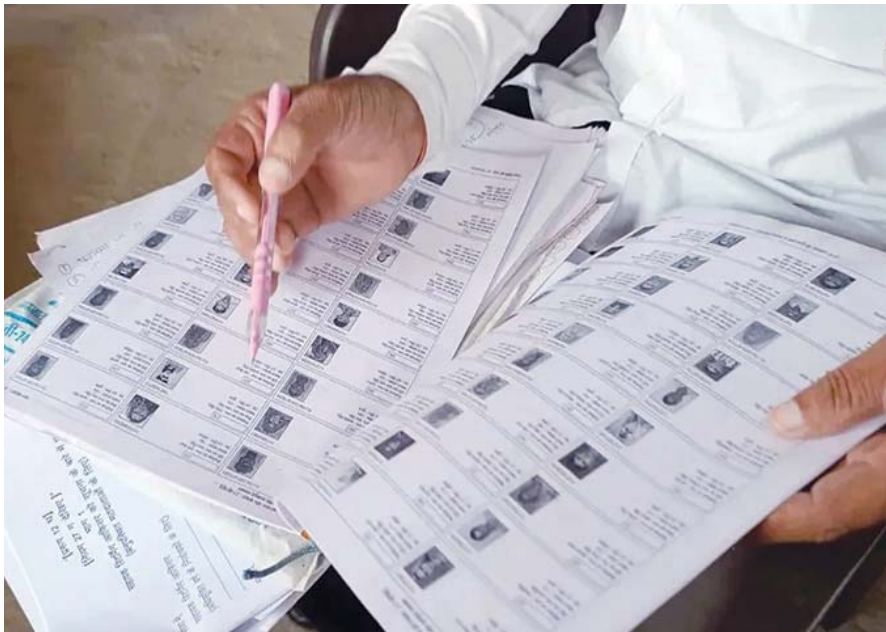
PWD, which maintains around 106 flyovers, 115 foot overbridges and nearly 70 subways, will construct the proposed police posts for

the Delhi Police.

Officials said the Government received an initial proposal from the Delhi Police to set up about 50 posts, which was found feasible on assessment. "While we have approved that proposal, in future, we plan to cover all road assets such as flyovers, pedestrian subways and foot overbridges.

Approximately 300 police posts will be set up," officials said. In the later phase of the

ECI extends deadline for objections on draft voter list till October 30



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India on Saturday extended the period for filing claims and objections under the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls in Delhi by a month, until October 30, with the final voter list now slated for publication on December 4.

Under the revised schedule, the deadline for disposal of notices and claims and objections has also been extended by a month, till November 30. The claims and objections process, which began on August 31, was earlier scheduled to end on September 30, while the disposal of notices and claims and objections was to be completed by October 30. The final electoral roll was scheduled for publication on November 4.

The revised schedule follows a request from the Delhi chief electoral officer (CEO), made in a letter dated September 23, seeking revision of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) schedule for the national capital. The extension comes as the claims and objections phase is underway following the publication of the draft rolls containing over 97 lakh voters.

Under fire over problems during the Special Intensive Review of voter lists, the poll body on Saturday announced several measures, including additional time to file

claims, home visits by election officials, and help desks for those facing notices of removal from the rolls.

After a meeting attended by Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, along with Election Commissioners Dr SS Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, the poll panel announced that Booth Level Officers (BLOs) will now conduct home visits to collect and upload documents on its unified portal, ECINet, for unmapped persons or those with logical discrepancies.

In-person hearings at ERO/AERO (Electoral Registration Officers/Assistant Electoral Registration Officers) offices are no longer required unless circumstances are exceptional; these will preferably take place online. Authorised family members can also attend on the elector's behalf, the EC said.

It also said it is strengthening facilities for the online hearing. It also directed District Election Officers (DECOs) to set up an adequate number of help desks/hold special camps for people living in night shelters, labourers, poor people, people experiencing homelessness, etc., as required.

The ECI said it has already made various portal upgrades based on inputs from State CEOs over the past few months. If field officers require further flexibility, it will be

made operational, it added.

Notices have been issued to 33.13 lakh voters over "discrepancies" in the details furnished in their enumeration forms, with many cases involving data that could not be matched with the electoral roll prepared during the previous SIR in 2002.

Several prominent voters, including former deputy prime minister L K Advani, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Election Commissioner SS Sandhu, former vice-president Jagdeep Dhankhar and ex-Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, had also received notices from the poll body.

However, officials said they validated most details through field verification and reserved their names for inclusion in the final roll.

Earlier, the Delhi CEO's office reiterated that issuing a notice doesn't mean an elector's name will be deleted from the electoral roll.

Voters who receive notices can submit their replies and requisite supporting documents before the concerned electoral registration officer or booth-level officer, it said.

Poll officials have maintained that no name can be deleted without following due process, including hearing the concerned elector and passing a proper, speaking, and appealable order.

DDA commences Rang Ras Rooh festival at Baansera to mark World Tourism Day



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on Saturday commenced its two-day 'Rang Ras Rooh' festival at Baansera to mark World Tourism Day. The festival witnessed enthusiastic participation from visitors, bringing together regional cuisines, traditional crafts, music, cultural performances and family-oriented activities.

The festival's culinary zone, 'Bharat Ke Zaayake', emerged as a major attraction, showcasing traditional dishes and culinary specialities from around 12 states across India. Families and visitors were seen exploring the diverse flavours and regional cuisines on offer.

At 'Hunar Gali', visitors got an opportunity to experience traditional crafts first-hand through interactive activities. People of different age groups showed keen interest in trying their hand at making clay articles and creating lac bangles, engaging directly with traditional art and craft practices.

The stage remained lively with a series of cultural per-

formances. Singer Anil Bhatt's energetic performance received an enthusiastic response, with audiences seen dancing to his songs. Folk dance performances and magic shows also kept visitors engaged and added to the festive atmosphere.

Children and families enjoyed a wide range of attractions, including camel rides, a toy train, games, rides and other recreational activities. The activities drew enthusiastic participation from young visitors and added to the family-friendly character of the festival. In a statement, the Authority said the day one concluded on a melodious note with a Sufi and Ghazal evening, which added a soulful touch to the celebrations. The musical evening received an enthusiastic response from visitors, bringing the first day of the festival to a fitting close.

"The celebrations will continue on Sunday, with more activities and cultural programmes. The second day will culminate in a live qawwali performance by the Nizami Brothers from 7 PM onwards. Tickets for the musical evening are available on BookMyShow," it said.



expired and are included in the re-tendering process, while renewal or re-tendering procedures remain stalled

money deposits and advance security amounts totalling nearly ₹109 crore, the civic body faces persistent non-payment issues from contractors, triggering default notices, security forfeitures and contract cancellations, it revealed in its answer.

The revelation comes alongside an ongoing overhaul of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi's (MCD) parking infrastructure. Of the 374 currently operational parking sites across various zones, including Civil Lines, Rohini, Karol Bagh and City-SP Zone, 25 contracts have

MCD parking dues cross ₹80 cr amid overhaul of 400-plus sites

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has accumulated over ₹80 crore in unpaid licence fees and contract dues from parking operators over the last three years, official documents showed.

The figures were disclosed in response to a short notice question raised by BJP councillor and Standing Committee member Hem Chand Goel during the committee's meeting at the Civic Centre on Thursday.

Despite holding earnest

at various stages for 155 sites, the civic body stated.

Data submitted by the municipal corporation details revenue collection across 433 surface parking sites and 30 multi-level or mechanical parking facilities, 463 in total, over the last three financial years.

In terms of fiscal performance, parking revenue stood at ₹179.45 crore in 2023-24, ₹186.05 crore in 2024-25 and ₹137.17 crore in 2025-26, while total revenue collected was ₹253.93 crore, ₹275.74 crore and ₹265.58 crore, respectively.



West Bengal makes Vande Mataram must in madrasas: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Saturday said his government has made singing of 'Vande Mataram' mandatory in registered madrasas.

Adhikari, while attending a programme at the National Library here, accused the previous Mamata Banerjee government of allowing infiltrators into the state and changing its demography.

"Rest assured... With a nationalist government that gives primacy to retaining the 'Sanatani' tradition at the helm, the state's borders will be secured and every infiltrator will be pushed back," he said. "Our government has made the singing of the national song 'Vande Mataram' mandatory in state schools and registered madrasas," he said.

He alleged that the previous TMC Government did not allow the BJP and other Hindutva organisations to celebrate December 6 as 'Shaurya Diwas' to mark the demolition of Babri Masjid in Ayodhya in 1992. "The day the nation was celebrating the consecration of Ram Temple



in Ayodhya in January 2024, the then CM was using the entire government machinery to hold a rally against the temple," he added.

Adhikari alleged that *Sanatanis* faced attacks under the Left and TMC regimes. "We have to save *Sanatan Dharma* as the people of West Bengal have chosen to prevent the state from becoming West Bangladesh," he said.

Adhikari praised Hindutva ideologue Syama Prasad Mookerjee for being instrumental in creating a "Hindu

homeland of West Bengal" during the Partition of India. "Otherwise, our ancestors would have faced serious consequences... Partition pangs still rankle the minds of Hindu Bengalis," he said.

Adhikari said the BJP-led government was committed to protect cows and enforced legislations in this regard.

He pledged to protect and uphold the glory of 'saffron', saying, "A section of media had wrongly described a demonstration as 'saffron tandav', which is not acceptable. You could

have called the agitation by political groups but don't dare point fingers at saffron. That is sacrilegious." The CM said his government was changing the names of roads to personalities associated with the nation's heritage and spiritual past and a committee has been formed in this regard.

"Occasions like Durga Puja should retain our Sanatani values, rituals and tradition... No puja will be inaugurated on 'Pitri Paksha', as was practiced during the TMC rule," he said. He said ₹2,000 crore has been allocated for setting up a pilgrimage circuit from Tarapith to Tarakeswar to promote religious tourism.

Adhikari also promised to create more job opportunities and develop the state.

He also paid respects to RSS national general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale, who was the keynote speaker of the programme. "He has worked for fostering nationalist spirit, devoted his life to nation-building, and remains a well-wisher of West Bengal," Adhikari said, while describing RSS as the world's largest social organisation upholding Hindutva values.

Ex-trust officials named as witnesses in Ram Mandir donation row chargesheet

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Lucknow/Ayodhya

A chargesheet filed in the Anti-Corruption Court in Ayodhya has named eight people accused of diverting cash offerings at the Ram Mandir, Ayodhya. It also lists former senior members of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust as prosecution witnesses. Champat Rai, the Trust's former general secretary, and Anil Kumar Mishra, a former trustee, are among the 133 witnesses listed. Both faced strong public and political scrutiny when the first allegations about mishandling donations appeared.

The chargesheet lists eight accused: Avinash Shukla (also known as Shani), Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav, Karunesh Pandey, Ramashankar Mishra, Subhash Srivastava, and Ramashankar Yadav (also known as Tinnu).

All are in judicial custody. Investigators say pilgrims took or hid some of the donated cash during counting inside the temple, before it was sent to the bank. The chargesheet notes 105 such incidents, all



recorded by CCTV cameras in the counting area.

Police have recovered about ₹79.85 lakh from seven of the eight accused. Investigators say they found no cash with Srivastava, who supervised the counting. The investigation also includes thousands of text messages, banking records, property documents, and a forensic audit. Several accused were repeatedly seen on camera removing notes or assisting others. Avinash Shukla is alleged to have been involved in most of the incidents. The police registered the case in late June after a Special Investigation Team (SIT) preliminary inquiry flagged suspected irregularities and Krishna Mohan. A Trust functionary and later its interim general secretary filed a complaint. Rai

and Mishra resigned shortly afterwards. Both were questioned about staff roles, donation-collection arrangements and internal controls. The chargesheet does not list them as accused. Their statements, along with those of Gopal M Nagarkatte (also known as Gopal Rao), a former special invitee to the Trust, explain how offerings were collected, counted, and deposited, and how the alleged problems were discovered.

Investigators say they found no evidence of theft after the counted cash left the temple for deposit at the bank. They also found no problems with the records of over 800 valuable donated items. The chargesheet says the alleged theft happened only in the counting centre. Earlier investigations found

procedural problems, such as incomplete frisking of staff, keeping CCTV footage for too short a time, and unauthorised possession of donation box keys. Tinnu Yadav, one of the accused, had worked as Rai's driver and is said to have had informal influence over internal arrangements.

Several other accused were connected through family or work relations to the counting operation, which used outsourced staff linked to the bank process for temple offerings. The State Government started the first inquiry after the Trust requested it.

The court monitored supervision and filed the voluminous chargesheet, running to tens of thousands of pages, including annexures and case diaries. Listing Rai and Mishra as witnesses rather than accused marks a significant turn in a matter that generated widespread controversy when the allegations first emerged.

Meanwhile, Ram Mandir operations continue under new administrative arrangements as the Ayodhya trial court will hear the criminal case.

Bonsai exhibition with 100 plants begins at Lodhi Garden

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A bonsai exhibition featuring around 100 plants, including several specimens nurtured for decades, was inaugurated at Lodhi Garden on Saturday in collaboration with the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC).

According to the statement, NDMC Chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi inaugurated the exhibition at the National



Bonsai Park in the presence of Japan Foundation Director

Koji Sato, Head of Public and Cultural Affairs Kakashi Kobayashi, senior NDMC officials, members of the Indian Bonsai Association and enthusiasts. The exhibition showcases flowering, fruiting and other varieties of bonsai, with some specimens aged between 20 and 50 years. The collection highlights the patience and care involved in cultivating bonsai as both a horticultural practice and an art form, officials said.

EC statement exposes Congress manufactured lie on SIR: Nabin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

After the Election Commission on Saturday issued a statement on SIR, BJP president Nitin Nabin alleged that the Congress tried to build its allegations around a "manufactured lie" to attack the poll panel.

"The opposition has once again been exposed for misleading the public on SIR," Nabin said in a post on X. The BJP chief's remarks came after the Election Commission (EC) on Saturday asserted that all orders related to Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls were issued after approval from all three election commissioners, and the changes in



Form 6, through which names are included in the voters' list, have been upheld by the Supreme Court. Amid the ongoing row over "differ-

ences" between two election commissioners and Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, the EC said in the statement that letters sent by the two commissioners — Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi — to the Cabinet secretary were not related to any policy matter of the Commission or its IT division, but to the working of an officer on deputation to the poll panel.

"The Election Commission has made it clear that every decision relating to the SIR was taken unanimously by the full Commission. Yet, the Congress chose to build its allegations around a manufactured lie and attack our constitutional

bodies," the BJP chief alleged. Nabin said the "hypocrisy" of the Congress and its allies is evident as when the same electoral process delivers victories for them in states like Kerala and Tamil Nadu, its credibility is readily accepted.

"But when people's mandate goes against them elsewhere, they question the very institutions that conduct those elections," he said, adding: "Democracy cannot be respected selectively." Nabin also said that wins and losses are inherent parts of a democracy, but resorting to "malicious propaganda" to discredit respected constitutional institutions is "deeply unfortunate".

FROM PAGE - 1

EC rejects reports of internal rift

The work re-distribution orders issued by the officer concerned were not implemented after the orders of the two Commissioners, and the Deputy Election Commissioner (DEC) never withdrew oversight of the IT division, the EC said in the statement, issued with the approval of the full Commission.

"In recent months, the Commission has taken numerous decisions, including on SIR across the country. The order for the SIR, issued on June 24, 2025, for all States/UTs, starting with Bihar, followed by West Bengal and 30 other States/UTs, was issued with the unanimous approval of the Commission. The Hon'ble Supreme Court of India upheld the same vide its order dated May 27, 2026. The Commission issued the schedule for SIR for 12 States and UTs on October 27, 2025, and for 19 States/UTs on May 14, 2026, with unanimous approval. The final figure for the number of electors will be known only after the final publication in the remaining 12 States of Phase III," the poll body said in a statement.

At a meeting held on Saturday, the Commission decided that voters who receive notices during the ongoing SIR over being unmapped or having logical discrepancies will not ordinarily have to appear before the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO).

Booth-level officers (BLOs) will visit their homes to collect documents and upload them to ECINet for the ERO to decide. Hearings will be held only in exceptional cases, preferably online. An adult family member can also attend a hearing on behalf of the elector if authorised. The Commission said it would strengthen facilities for online hearings. The Commission also directed district election officers to set up help desks and special camps for people living in night shelters, labourers, poor people and homeless persons, depending on local requirements.

The EC said SIR has been completed in 20 states and Union Territories, including Bihar and West Bengal. It said voters whose names were left out during or after the exercise, as well as young and first-time voters, can apply to the concerned ERO for inclusion through continuous updation. Chief Electoral Officers (CEOs), DEOs and EROs have been directed to launch a special enrolment drive. On ECINET, concerns were raised over access to the electoral-roll database and the functioning of the portal. The poll body said the work redistribution orders issued by the officer were not implemented following directions from two Commissioners, and that oversight of the IT division by the Deputy Election Commissioner was never withdrawn.

The EC said field officers have role-based access to the ECINet system based on their statutory powers. A committee headed by a senior Deputy Election Commissioner and including an independent IT/IIIT expert will review the system for compliance with relevant laws and rules. The Commission also said future initiatives involving IT modules and portals would be discussed by the Committee of Officers before being placed for approval.

The Commission extended the deadline for

filing claims and objections in Delhi till October 30, following a request from the Delhi CEO. The deadline for disposal of notices, claims, and objections has been extended till November 30.

SIR controversy sparks fresh BJP-Opposition...

The Opposition said their demand for removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar remained central to its campaign against the Election Commission.

Commenting on the matter, senior BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad said, "Based on a media report which was factually wrong, the opposition, especially Rahul Gandhi, was levelling baseless and shameless allegations."

"The EC's statement has exposed the Congress and Rahul Gandhi," he said. Prasad also took on the other opposition parties, saying they should work hard to win elections, instead of levelling baseless allegations against the poll authority.

NDA partner Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu said the "unanimous clarification" issued by the Election Commission on the SIR issue reaffirmed the integrity and credibility of the country's constitutional institutions and put to rest all the misconceptions surrounding it. In a post on X, Naidu, whose TDP is one of the key constituents of the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA), said the decisions concerning the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls are taken "collectively" and in strict adherence to established institutional protocols. "Attempts to undermine global confidence in India's democratic framework or electoral processes for short-term political gains are deeply unfortunate," the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) president said in a veiled attack against the Congress and its allies.

"Electoral outcomes reflect the people's mandate. In a robust democracy, leadership also means accepting both victories and defeats with grace and humility," Naidu said, adding, "Respect for our constitutional institutions is paramount. It is the collective responsibility of leaders across party lines to uphold public confidence in India's democratic process."

Congress general secretary (communications) and Rajya Sabha MP Jairam Ramesh on Saturday launched a fresh attack on the Election Commission of India (ECI) over its handling of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, alleging that the poll panel's latest press note had failed to directly rebut the findings of recent media reports and demanding the immediate suspension of the exercise as well as the resignation or prosecution of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Trinamool Congress national joint secretary Derek O'Brien on Saturday said the opposition's demand to remove Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar remained central to its campaign against the Election Commission. Other demands, including changes in the CEC selection process and opposition to the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, were also firmly in place, he said.

The remarks came after the Election

Commission (EC) on Saturday asserted that all orders related to Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls were issued after approval from all three election commissioners, and the changes in Form 6, through which names are included in the voters' list, have been upheld by the Supreme Court. Amid the ongoing row over "differences" between two election commissioners and Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, the EC said in a statement that the letters sent by the two commissioners - Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi - to the Cabinet secretary were not related to any policy matter of the Commission or its IT division, but to the working of an officer on deputation to the poll panel.

Terror sponsors cannot escape consequences...

Jaishankar said terrorism remains a persistent threat to international peace and security, particularly when states allegedly facilitate attacks across borders. "When a state sponsors it to carry out attacks across borders, it becomes a direct affront to the global order," he said.

He called on the international community to hold governments involved in cross-border terrorism accountable. "Governments that engage in cross-border terrorism must be called out," Jaishankar said. His remarks came amid continuing tensions between India and Pakistan and New Delhi's longstanding allegations that Pakistan-based terrorist groups have targeted India. Pakistan has rejected India's accusations and has made counter-allegations against New Delhi. Jaishankar also had a brief but pointed exchange with a Pakistani journalist during a media interaction on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly.

After the journalist questioned India over alleged sponsorship of terrorism in Pakistan and asked when New Delhi would stop such activities, Jaishankar responded: "A terrorist country is asking me that question. Come on."

The exchange came after Jaishankar and Liberian Foreign Minister Sara Beysolow Nyanti spoke to reporters following discussions on the safety and security of shipping and seafarers. The exchange was subsequently reported by Indian media. Beyond terrorism, Jaishankar used his UNGA address to discuss wider global security concerns. Referring to the ongoing conflict in Ukraine, he said the war, now in its fifth year, remains a matter of concern.

"Endless war must give way now to an end to war," he said, referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's position. Jaishankar said India supports ongoing efforts to bring about peace, while highlighting the need to protect seafarers and ensure uninterrupted supplies of food, grain and energy. He also stressed that peace should not be understood merely as the absence of armed conflict.

"Peace is not just the absence of war," Jaishankar said, warning that continuous threats and pressure can leave the international system "on the edge of an abyss." He argued that greater stability, security and predictability are essential for creating conditions conducive to lasting peace. The safety of commer-

cial shipping and seafarers was another major theme of Jaishankar's engagements at the UN. Addressing the issue of conflict in the Gulf, he said attacks on commercial shipping were unacceptable and called on all sides to exercise restraint and protect civilians and seafarers. "There can be no justification for such violence and loss of life. Put simply, these attacks must stop," Jaishankar said.

India, one of the world's major sources of seafarers, has joined Liberia, which has the world's largest shipping registry by tonnage, in bringing together countries concerned about maritime security and major ship-owning nations.

Jaishankar's interventions at the UN therefore combined India's concerns over terrorism and cross-border violence with broader calls for international stability, maritime security and an end to ongoing conflicts.

Jaishankar ended his speech at UNGA81 with a Mahatma Gandhi quote: "There's no way to peace; peace is the way."

India lashes out at Pak over terrorism...

India reminded the UN General Assembly that Sharif's "bizarre remarks" came just a fortnight after New York City and the world marked the 25th anniversary of the horrendous 9/11 terrorist attack. "This context...is important to keep in mind because its mastermind, Osama Bin Laden, was living right on the doorstep of the Pakistani Army's premier academy," Gahlot said.

Slamming Sharif for raising the Kashmir issue in his address, Gahlot said the Indian Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir is an integral and inalienable part of the country.

"And will always remain so. But if we must talk about Kashmir, let us turn our attention to the Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir. Ask the people of Rawalakot about the wanton killings, the brutal violence and the denial of basic rights that they have long experienced," she added.

The Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) region has been witnessing protests for several months over 12 contentious refugee seats, triggering a crackdown by security forces and allegations of rigging in the recently held elections to the so-called legislative assembly. (PTI)

Gold double: India's men and women rule Asiad...

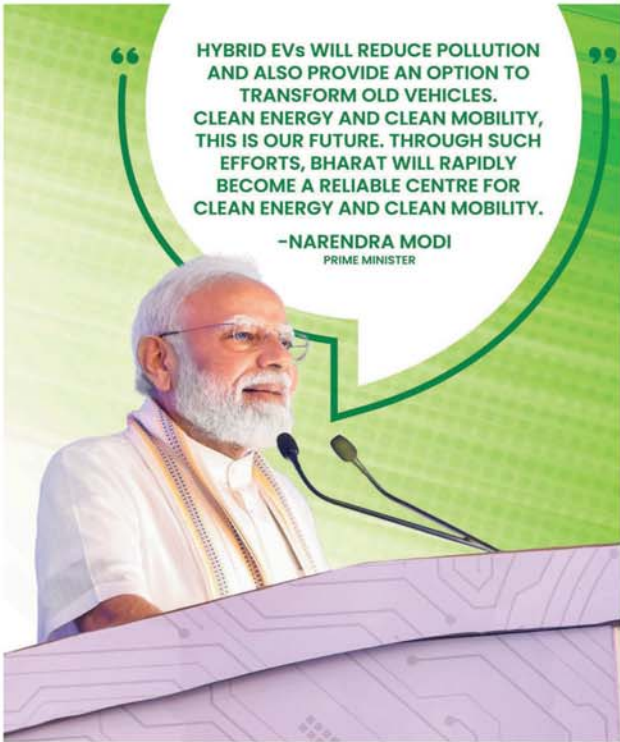
Women clinch it in tense finish

The women also held their nerve in a slightly more tense finish to clinch a record-extending fourth gold. India had already beaten Iran in the group stage and, in that encounter, also identified a weakness they would return to when the stakes were much higher-the left flank.

Raiders Nikita, captain Pooja and Sanju Devi repeatedly attacked from that side, and the strategy paid dividends. The tall, athletic Iranians had the technique and the physical presence to trouble India. Still, their lack of experience at this level showed when India consistently found openings on the left. India began briskly, moving 3-1 ahead and reducing Iran to three players. But the Iranians refused to be overwhelmed. (PTI)

EVs drive against pollution: Incentives, infrastructure & innovation for a future-ready Delhi

Under the guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Delhi is powering ahead towards a cleaner, smarter, and future-ready EV ecosystem



“HYBRID EVs WILL REDUCE POLLUTION AND ALSO PROVIDE AN OPTION TO TRANSFORM OLD VEHICLES. CLEAN ENERGY AND CLEAN MOBILITY, THIS IS OUR FUTURE. THROUGH SUCH EFFORTS, BHARAT WILL RAPIDLY BECOME A RELIABLE CENTRE FOR CLEAN ENERGY AND CLEAN MOBILITY.”

—NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER

Electric mobility in Delhi is no longer limited to simply switching vehicles. Through the Delhi EV Policy 2026, the capital is building a comprehensive EV ecosystem that brings together EV purchases, scrapping of old vehicles, charging infrastructure, battery management, digital services and the electrification of public transport.

Aligned with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision for clean, sustainable and future-ready mobility, and under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the Delhi Government is working to make clean transportation more accessible and convenient for citizens. The new policy came into effect on 1 July 2026 and will remain in force until 31 March 2030.

FROM PRIVATE VEHICLES TO PUBLIC TRANSPORT — THE WHOLE SYSTEM GOES ELECTRIC

Delhi's clean mobility journey is not limited to private vehicles.

The electrification of public transport is also a major focus of the Delhi Government. The Government has set a target of 14,000 electric buses by FY 2028–29. The objective is not merely to increase the number of electric vehicles on Delhi's roads, but to build a cleaner, modern and sustainable public transport system for the capital. At present, the DTC's total bus fleet has reached approximately 6,840 buses, of which more than 5,000 are electric buses.

The objective is not merely to increase the number of electric vehicles on Delhi's roads. It is to transform the city's entire public transport system into one that is cleaner, more modern and more sustainable. This transformation is not limited to increasing the number of buses. Alongside the induction of new electric buses, greater attention is also being given to passenger safety and convenience.

Buses equipped with CCTV cameras, panic buttons and other modern features are helping move public transportation towards a safer and more technology-enabled future. Delhi's electric

mobility ecosystem is also expanding beyond the Capital's boundaries. To ensure that electric mobility is not confined to journeys within Delhi, interstate e-bus connectivity is being expanded. An interstate electric bus service has recently been introduced between Delhi and Karnal, while a zero-emission e-bus service between Delhi and Rewari has also been launched.

These initiatives are aimed at strengthening clean public transport connectivity between Delhi and neighbouring cities. In this way, the EV ecosystem is expanding from

intra-city mobility to regional connectivity, creating a wider network of clean transportation.

SAFE AND CONVENIENT ELECTRIC MOBILITY FOR WOMEN

Women's convenience and safety are also being integrated into Delhi's expanding electric public transport network.

In August 2026, ladies-special e-bus services were launched. These include special services for women passengers on high-demand routes, along with University Ladies Special services



SWITCH TO ELECTRIC & SAVE MORE

To accelerate Delhi's electric mobility journey, the new policy provides for more than ₹7,000 crore of government investment over the next four years. The objective is to strengthen both demand for electric vehicles and the infrastructure required to support their widespread adoption.

The new EV Policy offers a range of financial incentives to make electric vehicles more accessible to citizens

Up to ₹30,000 on an Electric Two-Wheeler

Up to ₹50,000 on an Electric Three-Wheeler

Up to ₹1 lakh on an N-1 Electric Truck

The policy also provides incentives for scrapping old polluting vehicles:

Two-Wheeler Up to ₹10,000

Three-Wheeler Up to ₹25,000

Four-Wheeler Up to ₹1 lakh

N-1 Truck Up to ₹50,000

Gramin Sewa Up to ₹15,000

The message is clear—**scrap the old polluting vehicle, switch to electric and move towards cleaner mobility**

Eligible electric vehicles will also receive **100% exemption from Road Tax and Registration Fee**. For electric cars, this benefit applies to vehicles priced up to ₹30 lakh ex-showroom



POWERING THE EV, MANAGING THE FULL LIFECYCLE

The new policy takes a comprehensive view of the EV lifecycle. It includes provisions for battery traceability, collection centres, Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR), battery recycling and battery management.

From scrapping old polluting vehicles to adopting new electric vehicles and responsibly managing their batteries, the policy focuses on building a complete and integrated clean mobility ecosystem.



A STRONG INSTITUTIONAL FRAMEWORK

For effective implementation of the EV Policy, dedicated institutional mechanisms including an EV Cell, Project Management Consultant, Model Approval Committee, High-Powered Committee and Delhi EV Apex Committee have been established. The Model Approval Committee will assess and approve EV models for eligibility and incentives based on prescribed technical

standards. The High-Powered and Apex Committees will strengthen policy implementation, inter-departmental coordination and regular monitoring.

The financial framework for the policy has also been broadened. PM E-DRIVE, Central Government schemes, Delhi Government budgetary provisions and the ECC Fund, among other sources, have been linked to the policy.

ONE POLICY, ECOSYSTEM, ELECTRIC FUTURE

₹7,000+ CRORE
Government investment

UP TO ₹30,000
Two-Wheeler Incentive

UP TO ₹50,000
Three-Wheeler Incentive

UP TO ₹1 LAKH
N-1 Incentive

30,000+
Charging Points by 2030

14,000
Electric Buses by FY 2028–29

BEYOND INCENTIVES- A ROADMAP FOR DELHI'S ELECTRIC FUTURE

The Delhi EV Policy 2026 goes beyond incentives and lays down a clear roadmap for phased electrification. From 1 January 2027, registration of new L-5 auto-rickshaws and N-1 goods vehicles will be restricted to electric vehicles.

From 1 April 2028, registration of new two-wheelers will be restricted to electric vehicles. Vehicles already registered will continue to operate until the end of their prescribed validity. The policy also provides for a 'No Entry' exemption for the first 1,000 electric N-2 goods vehicles registered during the first three months of implementation of the policy. School transport has also been brought into this transition, with a target of making 30% of the school bus fleet electric by 2030.



Through the Delhi EV Policy 2026, the capital is moving towards an integrated future of clean mobility, digital services and sustainable transportation

DELHI IS MOVING TOWARDS FUTURE-READY MOBILITY. CLEAN JOURNEYS. SMART SYSTEMS. AN ELECTRIC FUTURE.

NO QUEUES, NO PAPER CHASE, JUST DIGITAL CONVENIENCE

An important feature of the EV Policy is its focus on easy and transparent service delivery.

Through the Delhi EV Subsidy Portal, eligible citizens can apply online from home within 30 days of purchasing the vehicle and receiving the Registration Certificate (RC). Essential documents such as Aadhaar, RC and Voter ID can be uploaded online. Institutions can also upload their GSTIN, PAN and bank account details. With digital document verification, real-time application tracking and a paperless process, approved subsidies will be transferred directly to the beneficiary's bank account through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT).

Following verification of the required documents, the Government aims to release the incentive amount within a maximum of 60 days as per the prescribed process.

"No long queues. No unnecessary running around. Just digital delivery and direct benefit."



A DIRECT FOCUS ON POLLUTION CONTROL

According to the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) report, vehicular emissions contribute around 23% of Delhi's air pollution, particularly during winter. Nearly 67% of Delhi's total vehicles are two-wheelers. This is why the new policy places priority on the electrification of two-wheelers, three-wheelers, commercial cars and goods vehicles.

Automated Testing Stations: Technology and Transparency in Vehicle Testing

Delhi is also expanding its network of Automated Testing Stations to strengthen the city's safe and clean transport system. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated Delhi's advanced Automated Testing Stations at the DTC's Nand Nagari and Tehkhand depots.

The facilities feature separate lanes for heavy motor vehicles, light motor vehicles and two-wheelers. These facilities are capable of conducting fitness tests for more than 72,000 vehicles annually.

The entire testing process will be technology-driven and automated, reducing human intervention while enhancing transparency, accuracy and consistency.

The testing process will cover critical parameters including:

- Braking performance
- Suspension
- Headlight alignment
- Side-slip
- Emission levels
- Inspection of the vehicle's underbody

By bringing technology into vehicle fitness testing, Delhi is strengthening both road safety and transparency in the transport system.



30,000+ CHARGING POINTS — BECAUSE EVS NEED INFRASTRUCTURE TOO

A strong charging network is essential for faster EV adoption. Keeping this in focus, Delhi has set a target of developing more than 30,000 public EV charging points by 2030. A single-window system, digital monitoring and a dedicated institutional framework are being developed to expand charging infrastructure and ensure convenient and reliable charging facilities for EV users across the capital.

The aim is to ensure that EV users across the Capital have access to convenient, reliable and hassle-free charging facilities. At present, consumers can use an online process to select chargers and complete the connection and installation process at private and semi-public locations such as markets, malls, hospitals, offices, group housing societies and other parking facilities.

The expansion of the charging network will focus on prioritising fast-charging infrastructure, ensuring adequate power supply and gradually upgrading slower charging stations to fast-charging facilities. At the same time, work is also underway on plans to promote solar-powered charging stations in the future. As part of this larger effort, public EV charging infrastructure is also being expanded at various DTC depots across Delhi. New charging stations have been commissioned at locations including Rajghat, Hasanpur and Ghazipur. The station commissioned at Rajghat Depot-1 features four 240 kW EV chargers. These chargers can serve not only electric buses but also heavy commercial EVs and electric cars.



DELHI'S E-MOBILITY ECOSYSTEM GAINS NATIONAL RECOGNITION

In the NITI Aayog India Electric Mobility Index 2025, Delhi received a score of 84. The index assesses e-mobility progress across various indicators, including transport electrification, EV charging infrastructure, and EV research and innovation.

The assessment places a national spotlight on the various dimensions of Delhi's emerging EV ecosystem.



Nothing short of CEC’s resignation or prosecution will suffice: Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Saturday said the Election Commission of India (ECI) was in “damage control” mode after differences within the poll body came out following a media “expose” and demanded that the ongoing SIR exercise that has “disenfranchised crores” is suspended immediately.

The Congress also said that nothing short of CEC Gyanesh Kumar’s resignation or prosecution will suffice.

The Opposition party’s reaction came after the ECI issued a statement asserting that all Special Intensive Revision (SIR) orders were issued after approval from all three Election Commissioners and the changes in Form 6, through which names are included in the voters’ list, have been upheld by the Supreme Court.

The poll body also claimed that the letters sent by commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi to the Cabinet Secretary were not related to any policy matter of the Commission or



CEC Gyanesh Kumar

its IT division, but to the working of an officer on deputation to it.

Reacting sharply to the ECI statement, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said the poll body is in damage control mode after it has already caused “massive damage” to our democracy.

“It has just issued a wishy-washy Press Note that raises further questions on its intent, integrity, impartiality and credibility,” he said on X.

“The ongoing SIR which has turned to be method of massive disenfranchisement

of several crores of India must be suspended immediately without delay.

“In the meantime, nothing short of the CEC’s resignation or prosecution will suffice,” he said in a two-page statement.

He said in the wake of the expose by the Indian Express and subsequent reporting in other newspapers, and the nationwide protests that have followed seeking the removal of Kumar, the ECI has now come out with a press note.

“First, the Press note does not directly deny the story or

its findings. It makes a defensive attempt to downplay the same in paragraph 3(i) and 3(ii) but does not say that the allegations are baseless.

“Second, in the case of Goa, after having been caught out the ECI has sheepishly stated that Form 6 has already been filled out for inclusion by 81 of the 97 deleted voters. To put this another way, you disenfranchise voters through a broken and corrupt system, and when caught say that they are being added back,” Ramesh said.

He claimed that it seeks to justify the Commission’s actions by appealing to the Order of the Supreme Court of May 27, 2026.

“The Order which was pronounced well before the recent revelations will not save the CEC for the malicious deletion of targeted voters, for the incompetence that has resulted in citizens being wiped off the roles, for the crores lost in both expenses and man-hours due to the confusion and harassment caused to entire families,” he noted.

ECI row brings Mamata, CPI(M) together after 3 decades

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The controversy over Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar has opened an unusual channel between two long-standing West Bengal rivals. Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee and CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby held their first direct one-to-one conversation in three decades this week, even as the INDIA bloc has yet to announce a joint action plan.

The trigger was a 23 September investigative report on an internal rupture within the Election Commission. Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had formally objected at least 14 times over ten months to decisions taken in the Commission’s name. The disputes concerned the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls: voter additions and deletions, restoration of names, changes to Form 6, appeals against roll decisions, and centralisation of the voter database. Some steps were described as unauthorised and illegal. Opposition parties demanded Kumar’s removal, a court-



CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby, Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee



monitored inquiry, and a halt to the revision, arguing that the Commission’s credibility and Indian democracy itself were at risk.

Baby wrote to non-NDA parties the same day, including those outside the INDIA bloc, such as the DMK, TVK, BRS, BJD, and AAP. He called for an urgent meeting to shape a united opposition campaign. Banerjee first sent a written reply and then telephoned him on Friday. She told him she had also spoken to Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi and pressed for an early INDIA meeting. Baby proposed including parties that

keep their distance from both the Congress and the BJP; Banerjee agreed.

The two also discussed taking the issue onto the streets. The call is notable because the TMC and CPI(M) have barely spoken at the top level since Banerjee left the Congress in the late 1990s, formed her own party, and later ended 34 years of Left Front rule in Bengal. They have shared INDIA platforms but avoided personal contact. Consequently, the outreach appears to be a tactical pause driven by institutional considerations, rather than a relaxation of state political tensions. Its poten-

tial to result in a more comprehensive strategy remains uncertain.

Several political groups have already demanded Kumar’s resignation or apprehension and the scheduling of new elections in the State where the revisions occurred. The INDIA bloc itself has issued no joint programme. Efforts are underway to convene a meeting as early as next week. The coming days will show whether the first conversation in three decades becomes the start of a wider realignment or remains an isolated, issue-specific contact.

Harish Rawat appears before ED for questioning in 2016 recruitment case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dehradun

Former Uttarakhand Chief Minister and senior Congress leader Harish Rawat arrived at the Enforcement Directorate’s (ED) Dehradun office on Saturday for questioning in a 2016 case involving alleged irregularities in a recruitment exam.

Rawat wore a photograph of his mother around his neck as he entered the office. Before the questioning, he shared a video stating that he had received an ED notice two days earlier summoning him for questioning.

The case pertains to alleged irregularities in the 2016 Village Panchayat Development Officer (VPDO) recruitment examination conducted by the Uttarakhand Subordinate Services Selection Commission (UKSSSC).

In connection with the matter, the ED conducted searches at several locations in Dehradun on September 10, including the residence of



Chandan Singh Jeena, Rawat’s current personal assistant, who also served as his Officer on Special Duty (OSD) during his tenure as chief minister.

In his video, Rawat noted that the ED had requested a large number of documents from him. Specifically, the agency sought information regarding his past Income Tax Returns (ITR) and details about his assets and those of his family members.

Rawat mentioned that the notice also requested documents related to his family, although he was uncertain

about which members were specifically included under the definition of ‘family’. He pointed out that he has a large family, and his daughters are married, making it difficult to gather old documents for every member.

The former chief minister added that he had not informed anyone beforehand about his visit to the ED. On September 12, Rawat announced his decision to step down from all party posts after the Enforcement Directorate recovered cash and jewellery from his personal assistant’s house.

Enforce noise laws strictly, MP HC tells authorities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

The Madhya Pradesh High Court has directed State authorities to strictly enforce laws regulating noise pollution, observing that the situation on the ground appeared markedly different from the measures claimed in the Government’s response.

A Division Bench of Justices Subodh Abhyankar and Jai Kumar Pillai passed the directions on September 24 while hearing a public interest litigation concerning excessive noise from loudspeakers, DJs, processions, religious programmes, marriages and other public events in Indore. The petition, filed in 2023, raised concerns over the impact of unchecked noise on citizens’ right to life and peaceful sleep.

During the hearing, the Bench noted that it had itself encountered loud noise at several locations while travelling from the court to the judges’ residences. The court also took note of a newspaper report concerning the



death of a seven-year-old schoolchild allegedly linked to high-volume sound from loudspeakers used during a procession.

The Bench observed that despite a detailed response from the authorities outlining measures purportedly taken to control noise pollution, the actual situation appeared grim. It consequently decided to continue monitoring compliance rather than close the proceedings.

The court directed police and administrative authorities to ensure effective implementation of the

publicise dedicated contact and helpline numbers so that residents can report violations and seek timely intervention.

The Bench also sought a fresh compliance report from the State within one week. The matter has been listed for further hearing on October 5, 2026.

The PIL had highlighted the alleged widespread use of loudspeakers and high-volume sound systems at public events and other gatherings. The petitioners argued that prolonged exposure to excessive noise can affect citizens’ health and interfere with their right to peaceful living.

The court’s latest directions place the focus on implementation and accountability, requiring authorities to demonstrate that existing statutory safeguards are being enforced effectively on the ground.

Advocate Abhinav Dhanodkar appeared for the petitioners. Government Advocate Pradyumna Kibe and advocate Rishabh Singh Chouhan represented the respondents.

Palaniswami targets CM Vijay over horse-trading

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami on Saturday accused the ruling TVK of “inducing” opposition legislators to defect through horse-trading, labeling its by-election candidate Maragatham Kumaravel a “traitor” for betraying both AIADMK and the voters.

Targeting Chief Minister and Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam founder C Joseph Vijay for encouraging defections while branding his party a “pure force”, Palaniswami claimed that the CM was merely “acting” in real life just as he did in films. He claimed that the by-election was “thrust” on the people by the TVK.



Nandigram bypoll: Hasirani Rath seeks bigger margin, CM Suwendu to campaign

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

BJP candidate Hasirani Rath on Saturday said her objective in the October 6 Nandigram bypoll was not just to win the seat but to increase the party’s victory margin, as she announced that West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari would address two rallies in the constituency on October 2 and 4.

Campaigning amid rain, Rath moved through villages in Nandigram’s Block II, travelling by toto and making door-to-door visits in Shibrampur, Hanubhuinya and Kalibari areas. She also offered prayers at several temples as part of her campaign. “Nandigram is Adhikari’s land. He is the last word here. I will represent him. He is everything,” Rath told reporters during the campaign.



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari along with BJP candidate Hasirani Rath during a rally for the filing of nomination for Nandigram Assembly constituency ahead of by-elections at Purba Midnapore, West Bengal

She said Adhikari, who vacated the Nandigram seat after retaining Bhabanipur in south Kolkata, would campaign for her at two public meetings on October 2 and 4, the latter being the last day of campaigning for the bypoll.

The BJP has projected the contest as a test of its organisational strength in a constituency that has acquired

a strong association with Adhikari since his defeat of TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee there in the 2021 Assembly election.

Rath, the mother of slain Adhikari aide Chandranath Rath, has been fielded by the BJP in an attempt to give the contest an emotive dimension.

The candidate had, from the outset, sought to frame

the election less as a conventional contest and more as a referendum on Adhikari’s political hold over Nandigram.

“The opposition is busy fighting for its existence. They have no ground and nowhere to campaign. They are fighting to save their deposits. We are fighting to see how much we can increase our margin,” Rath had said during her initial campaign.

The BJP has already set an ambitious target for the constituency, with Rath earlier saying the party hoped to secure 1.10 lakh votes.

Nandigram’s October 6 Assembly bypoll took a dramatic turn last week as Mamata Banerjee’s candidate Sanchita Pradhan Dey withdrew from the race hours after meeting Adhikari, prompting Banerjee to back Congress nominee Milan Pradhan, who was arrested

later in an old murder case.

The rapid-fire developments unfolded on a day when the Election Commission allotted new names and symbols to the two rival TMC factions after freezing the party’s traditional name and “flower and grass” symbol.

Pradhan Dey, who had briefly lost her job during a major teacher recruitment scam, met Adhikari at the state secretariat Nabanna along with her husband Satyajit before withdrawing her nomination, a day ahead of the deadline.

Her withdrawal left the Mamata camp without a candidate in Nandigram even as the faction was allotted the name Mamata All India Trinamool Congress and the Football Player symbol for the bypolls. The rival faction was allotted Democratic Trinamool Congress and the Envelope symbol.

BJP, JD(S) to jointly contest 4 Karnataka Council seats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The BJP and JD(S) have decided to jointly contest the upcoming elections to four Karnataka Legislative Council seats from teachers’ and graduates’ constituencies, State BJP president BY Vijayendra said on Saturday.

He said the two parties also discussed effectively countering the Congress Government together and bringing an NDA Government to power in Karnataka.

Vijayendra was speaking to reporters here after a meeting



Representational image



between BJP and JD(S) leaders. He said a special meeting was convened to discuss the strategy for the Legislative Council elections.

Union Ministers Pralhad Joshi, HD Kumaraswamy, Shibha Karandlaje, Leaders of

Opposition in both legislative Assembly and Council R Ashoka and Chalavadi Narayanaswamy, along with senior leaders, district presidents and other key functionaries of both parties, attended the meeting.

“It has been decided that the BJP and JD(S) should contest the elections together in all four constituencies. We have to win all four seats and work together towards that goal,” Vijayendra said.

He added that the responsibilities have been assigned to party leaders for each constituency.

Vijayendra alleged that Congress legislators themselves were losing faith in Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and claimed that the CM was unable to exercise control over the administration.

ECI revises SIR schedule in Maharashtra, deadline for filing objections, claims extended to October 12

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Saturday announced a revised schedule for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll in Maharashtra, extending the period for filing claims and objections to October 12.

It also extended the period for disposal of notices and claims and objections to November 10,



and fixed November 16, 2026, as the date for final publication.

Earlier, the last date for filing claims and objections was September 30, 2026, and the date for final publication was November 4, 2026.

According to a directive issued by the Election Commission of India to the Chief Electoral Officer of Maharashtra, the qualifying date for the electoral roll remains October 1, 2026.

Shah launches She-Mart shops

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kollam

In line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "Sahkar se Samridhhi", and as an important step towards strengthening the rural economy through cooperation and giving fresh impetus to women-led development, Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Amit Shah on Saturday launched various initiatives related to women empowerment and cooperation at the Pavithram Convention Centre in Kollam, Kerala.

Union Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas and Tourism Suresh Gopi, along with several dignitaries and representatives associated with the cooperative sector, was present on the occasion.

At the outset of his address, Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Amit Shah congratulated and extended his best wishes to all Malayali brothers and sisters on the journey from Kerala to 'Keralam'. He said that during the Amrit Kaal of Independence, farmers and people associated with the cooperative sector had long demanded the creation of a separate Ministry of



Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Amit Shah launches various initiatives related to women empowerment and cooperation in Kollam, Kerala. Union Minister Suresh Gopi, State Ministers M Liju, PC Vishnunadh, MP NK Premachandran are also seen

Cooperation at the Centre. Prime Minister Narendra Modi took a major step towards the country's rural development, agricultural development and women empowerment by establishing the Ministry of Cooperation at the Centre, infusing new energy and momentum into the cooperative sector.

Highlighting Kerala's rich cooperative legacy, Amit Shah said that Keralam is among those states where the cooperative movement has remained strong and well-organised since even before

Independence. Regions such as Travancore, Kochi and Malabar have had a strong tradition of cooperation since the pre-Independence era, making Keralam's cooperative movement an important example for the entire country. He said that the 'She-Mart' initiative being launched today in the cooperative sector was announced by the Union Finance Minister in the Budget, and it is a matter of great satisfaction that the initiative is being launched from Keralam.

Elaborating on the initia-

tives launched to make affordable food products available to the people and farmers, the Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation said that an initiative has also been launched in Kerala to make onions, Bharat Atta and Bharat Rice available to farmers and the general public through NAFED's mobile vans.

He said that under the Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses, urad and gram seeds are being provided to women farmers.

Similarly, under the NAFED-Kalyan Scholarship Scheme, scholarships are being provided to girl children from nearly 2,000 families.

Underscoring the significance of 'She-Mart' for women Self-Help Groups and rural women entrepreneurs, Amit Shah said that the most important aspect of today's programme is the launch of 'She-Mart'.

The concept of She-Mart is an important initiative aimed at directly connecting women Self-Help Groups and rural women entrepreneurs with markets and consumers. He said that institutions such as NAFED, Kendriya Bhandar and Amul will also help women-led enterprises expand on a much larger scale.

Assam boosts industrial footprint with e-methanol project at Kandla

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Strengthening Assam's growing industrial presence at the national level, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma along with Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel and Union Minister for Ports Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal formally laid the foundation stone for a major e-methanol production project at Kandla in Gujarat at Kandla in Gujarat today.

The project is a joint initiative of Assam Petro-Chemicals Limited (APCL) and the Deendayal Port Authority.

With an investment of ₹2,300 crore and a production capacity of 150 tonnes per day (TPD), the project is among the major e-methanol production initiatives in the country. It is expected to create more than 3,500 direct and indirect employment opportunities. To be established at Kandla Port, one of India's major maritime commercial hubs on the western coast, the project is envisaged to promote the use of



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma along with Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal and Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel laying the foundation stone for a major e-methanol production project at Kandla in Gujarat

green fuel in the shipping sector, reduce dependence on imported fossil fuels and contribute to lowering emissions from maritime transport. The project also marks a significant expansion of Assam's industrial footprint beyond the State and reflects the capabilities and growing role of Assam's public sector enterprises in emerging areas of the national green economy.

Speaking on the occasion, Chief Minister Sarma said that the project would contribute significantly to India's efforts to expand the use of

green fuels. He recalled Prime Minister Narendra Modi's commitment to achieving net-zero carbon emissions by 2070, announced at the United Nations Climate Change Conference in Glasgow in 2021.

The Chief Minister said that, in keeping with the Prime Minister's vision, India has witnessed the emergence of a new movement towards green fuels and clean energy. He stated that Gujarat has emerged as a leading State in this transition through initiatives in

solar power, green hydrogen and other forms of clean energy. Sarma said that the Prime Minister's vision of accelerating the adoption of green fuels is gradually being translated into action across the country and that India is making significant strides in the development and adoption of clean energy technologies.

He said that it is heartening that the shipping sector is also being brought within the ambit of this green transition. In this context, the e-methanol project at Kandla assumes particular significance, as the methanol produced through the project is envisaged to be used as a marine fuel for ships operating from the port to international destinations.

Highlighting Assam's historic contribution to India's energy sector, Sarma said that the State has played a pioneering role in the country's oil and petroleum industry. He pointed out that Asia's first mechanically drilled oil well was established at Makum in Assam in 1867, while India's first oil refinery was commissioned at Digboi in 1901.

NTPC, EDF sign pact to develop renewable energy projects in India



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned NTPC and EDF Power Solutions India have joined hands to jointly develop, own and operate pumped storage projects, hydropower projects, as well as other renewable energy (RE) projects and distribution business. This 50:50 JV shall undertake projects within India and neighbouring countries, NTPC said in a statement.

The joint venture (JV) agreement was signed on September 25 in the presence of NTPC Chairman Gurdeep Singh and Bernard Fontana, Chairman and CEO of EDF SA, France. Through this strategic partnership, NTPC and EDF Power Solutions, a fully owned subsidiary of the French electricity company EDF (Electricité de France), are committed to establishing a responsible and innovative industrial company to develop, build and operate low-carbon power plants, as well as flexibility solutions and transmission assets.

EDF and NTPC will leverage their respective expertise to provide tailor-made offers, drive the decarbonisation and global performance of electrical systems, aligned with India's ambitious goals of 100 GW installed capacity of pumped storage projects by 2036.

Considering their expertise and resources, both entities are poised to contribute significantly to India's renewable energy market, driving innovation and fostering environmental stewardship.

IOC flags off first xtreme weather grade diesel consignment for Army's Eastern Command

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOC) has flagged off the maiden rake of its Xtreme Weather Grade high-speed diesel for the Indian Army's Eastern Command, expanding supplies of the specialised fuel beyond the northern frontier, the company said on Saturday.

Xtreme Weather Grade (XWG) high-speed diesel, launched in July 2026 by the Chief of Army Staff, has been developed to meet the Army's requirements in extreme cold and high-altitude conditions.

The fuel is designed to offer enhanced low-temperature performance and reliable operation of military vehicles and equipment in challenging terrain.

Fuel performance at low temperatures is critical for military operations in high-altitude regions, where conventional diesel can face prob-



lems related to cold-weather operability. Specialised grades such as XWG diesel are designed to address these requirements and improve the reliability of vehicles and equipment deployed in extreme climatic conditions.

The rake was flagged off from IOC's Panipat Marketing Complex by Lt Gen Mukesh Chadha, Director General Supplies & Transport and Senior Colonel Commandant at IHQ of the Ministry of Defence (Army), the company said in a statement. The move makes IOC the first public



sector oil company to position XWG diesel in the eastern region, enabling a dedicated supply chain for the Army's requirements in Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh.

With the latest dispatch, IOC's XWG diesel supply footprint now covers both the northern and eastern frontiers. "XWG is a potential game changer for operational preparedness and readiness in high-altitude and extreme-weather areas," said Lt Gen Mukesh Chadha.

He highlighted that for

the first time, this specialised fuel is being extended beyond Ladakh to support operations in Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh.

He emphasised the need for a predictable, scalable and responsive supply chain, with the right fuel at the right place and time. He also acknowledged IOC's partnership in transforming XWG Diesel from an operational requirement into an operational reality in the Eastern side.

K John Prasad, Country Head (Institutional Business), IOC, said, "The Indian Army operates in some of the most demanding terrains and climatic conditions, where dependable fuel performance is critical to operational mobility. Extending XWG HSD supplies to the Eastern Command strengthens our ability to support the Army across another strategically important geography".

India needs to utilise resources beneath earth to become self-sufficient: Anil Agarwal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Vedanta Resources chairman Anil Agarwal on Saturday said resistance to projects is a natural occurrence, and India needs to become self-sufficient by utilising its resources stacked beneath the earth, as other developed countries like the US and Australia.

Agarwal, whose Vedanta Group has already invested ₹1 lakh crore in Odisha and is ready to invest a matching amount for another refinery in Rayagada and a smelter in Dhenkanal district, said this after meeting Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi here.

He also proposed setting up a 1,000-bed hospital in the

western region of the State. The company has its refinery at Lanjigarh in Kalahandi district, a smelter and power plant in Jharsuguda district, which is part of the western region of the State.

Asked about the company facing resistance from the people for undertaking bauxite mining at Sijimali in Rayagada district, Ararwal said, "Resistance is natural. People will oppose, and we have to take it all along to build a developed Odisha and India. Two decades ago, some foreign elements were instigating our innocent people to oppose projects. Now, things are settled. There is no resistance at all."

Batting for large mineral explorations, Agarwal said



Vedanta Chairman Anil Agarwal

that India has become successful in becoming self-sufficient in food by utilising its resources above the earth. "Now, we should explore the resources under the earth and remove the tag of becoming a 'country of import'. We have our own

resources and need to explore them. Countries like the US and Australia have developed by utilising the resources beneath the ground," he said.

"Vedanta's proposed aluminium projects worth ₹1 lakh crore will generate over

₹ 2 lakh direct and indirect jobs. Efforts to implement the projects will be intensified. Will help establish Odisha as a world-class aluminium production hub," Majhi said in a statement after meeting Agarwal.

The meeting between Agarwal and Majhi emphasised strengthening cooperation between the government and the industrial entity to expedite Vedanta's various industrial projects in Odisha, advance local development processes, and create employment opportunities. Vedanta's proposed projects include a state-of-the-art aluminium smelter plant with an annual capacity of 3 million tonnes in Dhenkanal district and an alumina refinery with

an annual capacity of 6 million tonnes in Rayagada district. These projects will help establish not only Odisha but the entire country as a global hub for aluminium manufacturing, Majhi said.

Once these projects are implemented, Vedanta's total aluminium production capacity will increase to 6 million tonnes per annum, helping to meet India's growing demand for the metal.

During the discussion, Agarwal also proposed the expansion of a 1 MTPA aluminium smelter plant located in Jharsuguda.

The chief minister stated that, recognising the immense potential of these projects for employment

generation and local development, the state government would extend all support to these investments in the aluminium sector. Agarwal stated, "The objective of our proposed investments is to establish a world-class industrial ecosystem that will power India's infrastructure, energy transition, advanced manufacturing, and emerging technologies.

In partnership with the state government, we are committed to building globally competitive assets, generating large-scale employment, strengthening local enterprises, and making a meaningful contribution towards building a developed India."



Minister released the 'Compendium of Schemes for MSMEs & Startups', which brings together details of more than 50 schemes from the Government. At the event, the Minister launched the 'Compendium of Schemes for MSMEs & Startups', which lists over 50 schemes from both the Government of India and the Delhi Government.

This resource helps entrepreneurs find support for finance, capacity building, technology, market access, and business development.

particularly committed to empowering women entrepreneurs, in line with the vision of the Narendra Modi Government, because their participation is essential for inclusive entrepreneurship and sustainable economic growth.

From obtaining licences and registrations to identifying markets, buyers and online platforms, we want to guide entrepreneurs through the entire journey," said Sardar Manjinder Singh Sirsa.

AI, semiconductors, quantum tech next major frontier for India: Sitharaman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Saturday called for greater investment in AI infrastructure, semiconductors and quantum technology, stressing that these would be the next major frontier for India.

Speaking at a fireside chat organised by the IIT Madras Alumni Association here, she said India needed to accelerate efforts to build the hardware, skills and institutional ecosystem required to harness these emerging technologies. "Things are happening in India in AI, but the magazines and newspapers largely from abroad - Oh, India's missed the AI bus," Sitharaman said, adding that this perception was partly shaped by the

absence of a significant number of AI companies listed on the NSE (National Stock Exchange of India) and BSE (Bombay Stock Exchange).

She, however, pointed out that several startups in the AI sector had already become unicorns or were on the verge of becoming one.

The minister noted that there was a tendency among startups in general to be wary of listing due to the many compliances that were required to be followed, but emphasised that listing brings its own advantages.

Stating that "the cluster of listings" belongs to the AI domain, she said, if it (AI companies) had been in the stock market, maybe those writers "outside" would know that a lot of things are happening, funding is avail-

able, and institutions are coming up to fund. "India is not lost on AI or quantum. Maybe 'just not in the stock market' cannot be an adequate measure to see what's happening here. But mind you, that's the world. We have to have these narratives also addressed, retorted, and maybe, to get the best out of the world, get yourselves listed also where you can," she said.

Sitharaman said that India needed to strengthen its existing AI ecosystem through greater investment in hardware, training and skilling. "...despite the call for slowing down the speed with which innovators are coming up in the AI field, I'll still think, for India, from where it is, we still need a lot more investment towards bringing in that kind of hard-



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, centre, during the 7th edition of the IITMAA Sangam 2026 annual conference on the theme Atmanirbhar Bharat in Bengaluru, Karnataka on Saturday

ware and bringing in that kind of teachers to institutions which have to constantly upgrade and keep imparting AI-based knowledge, adaptability of AI into very many sectors," she said. According to her, India's MSMEs, which span a wide range of manufacturing sectors, increasingly needed AI solutions to improve productivity and compete with their counterparts in other countries.

"So investment in AI is definitely the next frontier. At what stage and at what level is something which I want both academia and industry to say," she said, adding that the focus should be on determining the level of investment rather than questioning whether AI should be pursued. Sitharaman said that the

next large investment in infrastructure would be in AI, semiconductor chips, and building on quantum technology, emphasising the need for academia and industry to work together to build capabilities in these fields.

In addition to this, the minister also highlighted the potential for greater investment in defence production, particularly in emerging technologies such as unmanned systems and drones.

"India has already moved forward in being not just an importer...We are exporting defence equipment of different order, different size, vectors which you would never have imagined. But there is more to do in the defence production," she said.

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

UNGA: PM returns home

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah on Saturday returned home after attending the 81st session of the UN General Assembly (UNGA), where he called for climate justice to be put into practice. Shah addressed the General Debate of the UNGA in New York. The main theme of the General Assembly was "Restoring Trust, Managing Transformation: A United Nations that Delivers for All." Shah drew the international community's attention to last month's devastating Bhotekoshi floods, which resulted in huge damage to life in Nepal. According to Foreign Ministry, Shah pointed out that although Nepal contributes a negligible 0.1 per cent to greenhouse gas emissions, it is at the forefront of the climate crisis. (PTI)

GERMANY

EU eyes migration curbs

European interior ministers held talks on Saturday to strengthen border controls, improve emergency response times and establish fast-track procedures for returning some migrants. The gathering of 17 ministers from the European Union (EU) and Britain comes as the 27-member bloc works to strengthen migration controls following the implementation in June of a migration pact. Asylum applications in Europe have fallen sharply and fewer migrants have attempted to cross the Mediterranean. (AP)

US President rejects Iran proposal to reopen Strait of Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington/Dubai

US President Donald Trump on Saturday rejected Iran's proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran offered this week to reopen the strait and resume talks on its nuclear programme in seven days if the US lifts its naval blockade of Iranian ports, waives sanctions on Iranian oil sales and observes a ceasefire that would include Lebanon.

But on Saturday, Trump rejected the proposal saying Iran wanted to make a deal because it was "losing so badly." "They want to make a deal and I think that's fine," Trump told reporters outside the White House before leaving for a college football game. "I'd like to make a deal, too. But that deal would not be acceptable."

Iran effectively closed the strait after the US and Israel attacked the Islamic Republic in late February, and the number of ships passing through has dropped significantly because of Iranian threats and attacks on vessels in the waterway.

US President Donald Trump has posted an image of the Strait of Hormuz labelled "Trump Strait"



shortly after Iran proposed a deal to open the waterway within a week if the US meets certain conditions. Meanwhile, Iranian media outlets say the country's president has left New York after the United Nations gathering of world leaders that included Iran's indirect talks with the United States.

And Saudi Arabia says it has intercepted another missile it blames on Iran-backed Houthis in neighbouring Yemen. Trump posted an image early on Saturday morning on his Truth Social platform of the Strait of Hormuz labelled "Trump Strait," in the first public indication of his thinking after Iran proposed the new deal and suggested it might help Trump ahead of the midterm elections.

The White House said only that US officials were having positive and constructive conversations with mediators on the Iran war. Earlier in the week, Iran held hours of indirect talks with the US.

Semiofficial media outlets in Iran reported that President Masoud Pezeshkian has departed New York for Tehran after the annual UN gathering of world leaders.

Pezeshkian's speech to the gathering pushed back against Trump's latest threat to "annihilate" the Islamic

Republic, but he ended by saying Tehran remains open to diplomacy.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told journalists Friday night that under Tehran's proposal, Iran would reopen the Strait of Hormuz and resume talks on its nuclear program in seven days if the United States lifts its naval blockade of Iranian ports, waives sanctions on Iranian oil sales and observes a ceasefire that would include Lebanon. Saudi Arabia's military spokesperson, Major Gen. Turki al-Malki, claimed early Saturday that a ballistic missile launched by the Iran-backed Houthi rebels in neighbouring Yemen was intercepted and destroyed. He said it was fired toward the southwestern city of Khamis Mushait.

The Associated Press couldn't immediately verify that independently. There was no immediate statement of responsibility, though it can take days for the Houthis to issue one.

A regional body representing Arab Gulf states, the Gulf Cooperation Council, condemned the latest Houthi attacks as a "grave escalation and threat to regional security" and urged the international community to respond.

Russian FM backs India's permanent seat on UN Security Council

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov has reiterated Moscow's support for India's candidature for a permanent seat on the United Nations Security Council (UNSC), saying any reform of the powerful UN body should not result in additional permanent seats being given to Western countries.

Speaking during the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly, Lavrov said Russia supports the candidature of both India and Brazil for permanent membership of the Security Council.

"UN Security Council reform cannot involve any additional seats being allocated to Western countries, especially Germany and Japan," Lavrov said, according to remarks delivered during his address. He added that Russia supports "Brazil and India's candidature for a permanent seat."

Lavrov's comments underline Moscow's stated position that the composition of the Security Council should reflect a broader representation of the world's major regions and emerging powers. India has for years sought permanent membership of the 15-member



Russian FM Sergey Lavrov

Security Council, arguing that the current structure does not adequately represent contemporary global realities. The Security Council currently has five permanent members — China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom and the United States — which possess veto powers, alongside 10 non-permanent members elected for two-year terms.

Efforts to reform the Council have been under discussion at the United Nations for decades, with member states divided over the number and composition of any additional permanent and non-permanent seats. Lavrov also criticised the prospect of Germany and Japan gaining permanent seats, saying the two countries were "now on the path to militarism and revisionism." The remarks reflect Moscow's opposition to expanding the permanent membership to those

two countries and come amid wider disagreements among major powers over the future structure of the Security Council.

India, meanwhile, has received support from several countries for its bid for a permanent seat. New Delhi has consistently argued that its large population, growing global role and participation in UN peacekeeping strengthen its case for a greater role in the organisation's decision-making structure.

In his address, Lavrov also touched on the selection of the next UN Secretary-General. He said Moscow favours a candidate who demonstrates "impartiality and equidistance" and represents the interests of the international community as a whole rather than those of individual states.

Lavrov further said Russia would support a Secretary-General who does not "dilute the prerogatives of the Security Council and its permanent members."

Russia, as one of the five permanent members of the Security Council, is among the states with a central role in discussions over both Council reform and the future leadership of the United Nations.

Sri Lanka Opposition leader Namal Rajapaksa quizzed in bribery case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Sri Lankan Opposition leader Namal Rajapaksa was on Saturday questioned in prison by the island nation's anti-graft commission in an alleged case of bribery.

Namal, 40, was questioned for allegedly accepting a bribe of Sri Lankan Rupees 70 million from the local agent of an Indian investment project, Krish Hotels.

The elder son of former president Mahinda Rajapaksa was questioned by investigators of the Commission to Investigate Bribery or Corruption (CIABOC) at the Colombo remand prison, where he is currently lodged.

He has been in remand since September 4 to face charges of accepting a \$2 million bribe



in the 2013 purchase of Airbus aircraft for SriLankan Airlines. A second remand order was placed on him a week later for money laundering in the same Airbus case.

Saudi, Pakistan and Turkiye defence officials resolve to assist Riyadh in wake of Houthi attacks

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

The top defence officials of Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkiye have resolved to defend the security of the Gulf Kingdom under the Makkah Defence Alliance in the wake of recent attacks by Yemen's Houthi rebels, the Pakistan Army said on Saturday.

The trilateral defence agreement, signed by the three countries last month, establishes a framework for collective deterrence and stipulates that an armed attack against any one of them would be regarded as an attack against all.

The meeting of the chiefs of defence forces and chiefs of general staff of the countries was held in Riyadh on Friday,



according to a statement by the army. They reviewed the security situation and the threats facing Saudi Arabia.

"The participants strongly affirmed their commitment to collective defence, thereby demonstrating the resolve of the three countries in defending the security, sovereignty and territorial integrity of Saudi Arabia," it said.

They resented the attacks targeting the Holy City of Makkah and civilian and economic infrastructure, while appreciating the vigilance and professionalism of the Saudi Armed Forces, the statement said. The participants also discussed ways to further advance cooperation among the armed forces of the three countries and to enhance intelligence sharing, military coordination, and capability integration.

The meeting came a day after the foreign ministers of the three nations met in New York and discussed the challenges faced by the kingdom.

On Wednesday, Pakistan appointed former Lt Gen Nauman Mahmood as the first secretary-general of the trilateral alliance. (PTI)

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Shristi, Daughter of No.15619459L Hav Rakesh Kumar Mishra, R/o- Vill- Pandela, PO- Kadipur, Teh- Kadipur, Dist- Sultanpur, U.P- 228145, have changed my Daughter's name from Shristi to Shristi Mishra, vide affidavit dated 26/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Urmila Maravi, W/o No.2300088M Lnk/Gnr Sarvan Marav, R/o- Vill- Kutwahi, PO- Rata, Teh- Bichhiya, Dist- Mandla, M.P- 481768 have changed my name from Urmila Maravi to Urmila Marav, vide affidavit dated 26/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Nasrul Ansari, Father of- No.16034622W RFN Arsad Ansari, R/o- Vill- Dewtha, PO- Sukrauli, Teh- Hata, Dist- Kushinagar, U.P.- 274207, have changed my name from Nasrul Ansari to Nasarul Ansari, vide affidavit dated 26/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Peesa Narasimhamurthy, Father of- No.15718683A Hav Peesa Kanakaraju, R/o- Vill- Arangi Peta, PO- Allinagaram, Teh- Laveru, Dist- Srikakulam, A.P.- 532403, have changed my name from Peesa Narasimhamurthy to Peesa Varahalu, vide affidavit dated 26/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Jaspal Kaur, Mother of- No.2615988A Hav Balwinder Khan, R/o- Vill- Charrian, PO- Singh Bhagwantpura, Teh & Dist- Ropar, Punjab- 140108, have changed my name from Jaspal Kaur to Jaspal Kaur, vide affidavit dated 26/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Patil Rupali W/o- No.15434747L HAV/NA Patil Samadhan Dhudku, R/o- Vill & PO- Mahindale, Teh- Bhadgaon, Dist- Jalgaon, Maharashtra- 424105, have changed my name from Patil Rupali to Rupali Samadhan Patil, vide affidavit dated 26/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform general public that Mr. Prince Kumar S/o. Late Vijay Singh alias Vijay Singh Kanwar has acquired Second Floor without roof rights, area measuring 139 sq. yds, built on Property bearing no. 12103, New No. 12, out of Kharsa no. 3863/2974, 3854/46Min, situated at village Chandrawal, in the abadi of Harsaran Niwas, Railway Road, Ilaga Shakhara, Delhi 110052, by way of Relinquishment Deed dated 13/08/2026.

Document related to the above said property has been misplaced i.e. Sale Deed dated 29/02/2012 in lieu of the said property. If anyone who find the above said documents shall handover the same to the Manager of Sitara Housing Finance Limited (earlier known as SEWA Grln Limited).

Now, Mr. Prince Kumar intending to sell the said property to Mrs Murtal and further Mr. Adnan Rayeen, Mr. Kail Rayeen and Mrs Murtal are availing loan on above said property from Sitara Housing Finance Limited (earlier known as SEWA Grln Rtn Limited) in case anyone has any objection, the same may be raised within 7 days of the publication to Mr. Ajit Sharma (Advocate), Partner of Acculaw Source LLP, Office no. 361, 2nd Floor, Sec-3, Vaisali, Ghazabad, U.P. Pincode 201010 or contact : 9819560399909 (M).

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the public at large that we, Anurag Vidyarthi, S/o Sh. Late L.K. Vidyarthi, and Esha Vidyarthi, D/o Sh. Anurag Vidyarthi, do hereby declare that Office No. T-3, Third Floor, Manish Abhinav Plaza, Plot No. 11, MLU Pkt., Sector-4, Dwarka, New Delhi - 110075, is in the name of Smt. Tanuja Vidyarthi, wife of Anurag Vidyarthi and mother of Esha Vidyarthi, respectively. Smt. Tanuja Vidyarthi expired on 24th April 2021. We hereby declare that we have no objection to the transfer of title of the above-mentioned property in our names, i.e., Anurag Vidyarthi and Esha Vidyarthi.

Any person having any objection, claim, or interest in respect of the said property may submit the same, along with supporting documents, within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice. Failing this, no claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter.

Anurag Vidyarthi
Esha Vidyarthi
309, First Floor,
Nagin Lake Apartments,
Peeragarhi, Paschim Vihar,
New Delhi - 110087

PUBLIC NOTICE

Our clients, Shri. Vijay Singh S/o Shri Yad Ram and Mithlesh W/o Shri Vijay Singh R/o P-1/611, Sultanpuri, P-1, Delhi- 110086 and owners of H.No. A-366, Jain Nagar, Gali NO.4, Delhi-110081, hereby notifies that their son, Shri Rinku and his family comprising of his wife, Geeta and their children have separated themselves from the families w.e.f. 12th August, 2026 on account of family dispute and they are residing separately from our clients since then. Our clients have got no relationship whatsoever with them and the public is hereby informed accordingly. The family of our clients will not be responsible for any liabilities, acts and deeds of their said son and his family. Any liability/claim/demand action against the aforesaid son and his wife shall be their sole responsibility.

Mittal & Mittal Co. (Advocates)
614, 6th Floor, R.G. Trade Tower, Netaji Subhash Place, Pitampura, Delhi-110 034
Ph: 9891477714, 9891188839
E-mail: mittal782004@yahoo.co.in

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Website: www.apssrinagar.co.in

INVITING QUOTATIONS

1. On behalf of the Chairman Army Public School, Srinagar invites sealed quotations from reputed and authorised firms for supply and installation of Digital Duplicator for the Exam Cell of School under **Two-Bid System (Technical Bid and Commercial Bid)** :-

2. The Tech Bid should contain the details of Company valid GST Registration Certificate and PAN Card. Technical specifications of the proposed digital duplicator including make/ model, warranty and all necessary details.

3. Firms shall submit their bids in **separate sealed envelopes**, clearly marked **"TECH BID"** and **"COMMERCIAL BID"**. The school reserves the right to cancel the call for quotation without assigning any reason. The last date for submission of quotations is **06 Oct 2026**. For any query contact during all working days between **10.00 A.M to 03.00 P.M at 0194-2468224**.

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BABA FARID UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES, FARIDKOT

ADMISSION NOTICE M.Sc. (Anatomy), M.Sc. (Physiology), M.Sc. (Biochemistry), Session 2026

Online Applications for admission to M.Sc. in Anatomy, Physiology and Biochemistry Courses, session 2026 are invited from eligible candidates through University website from **29-09-2026 to 16-10-2026** alongwith requisite fee through University Payment Gateway. Physical counselling will be held on **21-10-2026 (10:00 AM)** BFUHS, Faridkot. The selected candidates shall pay the tuition fee on the spot at the counselling venue in the shape of Bank Demand Draft in favor of Registrar, BFUHS, payable in Faridkot

ADMISSION NOTICE-Certificate and Diploma Session 2026

Online Applications for admission to Certificate and Diploma Courses, session 2026 are invited from eligible candidates through University website from **29-09-2026 to 06-10-2026** alongwith requisite fee through University Payment Gateway. Prospectus for admission to above mentioned courses is available on University website. For Prospectus, details/Updates visit university website (www.bfuh.ac.in)

Registrar

3108/12/2026-27/15565 Dated CHD :- 25/09/2026

सेंट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India

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BRANCH OFFICE: BHAGIRATH PALACE, DELHI-110006

POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property) [Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas, the Authorised Officer of the Central Bank of India, Bhagirath Palace Branch, Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002, (Act 54, of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (2) and 13 (12) read with the Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 issued a demand notice dated **04.06.2026** calling upon the **Borrower: Shri Jagannath Sharma & Smt. Urapramali Devi**, R/o C-539, Ground Floor, Brij Vihar, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201011 **Guarantor: Shri Heera Lal Gupta**, R/o C-544, Brij Vihar, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201011, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.19,78,646.71 (Rupees Nineteen Lakh Seventy Eight Thousand Six Hundred Forty Six and Paise Seventy One Only)** + Interest and expenses thereon, within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The borrowers having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers, the Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under sub section (4) of Section 13 of the said Act, read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this **25th Day of September of the Year 2026**. The Borrowers and the Guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to charge of **Central Bank of India, Bhagirath Palace Branch, Delhi** for the amount of **Rs.19,78,646.71 (Rupees Nineteen Lakh Seventy Eight Thousand Six Hundred Forty Six and Paise Seventy One Only)** as on 04.06.2026 with subsequent interest and expenses thereon (less if any payments made).

The borrower's/guarantor's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF SECURED ASSETS

A Residential Flat situated at C-539, Ground Floor (LLG) Triple Storey, Sector 8, Brij Vihar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201011 admeasuring Total area 40.22 Sq.Mtr., covered area 35.29 Sq.mtrs. in the name of **Shri Jagannath Sharma, Bounded as under:-**

North: Road 20 Ft wide South: Building No.C-538
East: Road 20 Ft wide West: Building No. C-536

PLACE: GHAZIABAD (Authorised Officer),
DATE: 25/09/2026 Central Bank of India

Bangladesh, US sign MoU on civil nuclear cooperation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Bangladesh and the United States have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on strategic civil nuclear cooperation to deepen cooperation in the peaceful use of nuclear energy.

The MoU was signed in New York by Bangladesh Prime Minister's Adviser for Science and Technology Rehan Asad and US Under Secretary of State for Economic Growth, Energy and the Environment Jacob Helberg, according to Bangladesh's ruling party BNP's media cell.

The agreement comes as Bangladesh seeks to expand and diversify its long-term energy sources. The country is developing its first nuclear power plant at



Bangladesh PM's Adviser Rehan Asad and US under secretary Jacob Helberg sign MoU on civil nuclear cooperation in New York

Rooppur and has been pursuing international cooperation in nuclear science and technology.

Under the MoU, the two sides recognised the strategic significance of their diplomatic relationship and its regional and international security implications, including energy security. They also noted the role nuclear energy can play in meeting the energy requirements of both countries, according to local media reports.

The MoU records the shared position that all civil nuclear cooperation should follow the highest standards of nuclear safety, security, safeguards and non-proliferation, according to *The Daily Star* newspaper.

It also noted that both Bangladesh and the US have International Atomic Energy

Agency safeguards agreements and Additional Protocols in force. Both countries are parties to the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons.

The latest MoU specifically focuses on civil nuclear cooperation and the peaceful use of nuclear energy. During US Special Envoy for South and Central Asia Sergio Gor's recent visit, Washington proposed a memorandum of understanding on civil nuclear cooperation with Bangladesh.

On August 3, State Minister for Foreign Affairs Shama Obaed Islam said Bangladesh views the US proposal on civil nuclear cooperation positively, stressing that any engagement with Washington will be considered if it serves the interests of the people of Bangladesh.

Peru in court over logging threat to isolated Amazon tribes



STEVEN GRATTAN
■ Paramaribo

Peru faced the final day of a landmark hearing before a regional human rights court on Friday over allegations that it failed to protect Indigenous peoples living in isolation in the Amazon from logging and other activities encroaching on their territory.

The two-day hearing before the Inter-American Court of Human Rights in Montevideo, Uruguay, marks the first time the tribunal has considered a case involving Indigenous peoples living in isolation in Peru. The case centres on the Mashco Piro, Yora and Amahuaca peoples, who live in remote areas of the Peruvian Amazon. Indigenous organisations say logging concessions and other

incursions have pushed outsiders deeper into forests used by the groups, increasing the risk of violent encounters and exposure to diseases to which isolated peoples may have little immunity. "Many of our brothers and sisters have already disappeared, and we don't want the Mashco Piro to suffer the same fate," Maglin Alvarado Vargas, a leader of the Yine Indigenous people from the Native Community of Monte Salvado, told the court. "It is in your hands whether they can survive."

Peru has argued that it has adopted laws, protocols, monitoring systems and other measures to protect isolated Indigenous peoples. The Peruvian Government did not immediately respond to a request for comment. (AP)

Russian attacks kill 4 across Ukraine as strikes intensify

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Russian attacks killed four people across Ukraine on Saturday, officials said, as the aerial war between Moscow and Kyiv intensifies.

Russia has hammered Ukraine with cruise and ballistic missiles, powerful glide bombs and jet-powered drones while front-line progress has slowed, some 4½-years after Moscow launched a full-scale invasion of its neighbour.

"It is essential that our partners not forget: Russia is escalating every single day. If the Russians have chosen to make their strikes even more brutal, the world must choose stronger responses to keep the war from spreading further," Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on Saturday morning.

He listed "numerous strikes on residential homes" in the cities of Kyiv and Zaporizhzhia, and the

Odesa, Sumy, and Kharkiv regions.

Two women in Zaporizhzhia died when they were trapped beneath the rubble of their destroyed home, Zaporizhzhia's regional military administration said. A separate Russian attack on the city of Sumy also killed two people, local officials said. Zelenskyy appealed at the United Nations earlier this week to countries to starve Russia of revenue through sanctions and trade bans, denying Moscow the money it needs to prolong the war. But despite years of diplomatic efforts, there is no sign of a breakthrough in ending the war.

Meanwhile, Ukraine's long-range drones have targeted Russian oil refineries and businesses. A Ukrainian drone attack on the southern Krasnodar region killed three people and wounded two, local officials said Saturday.

Writing on Telegram, regional Gov. Veniamin Kondratyev said that



a Ukrainian attack sparked fires at two industrial sites, but did not give further details. Russian media outlets later reported that a local oil refinery was targeted in the strike.

Elsewhere in Ukraine, two people were injured in the Kyiv region

overnight after a Russian drone attack caused a fire at a warehouse in the Boryspil district. Russian drones also hit several districts in the Ukrainian capital itself, injuring four and damaging residential and office buildings, officials said. (AP)

12 killed, 18 injured in suicide attack in northwest Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

At least 12 people, including two women and two children, were killed and 18 others injured when a suicide bomber belonging to the banned terror outfit Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan targeted a police checkpoint in north-west Pakistan on Saturday, an official said.

According to Pakistan's national emergency response service Rescue 1122, the incident occurred in Darazinda tehsil of Dera Ismail Khan district, near the border between the restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan provinces.

The suicide bomber rammed a tractor-trolley loaded with explosives into the Aman Mela police checkpoint, Regional Police Officer Khan Mubashir Malik said. Twelve people were killed, and 18 others sustained injuries in the attack, he added. According to police, two officials from the customs and excise department were among those killed. The injured were shifted to the District Headquarters Hospital for treatment, while the bodies of the deceased were also taken there.

Congo plane crash kills 14, including 2 military officials

JEAN-YVES KAMALE ■ Kinshasa

At least 14 people, including two senior military officials, have died in a plane crash in Congo, the military said.

The two senior military officials are Lieutenant General Mutombo Katalayi Tiende, head of the military court, and Lieutenant General Bakumi Likulia, auditor general of the armed forces.

"In addition to the two general officers, twelve members of the delegation and the crew members also lost their lives in this accident," Major General Efomi Ekenge, spokesperson of the Congolese military, said in a statement. The plane was returning to the capital city, Kinshasa, from southwestern Kikwit when it developed a technical fault and crashed in Kenge where everyone on board died, according to local officials.

An investigation has been opened



to determine the cause of the accident, Ekenge said.

Tryphon Kin-Kiey Mulumba, Chairman of the Board of the Civil Aviation Authority, said the cause of the crash is unknown. The Congolese

military has been battling scores of rebel groups, including the Rwanda-backed M23 rebel group in the eastern region since last year, after a blitz of attacks that led to the rebel groups seizing key cities. (AP)

Nepal floods: 1,453 dead, nearly 5,300 still missing a month after disaster

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

A month after the devastating flash floods hit Nepal's central and northern districts, at least 1,453 people have died and 5,285 remain unaccounted for, according to the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA).

NDRRMA said the bodies of 1,451 people have been recovered so far, while two others died while undergoing treatment. A total of 13,795 people have been rescued to date, it said Saturday.

Of those rescued, 1,113 people are currently staying in 21 holding centres, including 187 from Nuwakot, 805 from Rasuwa and 121 from Dhading districts. Flash floods originating near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26 devastated



towns and villages in northern and central Nepal.

The Bhotekoshi River, which flows south from the Himalayan border region, carried the floodwaters downstream, sweeping away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges and damaging hydropower projects. The disaster also killed 43 people in Tibet, while more than 500 still remain unaccounted for,

according to Chinese media. In Nepal, security agencies have so far provided medical treatment to around 11,000 people affected by the floods, according to NDRRMA. Seven people injured in the floods are currently undergoing treatment, it said. Identification of the dead remains a major challenge a month after the disaster.

Of the 1,453 bodies recovered so far, 112 have been identified and handed over to their families, according to NDRRMA. Many of the recovered bodies were badly damaged or fragmented, making visual identification difficult.

Nepal Police has therefore been relying on DNA profiling to establish links between recovered remains and people reported missing after the floods. (PTI)

US, China open AI & crisis channels

HUIZHONG WU ■ Bangkok

China and the US agreed to set up a channel for handling AI-related incidents and accelerate work on military crisis communications following a three-day summit between their leaders in Washington, both sides said in statements on Saturday.

The two sides agreed to keep working together on a Board of Trade on selected bilateral trade issues, with the White House saying in a statement Saturday that the board went into operation this week.

The summit produced no major breakthroughs, but some experts say the steps toward greater cooperation were still considered important, allowing the two powers to set up working groups that could prevent problems from escalating.

Chinese President Xi Jinping landed back in Beijing on Saturday, according to Xinhua.

During the visit, President Donald Trump was remarkably warm to Xi, despite having escalated a trade war with China the previous year that had global repercussions. The two sides agreed to sign a memorandum of understanding on strengthening crisis communications and preventing crises



between the two militaries, China's Foreign Ministry said Saturday in its readout. The one-page statement from the Chinese side was light on details.

Both sides will set up a communication mechanism for artificial intelligence-related incidents, to discuss related risks and benefits, with an AI-specific dialogue scheduled for November.

The statement said both sides will continue to work together on the pledge to reduce reciprocal tariffs on roughly \$30 billion worth of goods. During the summit, the two leaders agreed to extend a trade truce by two months. (AP)

Heavy rain, flooding in Bangkok disrupts traffic and prompts evacuations

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bangkok

Rain hammered several areas of Thailand's Capital on Saturday, disrupting traffic and forcing hundreds to evacuate.

Thailand's Meteorological Department warned the heavy rain would continue in most parts of the country through Sunday, citing a strong low-pressure system over the central region and strengthening southwest monsoon conditions.

Accumulated rainfall in major canals in Bangkok exceeded 20 centimetres (7.8 inches), officials said. Floodwaters spread across the city, particularly in the central and eastern parts,

blocking roads and stopping traffic in some areas.

More than 84,000 people in 21 provinces nationwide were affected by flooding as of Saturday, especially in the central region. Authorities sent emergency warning messages through the cell-broadcast system to people in affected areas, the Government said.

Hwang Hwan-chung, who flew from South Korea and has visited Bangkok over ten times, said he had never seen such "crazy" weather, adding that he couldn't find a taxi.

Sukanya Tongasuk, a local, said the current flooding was similar to the last time Bangkok was hit by wide-



Men push motorcycles as they wade through floodwaters after heavy rain in Bangkok, Thailand

spread flooding in 2011.

"I think it's like 10 or 15 years ago that we saw heavy rain like this," she said.

Meanwhile, Dutch resident Bjorn Franken, who has lived in the capital for two years, said he was able to cope although one event he wanted to attend had been cancelled. Many businesses in Bangkok closed on Saturday due to flooding.

Cars crawled along waterlogged roads in parts of Bangkok, and bikers were seen pushing their motorcycles. Authorities said some regional bus services from Bangkok to the eastern provinces were suspended.

Phetchaburi Road, one of the capital's busiest main

roads, was unusually quiet as vehicles had to turn back. Some were left partially submerged. Residents, some barefoot and others wearing rubber waders while several wrapped plastic bags around their feet, made their way through murky waters, carrying fresh water and food.

Air traffic control authorities confirmed operations remained normal at airports, but some flights might face delays due to weather-caused detours.

Bangkok Governor Chachart Sittipunt said despite the heavy rain, flooding should recede once the rain subsides, as city officials work to drain floodwaters as quickly as possible.



 BRIEFLY

Salt Lake stadium gets makeover ahead of Brazil showdown



The iconic Salt Lake stadium is getting a major facelift as the football-mad city prepares to host five-time world champions Brazil against India on October 3 and two-time world champions Uruguay against India three days later.

With the two high-profile international fixtures approaching, work is being carried out at a fast pace, with the stands getting fresh coats of paint, seats being renovated and re-numbered, and spectator facilities being upgraded. The renovation work is being carried out by the state government's sports and youth affairs department under whose purview the Salt Lake Stadium falls.

Food stalls will be set up in the gallery lobbies to improve the matchday experience, while ground staff are completing the re-turfing of the main pitch and training grounds after heavy rain and back-to-back matches.

The stadium's exterior is also being spruced up, with landscaping and other aesthetic work underway.

Additional entry gates are being constructed and existing gates widened to ensure smoother crowd movement.

Restrooms and other public facilities are being renovated, while new fencing is being installed around the practice grounds as part of the security arrangements.

A delegation from the Brazilian Football Confederation (CBF) had earlier inspected Kolkata's infrastructure, with representatives remaining on site to oversee the final preparations for Brazil's visit.

With Brazil working to a tight schedule before their October 3 match, local authorities have fast-tracked preparations, keeping a close watch on security arrangements, training facilities and the playing surface.

The Brazilian contingent is expected to be around 90 members strong, including players, coaching staff, medical personnel, support staff and administrative officials.

The Khalid Jamil-coached Blue Tigers have warmed up to the two Kolkata fixtures with an impressive one-all draw against Panama, a side 94 places above them on the FIFA rankings, in a match in Bengaluru on Friday.

(PTI)

Rohit Rajpal hints at Davis Cup exit after December



AMANPREET SINGH
■ New Delhi

Rohit Rajpal on Saturday hinted that he may step down as India's Davis Cup captain, saying he does not believe in occupying a position if he feels he no longer has enough to contribute and that "every good thing comes to an end".

Rajpal, whose current contract runs until December 31, 2026, said he would take a decision on his future soon and was ready to ensure a smooth transition by sharing his experience with his successor.

AITA had extended his tenure until the end of 2026, last year. "I really do feel that I need to make this decision very soon and I will. Every good thing comes to an end. I can't continue forever," Rajpal said.

Should he leave the captaincy, Rajpal said his successor would inherit a team with a substantial knowledge base, but stressed that understanding individual players takes time.

"It took me at least two years to understand the players. A captain needs to know which conditions and

courts suit each player, how they respond to pressure and what they can handle in a Davis Cup match.

"I will be very happy to share all my knowledge from my four-five years as captain," he said.

For Rajpal, the potential transition is not necessarily an admission that the team needs a complete overhaul. Rather, he believes a new captain could bring a different perspective at a time when India has already built a platform to move forward.

"Somebody else would come and bring a different perspective to strategies. Somebody younger should also get a chance," he said but did not want to say who should replace him.

His own philosophy, he added, is simple: "Till the time you can contribute and contribute well, and you are justifying your position, you need to be there. And if you're not, then I think make space for somebody else to come."

The former India player, who took over as non-playing captain in 2019 after Mahesh Bhupathi opted out of the Pakistan tie, led India in 12 ties, winning six.

India seal semifinal berth in Asiad men's hockey

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kakamigahaa (Japan)

Defending champions India advanced to the semifinals of the Asian Games men's hockey competition after defeating hosts Japan 2-0 in a hard-fought pool A contest here on Saturday.

India had earlier thrashed Indonesia 13-1, Sri Lanka 16-1 and South Korea 8-2 in their opening three pool matches. The win over Japan was their fourth consecutive in the event, continuing an unbeaten run.

India will take on Bangladesh in their final pool match against Bangladesh on September 28, which they are expected to win handsomely.

Against Japan, Abhishek (15th minute) scored from a



field effort while skipper Harmanpreet Singh converted a penalty corner in the

40th minute. It was a pulsating first two quarters where Japan matched India stick-

for-stick with their aggressive play but the defending champions went into the

Anahat rallies to storm into final of women's singles squash

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagoya

India's teenage squash sensation Anahat Singh revealed that the thought of booking an Olympic spot "replayed" constantly in her head as she staged a stunning comeback to reach the Asian Games women's singles final on Saturday.

Anahat fought back from two games down to defeat Japan's higher-ranked Satomi Watanabe.

Anahat was trailing 0-2 in the semifinal with a partisan crowd cheering for the home player, but the 18-year-old Indian made a remarkable comeback to take the next three games and win the match 3-2 (9-11 11-13 12-10 11-6 11-3) and reach the final. Both the men's and women's singles gold medallists in Asian Games will get a direct qualification to 2028 Games.

"I mean, when I was losing, the first thought that came into my mind was you can't let the Olympic spot go by so quickly. And, you know, you really need to push for it. And that's what just kept replaying in my head over and over," Anahat



said when asked about her mindset after trailing 0-2 in the semifinal.

"And I think that's something that really motivates me rather than something that's a pressure that, you know, you're supposed to be in the Olympics or qualify for the Olympics," She said the coaches advised her to remain calm and maintain consistency throughout.

"After the first two games, my coaches were just telling me not to get too stressed out and that I'm playing the right game. And I just really need to make sure that I'm doing it continuously and not only towards the end of the games.

"And, they kept reminding me what I'm playing for, re-

resenting my country and to really show what I'm capable of. And I think that's what really pushed me over the edge and motivated me to keep pushing and hopefully win the match as well."

Asked if it was the best match of her career, she said, "Yes, it is the best win of my career. She's number five in the world and that's the highest win I've ever had in my squash career. Yeah, but I'm just really happy. I wasn't really thinking too much about that.

"I just thought of her as another opponent who I've played once before and I've had a close game with. And, you know, anything is possible in a stage like this. It just depends on who has the

right mentality and who is really willing to give it out all on court." She made her Asian Games debut in 2023 in China as a 15-year-old and she has travelled a long way since then.

"I think the last Asian Games were very different. I went into that Games just trying to get experience and just being in a very new atmosphere and environment around the top players. I had never been in a place like that before.

"But coming into this time, there has been a lot of different changes in my career. There has been a lot that I've learned and, of course, I've grown as well. And just coming into this event, there was, of course, a lot expected. "And, you know, get a medal and take it further and hopefully go to tomorrow. I do focus on that. I think of it more like something that's motivating rather than pressure."

In final, Anahat faces world number 5 and defending champion Sivasangari Subramaniam of Malaysia who beat last edition silver medallist Chan Sin Yuk of Hong Kong in the other women's singles semifinals.

Beating Olympic champion for silver helped ease disappointment of missing gold: Elavenil

SUMAN RAY/HARDIK SHARMA
■ New Delhi

Elite rifle shooter Elavenil Valarivan said beating reigning Olympic and world champion Ban Hoyojin of South Korea for an individual silver at the Asian Games has helped her overcome the disappointment of narrowly missing out on gold after leading until the final stages of the women's 10m air rifle competition in Nagoya. Elavenil returned home to a rousing welcome at Delhi's IGI Airport along with seven other medal-winning members of the Indian shooting contingent late Friday night.

"I feel very grateful that I got to represent my country and was able to bring a lot of laurels for the country. Definitely, there is some disappointment that I could not win the gold, but nevertheless, this is just the beginning and I think there is more to come," Elavenil told PTI after being accorded a thunderous welcome at the airport.

"I did beat the world champion as well as the Olympic champion, who came third. I am very grateful that I have an amazing team around me and we have been training on the right path. This medal is a confidence booster for me, to know that I am on the right track (towards the LA Olympics)," she said.

The eldest member of the contingent, Mairaj Ahmad Khan, 50, was simply elated and relieved that his long wait for an Asian Games medal was finally over. "For the last 25 years, I'm working. My first Asian Games was in 2006. And after two decades, I've won this medal for my country. And I'm very happy and I'm very thankful to Naveen Jindal, who supported me all the way through my journey to pursue my goal," he said.

Double silver medallist Anantjit Singh Naruka was happy and disappointed at the same time but said his two silver medals meant a lot to him as a shooter.



"It means a lot. I came back with two medals last time in China also, and this time also I got back with two medals.

"It's a proud moment for all of us. We worked really hard for it, and that's what showed when we were playing our matches. Of course, as an athlete, we feel that the colour could have gotten better. But I'm really happy with two medals," he said. One of the youngest members of the Indian contingent, talented shooter Raiza Dhillon, said the team medal was historic for the country's shooting squad. "It's a very historic medal

for us. It's the first team medal we've ever gotten in this game, so it's been a very big medal. And otherwise also, in the individual, I came fourth, so it was a very good competition all in all for me. I definitely had the full hopes of coming back with a medal. So I'm very happy that I have managed to do that," she said.

Naruka further said he and Parinaaz were aggressive shooters who relied on coffee and little sleep to stay sharp, and although he had hoped for three medals, he was happy with two and would now focus on Los Angeles. (PTI)

breather with a slender one goal lead.

India chief coach Craig Fulton will have plenty to worry about ahead of knock-outs, especially when it comes to in the penalty corner conversion as India secured 10 set pieces on Saturday but converted just one.

Japan was the better of the side in the first quarter with 60 per cent of possession but the Indians' were more relentless in attack.

India secured quick an early penalty corner in the sixth minute but skipper Harmanpreet couldn't make much of it as the Japanese defended stoutly.

In the 10th minute, Japan got a penalty corner and scored from it but the goal was disallowed as the

umpires deemed that the ball had touched an Indian's foot first.

Japan got another penalty corner but nothing came out of that either.

India finally took the lead through Abhishek's field goal. Japan secured their second penalty corner in the 17th min but India defended well.

India extended their lead from their fifth penalty corner with skipper Harmanpreet scoring through a fierce low flick to the right of the Japanese custodian.

The Indians enjoyed ball possession in the fourth quarter and secured four penalty corners in quick time but they failed to convert against a resolute Japanese defence.

Unnati enters quarters; Ayush, Lakshya exit Asiad



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagoya

Young shuttler Unnati Hooda produced an impressive show, notching up two fine victories to storm into the women's singles quarterfinals, while Lakshya Sen and Ayush Shetty were knocked out of the Asian Games here on Saturday.

In women's singles, Unnati, a winner of three BWF Super 100 titles, defeated Malaysia's Ling Ching Wong 21-14, 20-22, 21-19 to progress to the third round. The 19-year-old from Haryana then recorded a stunning 21-19, 21-13 win over world Number 6 Indonesian Putri Kusuma Wardani to set up a quarterfinal clash with Japan's Akane Yamaguchi.

Women's doubles pair Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand, who won their maiden World Championships bronze medal in New Delhi last month, notched up a second successive win in a week over world no. 3 Mayu Matsumoto and Yuki Fukushima of Japan, registering a 24-22, 21-18 victory to advance to the quarterfinals.

The Indian pair had defeated the same opponents in the women's team quarterfinal against Japan a few days back. Treesa and Gayatri will face Malaysia's Tan Pearly and Thinaah Muralitharan next. Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu, who won her maiden Super 750 title in Japan a few months back, also saw off Chinese Taipei's world No. 17 Chiu Pin-chian 21-19, 21-14 in the women's singles second round. Sindhu, who had received a bye in the opening round, will face Japan's Tomoka Miyazaki later in day.

Ayush, a finalist at the Badminton Asia Championships, brushed aside Kazakhstan's Makhmut Tajibullayev 21-7, 21-7 in the second round, but his gallant fight ended with a 16-21, 21-19, 17-21 loss to Chinese Taipei's 36-year-old Chou Tien Chen in the men's singles pre-quarterfinals. Earlier in the day, Lakshya lost to former world champion Loh Kean Yew of Singapore

in three games. The World No. 14 Sen went down 12-21 21-15 14-21 to the 2021 world champion, ranked 13th, in a battle lasting more than an hour.

The defeat came just a day after the shock exit of former world Number 1 pair Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty from the men's doubles, dealing another blow to India's badminton campaign.

An individual medal at the Asian Games thus continued to elude Sen, who had won the Commonwealth Games gold in 2022 and went on to finish fourth at the Paris Olympics. Sen, who has a team silver from last edition at Hangzhou, won a bronze in the team event on Wednesday.

World Number 24 Unnati, who had lost to her rival at the Hylo Open last year, opened up a 10-6 lead quickly before taking a two-point advantage at the break. Putri caught up at 15-15 and also took a slender 17-15 lead at one stage, but Unnati fought her way back to grab three game points. She squandered two of them before converting the third. In the second game, Unnati was 6-2 up, but Putri clawed back to 8-8. The Indian again regrouped to surge to 12-9. Putri narrowed the lead to 11-12, but the Indian slowly pulled away to shut the door on her fancied rival. Sindhu took time to get into the groove as it was her opponent Chui who kept things in control to move from 6-2 to manage a 11-10 lead at the break.

The Indian slowly made her way to 19-16 after some close fight. A backhand net shot error brought up three game points for Sindhu. A lucky net chord followed by a fine construction of rally helped Chui to save two before the Indian converted with a deep cross court push. In second game, Sindhu looked more in command as she opened up a 8-4 cushion early and then entered the break 11-8. Sindhu moves to 15-10 with Chui going long. The Indian eventually grabbed six match points and converted soon after.

Record-breaking Dhiraj, Chikitha lead India's strong archery show in Asian Games qualification

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Okazaki City (Japan)

Dhiraj Bommadevara and Chikitha Taniparthi led India's strong start to the Asian Games archery competition, topping the men's recurve and women's compound individual qualification respectively, while they also securing the top spot in the compound mixed team qualification here on Saturday. Fresh from winning a historic World Cup Final, Dhiraj's stunning 698-point effort in the morning not only set a new Asian Games qualification record but also helped India secure second place in the men's recurve team and recurve mixed team seedings.

Chikitha, who topped the women's compound qualification with 705 points, also powered

India to second place in the women's compound team event, while the compound men's team finished third, with Sahil Jadhav's fifth-place individual finish leading the charge. India are the defending champions in all five compound events, having swept all five gold medals at the Hangzhou Asian Games in 2023.

The only recurve team to finish outside the top five here was the women's side, which qualified sixth, with teenagers Kumkum Mohod (9th) and Kirti Sharma (16th) made the individual elimination rounds, while veteran Ankita Bhakat failed to qualify.

Dhiraj, currently ranked fourth in the world, shot 348 with his first 36 arrows before adding 350 in the second half, dropping just 10 points, to finish on 698 out of a



possible 720.

His score bettered the previous Asian Games qualification record of 690 set by Korean Lee Woo Seok in Hangzhou.

Korea's Kim Je Deok, a member of the Paris Olympics gold-medal winning team, finished second with a personal best score of 693, while Chinese Taipei's Chin-

Hun Tang was third with 692. Woo Seok finished fourth with 687. Dhiraj's top finish earned him a bye into the second round of the 64-archer individual elimination draw.

Woo Seok, the Paris Olympics bronze medallist, could be a potential semifinal opponent if both progress that far. Dhiraj leads their head-to-head record 2-1. The 25-year-old Army archer, who also won a maiden World Cup gold this year, will be looking to go further this time. He reached the quarterfinals at Hangzhou.

India have never won a gold in the recurve section at the Asian Games, with Tarundeep Rai's silver in 2010 remaining the country's best finish, and Dhiraj's stunning form will give them renewed hope. There was a major

surprise for Korea as legendary archer Kim Woojin missed the individual elimination round.

Woojin, who was eyeing a third Asian Games gold, finished third among the Korean archers and missed the cut, with only the top two from each country advancing to the 64-player elimination draw.

Dhiraj's score also helped India finish second in the men's recurve team qualification behind Korea. The second-seeded Indians have received a bye into the pre-quarterfinals and will face the Philippines. India had won a silver in the men's recurve team event at Hangzhou.

Dhiraj and Kumkum also combined for 1364 points to give India the second seed in the recurve mixed team event behind South Korea. The Indian pair have

received a bye into the pre-quarterfinals. In the women's recurve individual qualification, teenagers Kumkum and Kirti made the elimination cut, finishing ninth and 16th with 666 and 653 points respectively. Veteran Ankita Bhakat, however, missed the individual knockout after finishing third among the Indians.

The women's recurve team qualified sixth for the elimination rounds and will begin its campaign against Mongolia. In the compound section, Chikitha topped the women's individual qualification with 705 points from a maximum 720.

Iran's Bitar Asheghzadeh Oskoueie was a close second with 704, while Korea's Park Jungyoon and Kang Yeonsoo took the third and fourth spots.

Asian Games: Mixed day in athletics, shooting, Kabaddi skipper lauds raiders

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagoya

A historic marathon silver by Sawan Barwal was the high point of the country's erratic track-and-field campaign on Saturday with shooters enduring another mixed outing at Nagoya. India's Kabaddi players, both men and women, maintained their vice-like grip on Asian Games gold.

Indian women's kabaddi captain Pushpa Rana firmly believed in her raiding unit's ability to turn the tide, maintaining complete composure even as Iran's aggressive

gameplay temporarily dismantled her team's defense during their high-stakes gold medal match. That faith was rewarded as India held off a spirited Iran 37-34 to win a record-extending fourth women's kabaddi gold at the Asian Games, adding another chapter to their dominance since the sport's introduction at the 2010 Guangzhou Games.

"Our raiders are outstanding. So, our main aim was that even if our defenders are going out, our raiders are a strong point. They will always come good," Pushpa Rana said after the victory.

The captain acknowledged that the expectation of gold had brought its own pressure, particularly for an Indian team accustomed to ruling the continental competition.

"Yes, silver is less than gold. Because every time the Indian team has played, it has always brought gold. So that pressure is always there," she said. "There was confidence from the whole country that we would bring gold. All the players had that hope. We were able to apply the practice that we had been working hard on. Our coaches have supported us so much. Our



federation has supported us so much," she said. A standout aspect of India's overall performance on the day was squash players Anahat Singh and Abhay Singh advancing to the

finals to stay in the hunt for gold as well as qualification spots in the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

Meanwhile, Barwal is also the fourth Indian marathon runner to have ever won a medal in the Asian Games. Chhota Singh and Surat Singh Mathur had won a gold and bronze respectively in the inaugural Asian Games in 1951 in New Delhi.

Soon after, India's kabaddi dominance was reaffirmed despite a tough challenge mounted by Iran in both the men's and women's finals. While the Indian men rallied

to prevail 40-34, the women clinched it 37-34 after a few anxious moments. It was the ninth overall gold for the men and fourth for women.

At the shooting range, the Indian trio of Tilottama Sen, Vidarsa Vinod and Ashi Chouksey won the silver medal in women's 50m rifle 3 positions team event.

The Indian team aggregated 1763 to finish second on the podium. China claimed the gold medal with a games record 1773, while Kazakhstan settled for the bronze with 1754 following a gruelling contest. Tilottama and Visarsa also

qualified for the individual finals but could not finish on the podium, ending fourth and fifth respectively.

Indian squash players showed brilliant form with teen sensation Anahat Singh, Vidarsa Vinod and Ashi Chouksey won the silver medal in women's 50m rifle 3 positions team event.

The 18-year-old Anahat, who is the reigning world junior champion, staged a remarkable comeback after being down 0-2 at one stage of the semifinal to register one of the biggest wins of her career.

It's last WC I am going to play for India: Kohli



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Indian batting superstar Virat Kohli has said that next year's ODI World Cup is going to be his last for the country and he is going to "leave everything out there" to win the trophy.

The 37-year-old, who now plays only one format, spoke to "JioStar" ahead of the ODI series against the West Indies starting here on Sunday. The World Cup will be hosted jointly by South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia.

"For me, it's the last World Cup I'm going to play for India. And that is my motivation. Like, you know, to leave everything out there. And of course, the goal is absolutely to win the World Cup. And whatever it takes, I'm absolutely ready," he asserted.

Kohli has been a part of an ODI World Cup-winning side, having played under Mahendra Singh Dhoni's captaincy in the 2011 edition of the tournament.

Kohli, who will turn 38 in November, said the intensi-

1st ODI: India eye game-time for young names, Ro-Ko readiness against West Indies

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Pressing issues like giving more game time to young names and the continued assessment of the preparedness of Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli will feature high on India's list during the three-match ODI series against the West Indies, beginning here on Sunday, with the shadow of ICC World Cup 2027 looming larger. India are scheduled to play between 14 to 20 ODIs (if a planned series vs SA before WC happens as per plan) ahead of the global showpiece, and they would want to make each one of them count to travel to South Africa with a settled 15.

It demands a three-layered approach. The first point will be to keep someone like Yashasvi Jaiswal in the 50-over scheme of things

Jaiswal played three

matches against Afghanistan, largely because of the absence of injured Kohli, which forced skipper Shubman Gill to bat a slot down the order at Number 3.

But in the ensuing one-dayers against England, Gill reclaimed his opening slot after Kohli's return but the whole sequence meant that Jaiswal was not even included in the squad.

Now that the left-hander has returned for this series, partially because Shreyas Iyer and Ishan Kishan are in Japan for the Asian Games duty, the management will think hard whether to pair him again with Rohit from match one or continue with the Rohit-Gill combination.

That brings us to Rohit. Rohit temporarily shushed the clamour around his future with a typically marauding hundred against England at the Lord's.

More than anyone else,



Rohit will be keen to carry on and stitch some more big scores because, more than anyone else, he will be aware that daggers will be out again in the first instance of a failure. In contrast, Kohli stands on a firmer ground and will be eager to score 51 runs to become the second batter to score 15000 ODI runs after Sachin Tendulkar.

The way both Kohli and

to have more real match experience under their belt.

Bowling coach Morne Morkel too stressed on that point the other day, and Brar would also certainly want to improve his economy rate which at present hovers around seven.

The news of Hardik Pandya's fresh injury might have come as a dampener for all concerned, but that has also increased the significance of Nitish Kumar Reddy finding his range in top level cricket in white ball formats.

While his batting has more of a rounded touch about it, Reddy's bowling is still a work in progress.

The 23-year-old is yet to bowl 10 overs across six ODIs and he could just get a chance to go through the full spell in this rubber.

Morkel underlined the importance of Reddy developing that long-spell skill.

"It will be great for Indian

cricket if we can develop him, keep on developing him and for him to compete for that all-rounder spot. He's got all the talent and all the ability to do that. Luckily we do have a bit of time now," said Morkel.

"He always wants to be the guy that wants to create opportunities and having that mindset is fantastic.

"For us it's just again important to manage him quite well, to give him quite a simple role in terms of what he needs to go and do for the team," he added.

From the West Indies perspective, they should forget the disappointment of losing back-to-back home ODI series against New Zealand and Sri Lanka by close margins.

They are also dealing with a recent 25 per cent pay cut announced by Cricket West Indies to bring in "financial stability."

(PTI)

It's not that somebody is unfair to Jaiswal, but he has to work hard and wait for opportunity: Kotak

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Batting coach Sitanshu Kotak on Saturday hinted that India's first-choice opening pair will be Rohit Sharma and Shubman Gill, but said that should not be viewed as an "unfair" treatment of Yashasvi Jaiswal, urging him to keep on working hard on his game.

Jaiswal played the three-match ODI series against Afghanistan at home but was not included in the squad for the subsequent tour to England.

But the left-hander has again been drafted into the 15 for the ODIs against the West Indies, beginning here



on Sunday.

"I think there is so much competition (for team spots) and so many players are performing. Jaiswal...we all know he is one of the best batters and whenever he gets an opportunity he performs. So he is part of the team," Kotak told reporters on the eve of the first ODI.

"As a support staff, we look after his skills, practise and his mindset and Gautam (Gambhir) also talks to him a lot, but sometimes

you see, say if (for example) there are three very good wicketkeepers, only one can play," Kotak said alluding that Jaiswal still has to bid his time for more regular chances in the 50-over format.

"So, it is not that somebody has been unfair to him. He should keep working hard and waiting for the opportunity and so far whenever he has been getting the opportunity, he has performed," he added.

The ambition of Rohit and Kohli to play in 2027 WC is also carrying Jaiswal forward, and Kotak sees a lot of value in their presence in dressing room on road to South Africa.

(PTI)

Shubman has perspective to lead India in right way: Virat Kohli



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

India captain Shubman Gill received a big vote of confidence from the legendary Virat Kohli who has found the right perspective and intensity in him to lead the team for a long time to come.

Kohli, speaking to JioStar ahead of India's first ODI against West Indies on Sunday, shared his thoughts on the current national skipper and also decoded his changed batting approach.

"Shubman, the captain, is still learning. He is still young in the role, but he has got the right perspective and the right kind of intensity to lead the Indian team," Kohli told the broadcasters ahead of the series. What Kohli finds impressive is Gill's clarity while devising strategy and intent to do things in a right manner. "He (Gill) has got his plans very clear in terms of how he looks at us operating in the field. Of course, with more experience and understanding situations, the kind of calls you take are things

that he will keep working on and improving, which everyone does in a leadership role," Kohli was effusive in his praise.

"But he has got the desire to lead the Indian cricket team in the right way, which is the most important factor. So, I see him leading for a long time, and he will be absolutely fine," he added.

Kohli has felt that Gill has the ability to stay a step ahead of his opposition.

"He thinks of ways to get batters out in the field, which is always a sign of doing something different or staying a step ahead. He is not shy to use different kinds of fields, put guys under pressure, communicate the same to the bowlers, and bring in a certain kind of bowling attack," Kohli said. The soon-to-be 38 Kohli has been in phenomenal form during the last 10 ODIs in which he has scored three centuries, one 90 plus knock and four fifties.

Virat Kohli has looked fresh and rejuvenated as a one-format player in the last 18 months.

Hardik Pandya suffers fresh shin injury, out of New Zealand series

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

Senior all-rounder Hardik Pandya has sustained a fresh injury to his right shin which is all set to rule him out of competitive cricket for at least three weeks including the white ball tour of New Zealand. Pandya's 'Return To Play' date was set for September 20 and accordingly the selectors picked him for India A for the upcoming One Day series against Australia A starting October 6.

"This is very unfortunate but Hardik's latest scan reports have revealed an injury to his right shin. He has been advised complete rest for a period of two



weeks. BCCI's medical panel head Dr Dinshaw Pardiwala has seen his reports and on

anonymity. The New Zealand T20I series starts on October 22, followed by ODI series. There is no chance of Hardik making a comeback by then.

It is understood that BCCI wanted Pandya to travel with the squad to Japan for Asian Games and BCCI's operations team had taken his passport for visa related work.

However just before the start of the Afghanistan T20 series, he suddenly developed a shooting pain around his knee while doing his fielding drills. He in fact took a break and decided to take a few days' rest. However just as he was ready to get fit certificate, the pain resurfaced and

scans revealed that there is an injury.

The 32 year old Pandya is based out of Bengaluru since the end of IPL and now trains at the Centre of Excellence having relocated to the Garden City.

But over the course of last four months, at least thrice (Afghanistan ODIs, England T20Is and now Australia A), the all-rounder has suffered a fresh niggle which has proved to be an impediment towards his comeback. With New Zealand series also out of his way, Pandya will now have to wait for the Zimbabwe ODIs if he is fit to play or perhaps check his fitness in Vijay Hazare or Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy.

(PTI)

Playing India in their backyard is a challenge, need to grasp and embrace it: WI skipper Hope

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Thiruvananthapuram

West Indies skipper Shai Hope on Tuesday conceded that playing against India at the latter's backyard is a massive challenge but urged his players to "embrace" the hard task.

Hope will shepherd a team filled with some experienced stars and a few promising stars into a three-match series against India, starting here from Sunday.

"Playing India in their backyard is always a challenge. It's one that we definitely need to grasp and embrace. It's a great indicator for us to see where we are as a team," Hope said in the pre-match press

conference. "But it's something that we always look forward to when you're playing international cricket. You want to play against the best in their home conditions, and you get the real test. So, we're definitely looking forward to it, and it's going to be an exciting one for us," he added.

In fact, Hope can tell that from his own experience as he is one of the rare visiting batters to have mastered the Indian conditions.

The 32-year-old has played 26 ODIs against India, making 988 runs at an average of 47 with three hundreds and five fifties.

If one further filters that stats, the right-hander has played 14 ODIs in India,



scoring an astonishing 741 runs at an average of 74.1 with three hundreds and as many fifties.

So, what's Hope's secret of success against India?

"I pride myself a lot on trying to be the best I can be.

One of those things, you have to be able to adapt to different conditions, and play against different oppo-

sitions. It's not always going to work out. Every day is not going to be your day.

"But I really try to focus on the fine details to give myself the best chance to score runs. Here in India, you're going to play differently as if you're going to in Australia, or even back in the Caribbean. It's just about being very critical with the way you go about your training and preparation.

"That's something I always try to put up there in the team rooms whenever we have our chats and discussions. Hopefully, some of the guys will never be here before, and get a good start to their Indian career. This is one tour you look forward to. When I was younger in

my career, it was a tour I was expecting a lot from myself," he added. West Indies have not won an ODI series in India since 2002 when Carl Hooper's side beat them 4-3 in a seven-match affair.

Hope looked for a change in that script.

"The harsh reality is that almost every series that we go into, those stats are always at the top of the list. We always say we haven't beaten this team in 20 years or 15 years. It will definitely be adding motivation.

"We know it's going to be a tough battle, but we're looking forward to this one," he said.

Hope also placed faith on a capable spin attack -

Roston Chase, Gudakesh Moti and Vitel Lawes - to do well on this trip and beyond.

"The spinners that we have on this trip...the experience of Ross then and Moti, they have played quite a few games, and they have a big impact for West Indies over the last few years. Obviously, Lawes is coming into the game, like he's been shown what he's capable of at this level." "So, it's a great indication that he can continue along those lines. But I expect him to keep growing as a left-arm spinner, as a wrist spinner, and he can be an asset for us going forward. We are leaning on them here," Shai Hope concluded.

(PTI)



All that glitters is stitched

In the old royal courts, gold sat on the neck and pearls were sewn into silk. Awigna's Zevar carries that craft into modern wedding wear

SAKSHI PRIYA

Historically, royal Indian courts maintained a strict hierarchy of adornment. Heavy gold and uncut diamonds rested over handwoven silks, keeping textile and jewel as two entirely separate entities of power. The artisan painted the canvas with thread, while the goldsmith provided the solid armour. Today, that ancient boundary shatters completely.

Zevar, the new collection from Delhi label Awigna, brings those two crafts together. Marking a significant shift in festive couture, the newest line in a med Zevar steps onto the

runway. The word translates to jewellery. The creators made sure these garments absorb this historical language directly into the fabric itself. Master craftspeople translated the delicate motifs of fine ornaments into surface embroidery. Think about the heavy bangles, intricate chokers or heavy armbands women traditionally wear. Instead of layering separate metal pieces, these exact motifs are now intricately woven down the sheer sleeves and necklines using thick pearls, light catching Swarovski elements and cut crystals. The depth here is completely intentional. Anchoring these gems deeply into the weave gives every silhouette a striking three dimensional glow. This design choice frees the wearer from the physical burden of heavy antique sets, because the clothes do the work of the jewellery. The visual narrative reveals a beautiful balance between historic weight and modern lightness.

"Opening our Delhi flagship marks a special chapter, bringing Awigna's collections and Zevar's intricate Jewellery-Inspired craftsmanship closer to our community."

-Varsha and Ritu Aggarwal, Co-Founders of Awigna

HOW TO WEAR IT THIS WEDDING SEASON

- Go easy on the real jewellery. The outfit is already doing that job. A pair of studs or one good ring is plenty. Let the embroidery be your necklace.
- Keep the hair simple. A sleek low bun or soft open waves will show off all that detailing far better than a busy hairdo.
- Think past the main day. Soft colours and a lighter touch make these pieces perfect for a day mehendi, a cocktail night or your sister's sangeet. And you'll want to wear them again next season.
- Let the makeup follow the palette. Fresh, dewy skin and a soft lip suit pale shades much better than a heavy smoky eye. The shine is already coming from the clothes.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR



Vivid bridal golds appeared heavily laden with golden encrustations and veiled in sheer netting. Traditional opulence found an airy counterpoint in soft blush peach ensembles featuring sweeping, meticulously beaded jackets where the sleeves glisten like stacked bracelets. Deep emerald greens offered striking evening alternatives, particularly a slick draped skirt paired with a crystal fringed crop top alongside a dramatic scalloped cape set. An ethereal pale ivory creation also commanded attention, featuring sleeves shimmering under fine metallic accents that mimic royal arm cuffs.

By treating embellishment as actual jewellery, the creators present a wonderfully crafted approach to modern festive dressing.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

The grandeur of the Indian wedding

TEAM VIVA

Indian weddings are rarely just ceremonies; they are occasions where tradition, family, fashion, food, hospitality and celebration come together on an extraordinary scale. From couture and jewellery to elaborate décor, destination venues and personalised experiences, the modern Indian wedding has become an expression of both heritage and aspiration. VanVivaha 2026 tapped into this culture of grandeur by bringing the many worlds of the Indian wedding under one roof- from bridal fashion and luxury jewellery to hospitality, destinations, décor and wedding technology.

Gurugram hosted VanVivaha 2026, billed as

the World's Largest Wedding Expo, on September 24 and 25 at A-DOT, Ambience Island. The inaugural edition brought together more than 150 exhibitors across 1,40,000 sq ft, including 70,000 sq ft of exhibition space and over 100 curated stalls.

Organised by Van Vivah Exptainment, founded by Tejwannt Singh Lamba, Jasleen Kaur Lamba, Sarthak Saini and Namhe Singh, the two-day event drew an estimated 2,000 to 2,500 visitors. What set VanVivaha apart was its attempt to bring the entire wedding ecosystem under one roof, structured around four pillars: Bridal Couture, Jewellery and Beauty; Wedding Planning, Hospitality and Destinations; Celebration, Décor and Experiences; and Luxury Lifestyle, Travel and Wedding Innovation. Visitors moved between fashion showcases, seminars, live entertainment and vendor stalls covering everything from trousseau and lehengas to yachts, destination tourism boards and wedding technology. This scale matters because India's wedding industry, valued at nearly \$33 billion in 2025 and projected to touch \$93 billion in the coming years, remains largely unorganised, with couture houses, decorators, planners and hospitality brands typically operating in silos. An expo of this size changes that equation in two clear ways.

For couples and families, it compresses months of scattered shopping and vendor-hunting into a single weekend. Instead of visiting a dozen showrooms across the city, a bride can compare bridal wear, jewellery and décor concepts side by side, catch live fashion shows for trend cues, and sit in on planning seminars, all while making direct contact with vendors rather than relying on word of mouth.

For businesses, the payoff is concentrated access to a qualified, high-intent audience. A stall at VanVivaha puts a jewellery brand or a destination-wedding resort in front of thousands of buyers actively planning weddings, generating leads that would otherwise take a season of scattered marketing to accumulate. It also opens doors to networking with fellow vendors, planners and hospitality groups, the kind of cross-referrals that keep India's wedding trade running.

INDIAN WEDDINGS HAVE EVOLVED FROM INTIMATE, TRADITION-LED CEREMONIES INTO ELABORATE CELEBRATIONS BLENDING HERITAGE, FASHION, HOSPITALITY, FOOD AND PERSONALISED EXPERIENCES, REFLECTING CHANGING LIFESTYLES

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR



Behind every face

Twenty-four artists, Krishen Khanna and Anjolie Ela Menon among them, read the human face differently

ART CORNER



TEAM VIVA

The human face reveals everything about who we are and what we have experienced. This beautiful idea forms the foundation of *HEADS: Every Face Holds a Story*, an exhibition organised by Nayan Naveli Gallery at Shridharani Gallery in New Delhi.

Amrita Kochhar put this show together by gathering twenty-four artists across different generations. Seeing paintings by Krishen Khanna, Jogen Chowdhury, Jatin Das, and Anjolie Ela Menon together shows how they use human faces to document actual life stories. They join a massive lineup of over twenty other artists, like Sakti Burman and Arpana Caur, sharing this single exhibition space right now. Every artwork seems to map out the real, lived history of a person, leaving a permanent record of the miles they have traveled. Some stick to the strict discipline of classic portraiture, while others abandon those rules entirely to let features blur into a fleeting memory. Brand new commissions sit easily next to older works where you can instantly spot the familiar hand of a master.

KAOchhar arranged the gathering to honour her late mother, Manjit Kochhar, who spent her life in medicine and public service. This personal history changes the gallery's atmosphere completely. It provides a rare warmth that large group shows almost never achieve, making every painted expression on the wall feel like a quiet conversation waiting for a visitor to arrive and listen.

STRIKING FACES

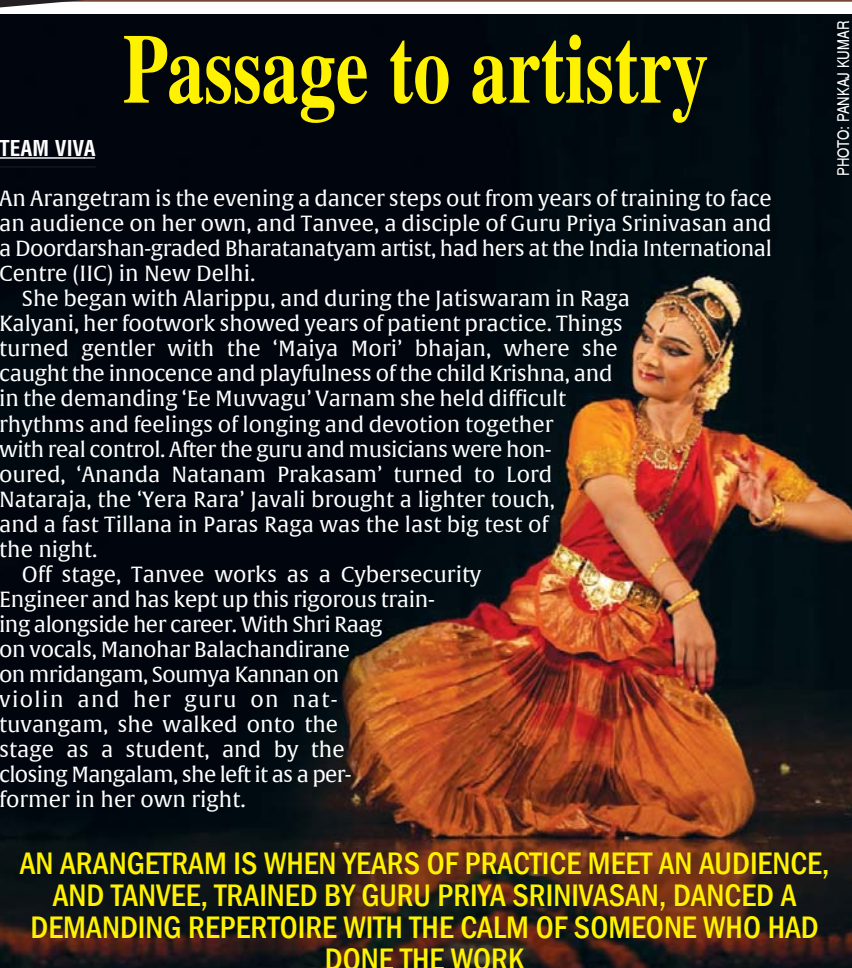
These paintings gather a really fascinating crowd of faces in one place. Every single expression seems to carry a heavy mood or a deeply private memory. A young face stands out because it is split right down the middle by harsh clashing colors. Another painting simply shows a woman clutching a blue elephant. It is an unusual detail for sure. Yet these paintings manage to dig right into the messy reality of childhood innocence and the complicated ways individuals figure out their true identities.






A handpan performance at the launch of 'HEADS - Every Face Holds a Story', a group exhibition

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR



PASSAGE TO ARTISTRY

TEAM VIVA

An Arangetram is the evening a dancer steps out from years of training to face an audience on her own, and Tanvee, a disciple of Guru Priya Srinivasan and a Doordarshan-graded Bharatanatyam artist, had hers at the India International Centre (IIC) in New Delhi.

She began with Alarippu, and during the Jatiswaram in Raga Kalyani, her footwork showed years of patient practice. Things turned gentler with the 'Maiya Mori' bhajan, where she caught the innocence and playfulness of the child Krishna, and in the demanding 'Ee Muvvagu' Varnam she held difficult rhythms and feelings of longing and devotion together with real control. After the guru and musicians were honoured, 'Ananda Natanam Prakasam' turned to Lord Nataraja, the 'Yera Rara' Javali brought a lighter touch, and a fast Tillana in Paras Raga was the last big test of the night.

Off stage, Tanvee works as a Cybersecurity Engineer and has kept up this rigorous training alongside her career. With Shri Raag on vocals, Manohar Balachandirane on mridangam, Soumya Kannan on violin and her guru on nattuvangam, she walked onto the stage as a student, and by the closing Mangalam, she left it as a performer in her own right.

AN ARANGETRAM IS WHEN YEARS OF PRACTICE MEET AN AUDIENCE, AND TANVEE, TRAINED BY GURU PRIYA SRINIVASAN, DANCED A DEMANDING REPERTOIRE WITH THE CALM OF SOMEONE WHO HAD DONE THE WORK

PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR

CINEMA

A VILLAGE THAT GROWS DAUGHTERS LIKE TREES

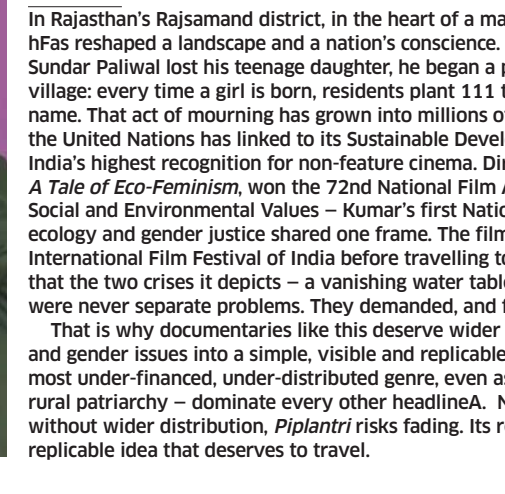
TEAM VIVA

In Rajasthan's Rajsamand district, in the heart of a marble-mining belt, a tradition born from grief hFas reshaped a landscape and a nation's conscience. Decades ago, after former sarpanch Shyam Sundar Paliwal lost his teenage daughter, he began a practice that has since transformed Piplantri village: every time a girl is born, residents plant 111 trees and open a savings account in her name. That act of mourning has grown into millions of trees, revived groundwater, and a template the United Nations has linked to its Sustainable Development Goals. This month, that story earned India's highest recognition for non-feature cinema. Director Suraj Kumar's documentary, *Piplantri: A Tale of Eco-Feminism*, won the 72nd National Film Award for Best Non-Feature Film Promoting Social and Environmental Values - Kumar's first National Award, and a rare moment when ecology and gender justice shared one frame. The film, which had its world premiere at the International Film Festival of India before travelling to Mumbai and, this month, Ireland, argues that the two crises it depicts - a vanishing water table and a dwindling regard for daughters - were never separate problems. They demanded, and found, a single solution.

That is why documentaries like this deserve wider promotion. Piplantri turns environmental and gender issues into a simple, visible and replicable solution. Documentary film remains India's most under-financed, under-distributed genre, even as its subjects - climate stress, water scarcity, rural patriarchy - dominate every other headline. A National Award offers a rare spotlight, but without wider distribution, *Piplantri* risks fading. Its real achievement is turning despair into a replicable idea that deserves to travel.



RAJAT
Best Non Feature Film Promoting Social and Environmental Values
Film - Piplantri - A Tale of Eco Feminism (Hindi, Rajasthani & English)
Director - Suraj Kumar



The \$4 bag that broke fashion week

TEAM VIVA

New York Fashion Week 2026 had its share of headline-making runway moments, but one of the season's most talked-about accessories came from an unlikely source: Burger King. The fast-food chain turned its revamped chicken nuggets into Le Nugguette, a tiny nugget-shaped purse that brought food and fashion together. Each bag came with a charm inspired by one of four sauces - Honey Mustard, Buffalo, Sweet and Sour or the new Special Savoury - along with a code for a four-piece nugget order, all for \$3.99. Only 100 were sold online daily from September 12 to 16, totalling 500. They disappeared within seconds, leaving plenty of fans empty-handed. The limited drop quickly sparked jokes online, with some comparing the \$4 nugget bag's scarcity to the coveted Birkin. Others called it one of fashion month's funniest accessory moments. The stunt joins a growing list of non-fashion brands entering runway territory, including Saratoga Spring Water's bottle-lanyard collaboration with Public School New York. Apparently, you do not need a luxury label to create a coveted bag - just a clever idea and a well-timed nugget.







Beyond punishment: Giving children in conflict with law a second chance



Last week, as I walked into a protection home to meet children in conflict with the law, I expected to speak to them about drugs, discipline and the choices that can shape their future. I carried with me the familiar concerns of a police officer: the dangers of substance abuse, peer pressure, crime and the challenges of returning to a normal life after coming into conflict with the law. But within minutes of meeting them, the conversation began to change the way I was looking at the issue. Some were quiet and hesitant; others looked at me with curiosity. Yet beneath those different expressions, I could see something common: they were children before they were anything else: children with fears, insecurities, aspirations and dreams. It made me reflect on a question that extends well beyond policing or juvenile justice: when these children eventually walk out of a protection home, what do we want them to become?

Do we want them to carry the burden and stigma of their past indefinitely, or do we want them to return as confident, skilled, self-reliant and responsible citizens? For me, the answer is clear. A mistake made by a child cannot be allowed to become the child's entire identity. This does not mean ignoring accountability. Children must understand that actions have consequences and that the law has to take its course. But accountability and abandonment are not the same. A humane justice system must protect society while preserving the possibility of reform and redemption.

This becomes particularly important when we consider substance abuse among young people. Addiction rarely begins by announcing itself as an addiction. It may start with curiosity, peer pressure, loneliness, emotional distress or the simple desire to belong. A friend says, "Try it once." What appears to be an experiment can gradually become a habit and eventually a dependency. That is perhaps the most insidious nature of drugs: they often enter a young person's life disguised as a friend,

before revealing themselves as an enemy. By the time their consequences become visible, they may already have damaged education, health, family relationships, finances and judgement. In some cases, dependency can also become a pathway to theft, violence, trafficking and other forms of crime.

The fight against drugs, therefore, cannot be left to the police and the criminal justice system. Prevention must begin much earlier: in families, schools and communities. Telling children simply to "stay away from drugs" is not enough. They need the confidence to refuse, the resilience to withstand peer pressure and the awareness to seek help when they are vulnerable. We must teach them that courage does not mean doing what everyone else is doing. Sometimes, real courage lies in standing apart from the crowd and saying, "No, I will not do this."

For those who have already experimented with drugs or are struggling with dependency, our message must be equally clear: their lives are not over. They do not need to hide in shame; they need support. Counselling, medical assistance, psychological care, family engagement and a positive environment can help a young person regain control. Asking for help should never be seen as weakness. It is often the first act of responsibility towards oneself and one's future.

This is why our approach towards children in conflict with the law must extend beyond punishment to reform, rehabilitation and reintegration. A protection home should not merely be a place where a child waits for a prescribed period to end. It should become a bridge between a difficult past and a more hopeful future. Education must be at its centre. Children whose schooling has been interrupted should be helped to resume it wherever possible, while vocational and technical training should be available to those who need alterna-

tive pathways. Computer skills, electrical work, mechanics, agriculture, tailoring, culinary skills, handicrafts and other employable abilities can provide young people with economic independence. Skill is not merely a means of earning a livelihood; it is also a means of restoring dignity and self-worth.

Rehabilitation, however, cannot be reduced to classrooms and employment. Many children carry anger, loneliness, insecurity, rejection or emotional distress. Counselling and life-skills education must therefore accompany formal learning. Sports, yoga, meditation, music and creative activities can develop discipline, confidence and emotional balance. Anger management deserves particular attention because some offences are not the result of carefully planned criminal intent but of a few uncontrolled moments. Young people should learn to pause before reacting, step away from confrontation and ask themselves a simple question: "Will what I am about to do make my future better or worse?" Sometimes, a few seconds of restraint can prevent years of regret.

CONTINUED ON >> P11

From delinquency to reintegration: Can juvenile homes break the cycle of crime?



When a child commits a crime, society is often quick to ask a familiar question: what punishment should follow? Juvenile justice requires a different question: what happens to the child after the offence?

That distinction lies at the heart of India's juvenile justice framework. The Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015 does not treat a child in conflict with the law simply as an offender requiring confinement. Its architecture is built around care, protection, development, rehabilitation and social reintegration. The real challenge is whether this philosophy survives beyond the

statute book.

The Supreme Court's judgment in Sampurna Behrua v Union of India remains a foundational authority in this area. The Court dealt extensively with the inadequate implementation of juvenile justice legislation and directed States to strengthen the institutional framework for children, including Juvenile Justice Boards, Child Welfare Committees, Observation Homes and Special Juvenile Police Units. But the significance of Sampurna Behrua goes beyond infrastructure.

The Court emphasised the importance of individual care plans and post-release plans and recognised the crucial role of Probation Officers in understanding the child's circumstances, facilitating rehabilitation and preparing the child for reintegration. The Court also stressed training and sensitisation of those responsible for implementing the juvenile justice system. This leads to an important legal question: can rehabilitation be achieved merely by placing a child inside a juvenile home?

The answer should be no. The Supreme Court's recent judgment in Prajwala v Union of India provides a contemporary reaffirmation of this principle. The Court explained that rehabilitation and social reintegration under the JJ Act are to be undertaken in accordance with the child's individual care plan and, preferably, through family-based care.

The judgment also makes an important point that is sometimes forgotten: the State's responsibility does not end when institutional care ends. Section 46 of the JJ Act provides for after-care support for children leaving child-care institutions. Rehabilitation therefore has to continue beyond the walls of the institution. If a child leaves a juvenile home and returns to the same circumstances that con-

tributed to the original offending behaviour, the possibility of rehabilitation becomes weaker.

The family, therefore, cannot be treated as an afterthought. Where appropriate, family counselling, parental involvement and restoration should form part of the rehabilitation process. Bihar's recent experience demonstrates why implementation matters as much as legislation.

In 2026, the Patna High Court, while examining the implementation of the Supreme Court's directions in Sampurna Behrua, questioned the State's compliance with the requirement of dedicated Special Juvenile Police Units and exclusive cadres of Child Welfare Police Officers. In its June 18, 2026 proceedings, the Court recorded that Bihar had 20 functional Observation Homes, five Places of Safety and one Special Home, with a stated capacity of about 1,300 children, while 1,898 children were residing in these institutions. The Court directed the State to take steps to establish the required institutions across districts and also addressed vacancies and institutional staffing.

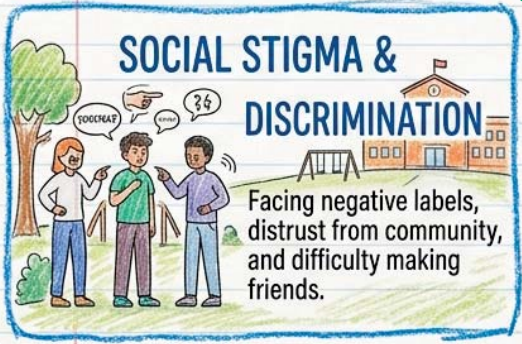
The proceedings expose a fundamental problem: a rehabilitative law cannot work through inadequate institutional capacity. But the larger lesson remains: juvenile justice cannot be measured merely by the existence of buildings. The quality, staffing and nature of rehabilitation provided inside them matter equally.

There is another lesson from the Supreme Court's jurisprudence. A child should not be permanently defined by the offence committed during adolescence. The JJ Act incorporates the principle of fresh start in Section 3 and seeks to prevent unnecessary stigma. This is not merely a compassionate approach. It recognises the developmental nature of childhood and the possibility of behavioural change. The ultimate test of the system, therefore, should not be how many children were housed in juvenile homes. It should be how many children returned to education, acquired skills, rebuilt family relationships and remained outside the criminal justice system. The law has already moved beyond punishment. The real question is whether our juvenile justice system has moved beyond custody. From delinquency to reintegration, the journey cannot end at the gate of a juvenile home.

The writer is a practising advocate and specialises in international law, corporate law and cyber law



CHALLENGES FACED BY JUVENILES AFTER LEAVING JUVENILE HOME



THE JUVENILE JUSTICE SYSTEM IN INDIA

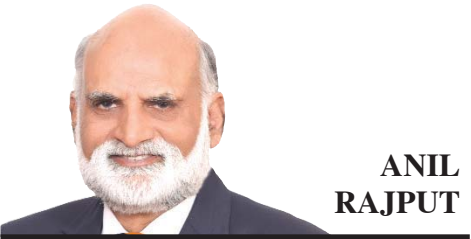
IT FOCUSES ON REHABILITATION, CARE AND SOCIAL REINTEGRATION RATHER THAN RETRIBUTIVE PUNISHMENT. ROOTED IN CONSTITUTIONAL PROVISIONS, SUCH AS ARTICLE 15, WHICH ALLOWS SPECIAL PROTECTIONS FOR CHILDREN, AND ALIGNED WITH THE UNITED NATIONS CONVENTION ON THE RIGHTS OF THE CHILD (UNCRC), THE SYSTEM TREATS YOUNG OFFENDERS AS INDIVIDUALS WHO LACK ADULT EMOTIONAL AND COGNITIVE MATURITY



“EAT BEAUTIFUL FOODS, WHICH ARE
NUTRITIONALLY DENSE, WHOLESOME
AND NATURAL”
— BRYANT MCGILL

PITRU PAKSHA

The cuisine that keeps ancestral memory alive



ANIL
RAJPUT

What does a family cook for someone who is no longer sitting at the table? Few observances in India answer that question as intimately as Pitru Paksha. Here, food is not prepared for spectacle, indulgence or celebration. It is cooked as remembrance. A bowl of kheer may recall a parent's favourite sweet, a particular vegetable may reproduce the way a grandmother once made it, and rice shaped by hand may become an offering to generations whose names still live within the family. In Pitru Paksha, the kitchen becomes one of the places where memory is given form.

In 2026, Pitru Paksha begins on Sunday, 27 September, with Pratipada Shraddha, and concludes on Saturday, 10 October, with Sarva Pitru Amavasya. Purnima Shraddha falls a day earlier, on 26 September, which explains why the beginning is sometimes shown differently in calendars. The fortnight is devoted to remembering departed ancestors through Shraddha, tarpan, pind daan, charity and the offering of food. Rather than following one fixed ceremony across India, families generally observe the tithi associated with an ancestor's passing, while Sarva Pitru Amavasya provides an occasion to remember ancestors collectively.

Observed across much of India, Pitru Paksha takes different forms according to region and community, from pind daan traditions in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh and Mahalaya observances in Bengal to distinctive Shraddha meals in Maharashtra and ancestral rites across southern India. The roots of the observance lie in the Hindu idea of acknowledging the debt owed to those who came before us. Sacred traditions connect Pitru Paksha with several stories, including that of Karna, whose legendary generosity in life had centred on gold and wealth rather than food. After death, he is said to have realised the importance of offering nourishment in memory of one's ancestors. The story gave anna daan, the giving of food, an enduring place in the cultural imagination surrounding Shraddha. Gaya in Bihar became one of the most important centres for these rites, particularly around the Falgu River and Vishnupad Temple, and tradition also associates the city with Rama and Sita performing ancestral rites for King Dasharatha.

That history helps explain why the cuisine of Pitru Paksha cannot be separated from the ritual itself. In many homes the food is freshly prepared, vegetarian and sattvic, although the precise rules vary considerably by region, community and family. Onion and garlic are commonly omitted. Some households also avoid particular pulses, vegetables or seasonings, while the same ingredients may appear in another region's Shraddha meal. What matters is that the food is prepared deliberately, offered before it is eaten and often shared with Brahmins, guests or people in need. In many traditions

portions are also set aside for cows, dogs and crows, with the crow carrying a particularly strong association with the ancestors.

At the centre of the ritual are pindas, usually formed from cooked rice or barley and combined, according to tradition, with ingredients such as black sesame, ghee, milk or honey. These compact offerings are not everyday food. Their importance lies in what they represent. The hand that shapes the rice is linking an ordinary grain, one of India's most fundamental foods, with lineage and remembrance. Black sesame, too, appears repeatedly in ancestral rites, particularly in tarpan, where water and sesame are offered with prayers for the departed. Food in Pitru Paksha therefore begins not with appetite but with meaning.

Once the ritual offering moves into the Shraddha meal, chawal ki kheer is among the most enduring preparations. Rice is simmered slowly in milk until the grains soften and the liquid thickens, then gently sweetened and perfumed, often with cardamom. It is familiar across India, but within Shraddha its simplicity acquires a different purpose. Maharashtra has its own tandalachi kheer, again built around rice and milk but belonging to a distinct ritual thali and household tradition.

Alongside kheer, lapsi gives the sweet side of the meal a very different texture. Broken wheat is patiently roasted and cooked with ghee and jaggery or sugar until the grains swell and become soft without losing their character. Its inclusion in traditional accounts of Shraddha food is significant because it reminds us that ancestral cuisine was never dependent on elaborate confectionery. Grain, ghee and sweetness were enough to make an offering worthy of the occasion. In parts of North India, pua performs a similar role. Flour is mixed into a lightly sweet batter, sometimes enriched with fennel or milk, and fried into soft-edged discs. Some families make malpua, its richer cousin, particularly where it belongs to an inherited family tradition. The sweets can extend further without becoming excessive. Atta halwa, made by roasting wheat flour patiently in ghee before adding hot water and sugar, brings the aroma of toasted grain to the meal. Til-gud laddoo, where sesame and jaggery are bound together, draws on an ingredient already associated with ancestral ritual. In Maharashtra, puran poli and god shevaya, sweet vermicelli cooked with milk or jaggery depending



on household practice, may also find a place in a Mahalaya Shraddha meal. The choice is not always governed by a universal rule. In many families, the most meaningful sweet is simply the one the departed person loved. A favourite recipe then becomes part of the ritual vocabulary of remembrance.

The savoury half of the meal is often even more revealing because it follows the produce, climate and habits of different regions. Kaddu ki khatti-meethi sabzi is a familiar Shraddha preparation in parts of North India, with pumpkin cooked until tender and balanced with gentle sourness and sweetness. Rather than relying on onion and garlic for depth, the dish draws flavour from the vegetable itself and from a restrained use of spices. Arbi ki sukhi sabzi works in much the same spirit. Colocasia is boiled or fried until its edges take colour, then seasoned so that its earthy character remains central.

Seasonal gourds and vegetables broaden the plate. Turai ki sabzi, made from ridge gourd, is soft and lightly spiced, while lauki ki sabzi turns bottle gourd into a gentle accompaniment rather than an aggressively seasoned curry. Kacche kele ki sabzi, prepared from raw banana, provides a firmer, starchier element and is especially useful in kitchens avoiding the usual dependence on potatoes. Suran or jimikand ki sabzi brings yet another texture, its dense flesh cooked carefully until tender. Parwal ki sabzi, using pointed gourd, and gawar phali, made from cluster beans, extend the meal further into the seasonal vegetable repertoire. Pumpkin and guar in particular have long

appeared in descriptions of Shraddha food, showing how strongly the observance remains tied to relatively humble produce.

Travel west and the same idea of remembrance produces a rather different plate. A Maharashtrian Shraddha meal may include lal bhopyachi bhaji, a preparation of red pumpkin, beside gawarichi bhaji made from cluster beans. Karlyachi bhaji, using bitter melon, brings deliberate bitterness into a meal otherwise full of mild flavours, while methichi bhaji contributes the fragrance and slight bitterness of fenugreek leaves. Bhendichi bhaji, prepared from okra, may also be part of the spread. These are not dishes selected because they conform to a modern idea of festive luxury. Their importance comes from continuity, from being cooked because this is how the family's Shraddha meal has been made before.

Maharashtra also gives the observance several preparations that immediately make the thali more distinctive. Patvadi, made by cooking seasoned gram flour into a thick mixture, setting it and cutting it into pieces, adds substance without depending on elaborate ingredients. Aluchi vadi layers colocasia leaves with a spiced gram-flour paste before rolling, steaming and slicing them. Depending on household practice, the pieces may be served steamed or given a further tempering. Amsulachi chutney, built around kokum and jaggery, creates a sharp sweet-sour counterpoint, while mirchiche panchamrut combines chilli with sourness, sweetness and spice into a concentrated accompaniment. Even the word panchamrut can mean different preparations in different ritual contexts, which is why family knowledge remains essential to understanding what appears on a particular Shraddha leaf.

Fried foods also appear in several regional traditions, although they are far from uniform. Maharashtrian meals may include chana dal vada, urad dal vada or traditional bharda vada, crisp outside and softer within, while some North Indian families prepare their own forms of vada or phulori. This is precisely where Pitru Paksha resists simplification. Some traditions avoid particular pulses that others incorporate into ancestral meals. Neither practice needs to be treated as the national rule. The contrast is a reminder that ancestral food follows inherited custom, and that the authority of the household kitchen can be as

important as the recipe itself.

Further south, the same ancestral logic enters a rice-based ritual vocabulary. In Telugu and other South Indian Pitru Karma traditions, gaarelu or vada may be prepared for naivedyam, while payasam supplies the sweet element and dadhyodanam, seasoned curd rice, may accompany rice and simple vegetable preparations. These should not be treated as a standard menu for every southern household, but their presence shows how ancestral cuisine adapts to regional staples without losing its central grammar: freshly prepared food, offering before eating and remembrance through feeding.

Beverages are similarly restrained. Pitru Paksha does not possess a pan-Indian festive drink comparable to thandai at Holi or the elaborate milk drinks associated with some other observances. Water is the most significant liquid because of tarpan, where water offered with sesame carries ritual meaning. At the meal itself, households may serve milk, chaas or buttermilk, or occasionally a simple seasonal drink according to regional custom and the rules followed by the family. In some homes, even a departed relative's preferred everyday drink may become part of remembrance. The absence of an elaborate beverage tradition is meaningful in itself. This is cuisine shaped by purpose rather than display.

After the food has been offered and shared, the meal returns to the living. That sequence matters. Feeding others, giving food in charity and preparing a meal for Brahmins or invited guests have traditionally formed part of Shraddha because remembrance is expressed through nourishment. The kitchen therefore connects ritual with social responsibility. Food prepared for those who have died ultimately feeds those who are present, transforming memory into an act of generosity.

That may be why Pitru Paksha cuisine deserves to be preserved with particular care. It is easy to record the name of a dish. It is harder to preserve why a certain vegetable was always cooked on Shraddha day, how a pua batter should fall from the spoon, when the kheer has reduced enough, why sesame enters the offering, which recipe belonged to a grandmother, or which sweet a father always asked for. These are details that disappear quietly when nobody learns them.

Passing this cuisine to the next generation therefore means more than handing down recipes. It means inviting children and young adults into the kitchen, telling them whose food is being prepared and why, showing them how the offering is arranged, and allowing them to understand that remembrance can live through taste as surely as it lives through photographs and stories. Pitru Paksha asks the living to look backwards, but its traditions survive only when they are carried forward. If every family teaches one more generation how its ancestral meal is made, the kitchen will continue to do what it has done for centuries: keep memory at the table, even when those we remember can no longer sit beside us.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

COFFEE CULTURE

What is brewing in India?

Around International Coffee Day, coffee is taking centre stage, evolving into a culture of craft, choice and personal taste

GYANESHWAR DAYAL

Not very long ago, a “coffee kit” in most Indian homes meant a jar of instant granules and a spoon. Today, it is as likely to mean a hand grinder, a pour-over dripper, a digital scale and a shelf of single-origin beans from Coorg. Morning coffee has become something people make for themselves — measured, timed and adjusted until it tastes the way they want it to. The shift didn't happen overnight. Third-wave cafés that opened across Indian cities over the last decade first taught a generation to tell a washed process from a natural one, an Arabica from a Robusta — building the palate before anyone thought to recreate it at home. What has sustained the habit is infrastructure that didn't exist a decade ago.



Direct-to-consumer roasters now ship freshly roasted, traceable beans from Karnataka's and Kerala's coffee belts

“HOME BREWING IS BECOMING A DEEPLY PERSONAL AND EXPERIMENTAL EXPERIENCE. PEOPLE EXPLORE DIFFERENT ORIGINS, ADJUST GRIND SIZES AND WATER TEMPERATURES, AND DISCOVER HOW BREWING METHODS CAN TRANSFORM THE SAME COFFEE. THEY BEGIN SOURCING MICRO-LOTS, FOLLOWING ROASTERS AND DEVELOPING THEIR PALATE. THIS SENSE OF OWNERSHIP TURNS A DAILY HABIT INTO A REWARDING CRAFT.”

— Abhinav Mathur, Founder & MD, Something's Brewing

straight to a customer's door — cutting out the old route where India's best coffee went abroad while its own drinkers made do with the rest. Grinders and drippers once bought on trips to Europe are now sold by Indian brands at Indian prices. And Instagram reels are turning brewing technique into something anyone can watch, copy and improve on. The good in this goes beyond caffeine. For the first time, it is ordinary Indian drinkers, not only foreign buyers, who are deciding what good Indian coffee should taste like — a shift that rewards growers for quality rather than volume. It has also made coffee personal rather than prescribed: a home brewer tunes grind, ratio and roast to their own palate in a way no instant sachet, and few café orders, ever allowed. Small roasters, subscription boxes and equipment makers have grown around it, turning a private ritual into a domestic industry.

The shift has also given rise to the home barista and the growing culture of dedicated coffee corners. As Abhinav Mathur, Founder of Something's Brewing, puts it, the home barista is no

longer a niche hobbyist. Consumers are creating curated coffee spaces at home, choosing their machines, grinders, cups, shelves and beans with the same intentionality they bring to a home office or wine rack. These spaces are becoming personal expressions of taste and lifestyle, turning coffee from a daily beverage into a craft and a form of identity. India isn't trading tea for coffee. Tea remains deeply rooted, but coffee is gaining a national identity as a drink of choice and craft. India isn't switching cups; it is simply learning to brew its own.



Turning Dim Sum into an art form



TEAM AGENDA

Dumplings have travelled a long way from their early roots in Chinese culinary history. Jiaozi, one of China's best-known dumplings, is believed to date back nearly 2,000 years, while the wider dim sum tradition evolved around tea-houses and the Cantonese practice of yum cha — combining tea, small bites and conversation. Over centuries, these delicate parcels became associated with family, celebration and togetherness.

As National Dumpling Day celebrates this much-loved food on September 26, its appeal lies in how easily tradition adapts to new tastes. At OKO, The LaLiT New Delhi, dim sum is treated as a ritual of sharing. The restaurant's Dumpling Diaries menu draws on Hong Kong's yum cha culture, inviting diners to slow down, share plates and linger over bamboo baskets. The menu spans familiar and adventurous flavours. On the non-vegetarian side, Xian Xia Jiu Cai Jiao — plump shrimp and chive dumplings — sit alongside the more unusual Xiangjiao Juan He Ta, river sole marinated in black bean sauce and wrapped in banana leaf.

Purists will gravitate toward the Xiao Long Bao, a Shanghai-style soup dumpling filled with chicken broth that bursts on the first bite, while the Yangrou Kao Baozi offers some-

thing heartier: a pillowy, open-faced bao stuffed with cumin-spiced lamb.

The Curry Pork Dumpling, doused in a rich, creamy Thai Bangkok curry sauce, is the most indulgent of the lot — an unapologetic fusion of Cantonese technique and Southeast Asian flavour.

Vegetarians are just as well looked after. The Luson Koumo Jiao pairs asparagus with button mushroom for a clean, earthy bite, and the Su Ji Jiao — a plant-based soya bean dumpling served with the same Thai curry dip — proves that vegan dim sum needn't feel like a compromise.

The Kao Baozi arrives filled with tempura enoki mushroom and a slick of spicy mayo, while the Si Xi Su Jiao channels a Cantonese

four-season medley of vegetables. For something with more bite, the Doumiao Mat Jiao brings Szechuan-spiced water chestnut and snow peas together in a satisfying crunch.

Executive Sous Chef Manish Prasad sums up the philosophy behind the menu: dim sum, he says, is rooted in craftsmanship, balance and the joy of sharing — and Dumpling Diaries was built to honour that tradition while layering in contemporary flavour and presentation.



A vibrant spread of bamboo basket dim sum, served with dipping sauces and colourful garnishes

“LOVE AND COMPASSION ARE NECESSITIES, NOT LUXURIES. WITHOUT THEM HUMANITY CANNOT SURVIVE”
— DALAI LAMA

A REVOLUTION OF LOVE

Today marks the 73rd birthday of Amma, Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, a global spiritual master and humanitarian born in a poor fishing village in Keralam

AMMA

The undefeatable power of compassion

I never think about my birthday. It is my children who wish to come together on this day to light lamps of love and devotion. But this is not the time for celebrations. This year, as humankind faces increasing crises, my wish is that it be a day of seva, shining a ray of hope for others. Across the world, my children are gathering to feed the poor, conduct public cleanup drives, plant trees, and meditate for world peace. Their selfless service is what makes me happy.

Once as a little girl, I was collecting food scraps from neighbouring homes and came upon an elderly woman lying alone in her hut. She was too weak to move, with no one to care for her. She was starving. The sight of that woman's suffering struck me like a lightning bolt. I ran home to gather food and clothing and brought them to her. As I fed her, she wept with gratitude.

At that moment, I understood something very clearly: God is not some distant figure sitting on a throne in the sky. God dwells in every being. Serving a suffering person is serving God. Wiping that elderly woman's tears became my purpose. From that point, nothing could hold me back.

Today, I have embraced more than 4 crore people across the world, but this did not begin intentionally. As a little girl, when I saw people crying, I just wiped away their tears. When they continued to weep, I embraced them and patted their backs. If they were still distressed, I let them lie in my lap to comfort them. Their sorrow became my sorrow. Their happiness became my happiness.

There are two types of poverty in the world. The first type is due to the lack of food, clothing, and shelter. The second type is the poverty of love and compassion. We need to deal with the second type of poverty first. When our hearts are filled with love and compassion, we will wholeheartedly help those who lack food, clothing, and shelter.

Whether or not God exists might be a source of debate, but no rational person can ever say that suffering humanity does not exist. We can see their suffering with our own eyes. Service to such people is worship of God. Let us pray that this self-sacrificing attitude awakens in hearts across the



Amma has given her darshan in the form of a motherly embrace to more than 4 crore people across the world.

Whether or not God exists might be a source of debate, but no rational person can ever say that suffering humanity does not exist.

— Amma

world. May we come to realise that the waters of love, compassion, selflessness, and sacrifice have not dried up in human hearts.

We must not let this world become a desert. We must not let love and compassion evaporate. If that happens, there will no longer be any human beings here. This beautiful world will become a forest filled with human animals.

If only our minds, eyes, ears, and hands could genuinely understand and feel the sorrow and pain of others. How many suicides could have been prevented? How many people could have been protected from exploitation and trafficking? How many wars in the name of power and money could have been avoided?

By calling out to God, we are planting the seeds of love. Even if only one flower blossoms in a desert, isn't it a beautiful sight? If one tree grows there, won't it give some shade? Sincere prayer is selfless love.

United in this love, we can become an

undefeatable power. When we work together, hand in hand with compassion, it is not just one life force, but the life energy of countless people that flows in harmony, unimpeded. From that constant stream of unity, real progress will take place, and we will see the birth of a world of peace.

If that is sincerely our goal, then there is only one path forward: we must usher in a revolution of love. It is a revolution that should happen first in the individual mind. From there, it must expand to one's home and community. The rest will happen spontaneously. If that goal is reached, our dreams of a noble world family will be fulfilled.

To this day, as long as there is enough strength to reach out to those who come to me, to place my hand on a crying person's shoulder, I will continue to embrace people. To lovingly caress them, to console and wipe their tears until the end of this mortal frame - this is my wish.

AMMA'S HUMANITARIAN IMPACT

64.6 lakh
people given ₹898 crore in free healthcare

48,000
homes built for those without one

2.5 lakh
women in 15,000 self-help groups

4.2 lakh
students reached with digital tutoring

55,000
rural children granted scholarships

2800
villages adopted across India

74 lakh
global participants in yoga & meditation

60 lakh
trees planted across the world



Amma comforts survivors of the 2004 Indian Ocean Tsunami. Her relief efforts came to more than ₹500 crore.

What does a prayer become when someone truly hears it?

BRAHMACHARINI RAJESWARI,
MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI MATH

It began in the poor fishing village where Amma was born in 1953. As a young girl, she helped all who came to her with their sorrows. Sharing food with hungry children at school. Caring for elderly abandoned by their families. Giving what little money she could to people in debt. As she wiped away the tears, their prayers became Amma's prayers.

Her humanitarian work begins with immediate aid for those who share their hardships. She then builds massive

humanitarian solutions that transcend political, regional, linguistic, and religious differences. Amma's initiatives have become a global spiritual and humanitarian movement that reaches more than 50 countries.

Amma truly embodies the ancient concept of Universal Motherhood. It is a love and compassion felt not only towards one's own children, but towards all people, animals and plants, rocks and rivers - a love extended to all of nature. Indeed, to a woman in whom the state of true motherhood has awakened, all creatures are her children.



After 12 hours of giving darshan in Kolkata, Amma and her team took to the streets to gather years of accumulated trash. Within three hours, a 3km stretch was clean again.

FROM AGENDA COVER

Beyond punishment: giving children in...

The influence of peers is equally significant. A positive friend can lift a young person, while a destructive group can pull him or her back into the circumstances from which rehabilitation sought to provide an escape. When children return to society, they therefore need continued support to build healthy relationships, find positive mentors and reconnect with their families and communities. Society, too, has a responsibility. If we repeatedly remind a young person of his past, we make it harder for him to build a future. Accountability is essential, but stigma should not become permanent. Trust may take time to rebuild, but the opportunity to rebuild it must remain open.

There is also a powerful possibility within this process. A young person who has experienced addiction, violence or criminal influence can eventually become one of the strongest voices against those very dangers. Someone who has known darkness can sometimes guide another towards light with an authenticity that no textbook can provide. A rehabilitated child can therefore become not merely a beneficiary of the system but, in time, an agent of prevention.

Additionally, this has a direct connection with nation-building. India is often described as a young nation and its youth as a demographic dividend. But a young population becomes a dividend only when it is educated, healthy, skilled, purposeful and given meaningful opportunities. Every child kept away from drugs, reconnected with education, equipped with skills and restored to a dignified life represents more than an individual success. It is an investment in the country's social stability and future.

Whenever a child comes into conflict with the law, we naturally ask, "What did the child do?" We must also ask, "What circumstances brought the child here?" More importantly, we should ask, "What can we do to ensure that the child does not return to those circumstances?" And ultimately: "How can we help this child become a responsible and productive citizen?" The answer requires the combined commitment of the police, juvenile justice institutions, families, schools, coun-

sellors, civil society and the community.

For policing, this calls for a broader understanding of success. Modern policing cannot be confined to responding to offences after they occur. Prevention, community trust and protection of vulnerable children must form an integral part of our mission. Our success should not be measured only by cases registered or offenders apprehended. It should also be measured by how many young lives we help redirect, away from drugs and violence, towards education, skills, dignity and opportunity.

When a child leaves a protection home, he or she should not leave merely with a certificate or a date of release. The child should leave with a plan for education or livelihood, the ability to make healthier choices, supportive relationships and, above all, faith in his or her own future. We must tell these children something that society sometimes forgets to tell them: your past may explain where you came from, but it does not have the right to decide where you will go. A mistake can be a chapter in your life without becoming the title of the entire book.

It is easy to label a child by an offence; it is harder to help that child become a responsible citizen. But a compassionate and democratic society must be willing to choose the harder path. Rehabilitation is not charity. It is an investment in public safety, social justice and nation-building. When a young person chooses dreams over drugs, discipline over anger, skills over dependency and responsibility over crime, society gains far more than a reformed individual. It gains a citizen.

Perhaps the most meaningful measure of rehabilitation is when a child who once needed protection grows into a young person capable of protecting another child from the very dangers he once faced. That is more than rehabilitation. That is transformation. And that is how a second chance given to one child can become an investment in the future of an entire society and of the nation.

Dr Kumar Ashish, IPS, DIG, Koshi Range, Saharsa, Bihar is known for pioneering people-centric policing initiatives such as AAWAZ DO, Nasha-Mukt Koshi Abhiyan, E-Bharosa, Coffee with SP, Thana Diwas and Rail Police Paathshala, with a focus on women's safety, digital policing, community engagement, drug abuse, youth empowerment and social justice

An officer's flight through turbulence

DEVSAGAR SINGH

Flight Into Turbulence and Safe Landing is an autobiography of MR Sivaraman, former Executive Director of the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and former Revenue Secretary to the Government of India.

Civil services in India are often associated with power and privilege, with officials administering their respective domains as largely faceless figures. Their contribution to nation-building is frequently submerged in the vastness of public life. Not many choose to recount their work and experiences after retirement. Former IAS officer MR Sivaraman's autobiography, *Flight Into Turbulence and Safe Landing*, is therefore both refreshing and informative. A 1962-batch officer of the Madhya Pradesh cadre, Sivaraman held several key positions, including Revenue Secretary to the Government of India, Executive Director at the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and Director General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). In his book, he presents his perspective candidly and without hesitation. His willingness to recount both his achievements and his differences with those in positions of authority makes the narrative particularly engaging.

Sivaraman says his approach to public service was simple: remain upright and honest, whatever the circumstances. That principle, he believes, served him well. He also recalls his differences with political leaders, including the then Civil Aviation Minister, the late Madhav Rao Scindia, over official matters during his tenure as DGCA.

One of the most gripping sections deals with the 1993 Indian Airlines hijacking crisis. Sivaraman recounts the difficult decision he took at Amritsar airport, including the possibility of opening fire inside a passenger-filled aircraft to

prevent it from taking off for Pakistan, as demanded by the hijackers. His account provides details and perspectives that remain relatively unfamiliar even today.

The title may initially appear unconventional, but it is deeply symbolic. Sivaraman took charge as DGCA at a turbulent moment for Indian aviation, following the crash of an Airbus A320 in Bangalore. His tenure placed him at the centre of a sector facing serious challenges, making the metaphor of turbulence particularly apt.

Sivaraman also questions Jawaharlal Nehru's economic model, particularly his socialist leanings, which he argues constrained the growth of the private sector. That assessment, however, could have benefited from greater historical context. Nehru had limited room for manoeuvre in an era when India was struggling with widespread poverty and enormous developmental challenges, and the priorities of the time were shaped by the needs of a vast population struggling for basic survival.

Where Sivaraman is on particularly firm ground is in his discussion of economic reforms during his tenure as Revenue Secretary under the then Finance Minister, the late Manmohan Singh. *Flight Into Turbulence and Safe Landing* ultimately offers something more than the recollections of a retired bureaucrat. It provides an insider's account of the pressures, conflicts and responsibilities that accompany public office. Its strongest passages are those in which Sivaraman allows the reader to see the civil servant behind the office: someone required to make difficult decisions, stand his ground and navigate the turbulence of administration without compromising his principles.

The book reviewer is a writer and commentator on public affairs, politics and society



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This Week's Zodiac Insights

Profession • Money • Family • Relationships • Health • Travel



Mesha | Aries: The week ahead helps you stay composed even when situations feel uncertain. Work can move smoothly, with tasks completed on time and appreciation coming your way. Financial matters may also improve, while relationships remain supportive and old connections could return. **Watch out for:** Speaking too sharply with elders and overlooking an older family member's health.



Vrishabha | Taurus: As the week unfolds, fresh ideas can strengthen your professional standing and an important person may prove helpful in the long run. Money matters need thoughtful handling, especially around risky decisions or agreements. Family bonds can improve when you make more time for them. **Watch out for:** Financial strain, relationship distance and physical overexertion.



Mithuna | Gemini: The coming week feels calmer and more settled, with confidence and professional authority likely to improve. Support from your partner and friends can help personal or business plans move ahead. Spending may remain high despite good prospects, so keep priorities balanced. **Watch out for:** Overspending, family worries and breathing-related discomfort.



Karka | Cancer: During the week, unfinished work can move towards completion through steady effort. Business and investment matters look encouraging, while asset-related decisions may also come up. Personal relationships improve when you listen patiently and avoid reacting too quickly. **Watch out for:** Property paperwork, family tension and neglecting your health under a heavy workload.



Simha | Leo: This week may bring a pleasant emotional lift along with encouraging movement in business and finances. Confidence grows, but differences with your spouse are best handled calmly before they build up. Friends may not always be motivating, so trust your own judgement. **Watch out for:** Domestic arguments, discouraging company and breathing-related discomfort.



Kanya | Virgo: In the week ahead, a new initiative may face resistance at first but can gain support once its value becomes clear. Business and financial prospects remain strong, while family pressure begins to ease. Old friends or relatives may reconnect positively. **Watch out for:** Relationship disappointment and expecting support without clear communication.



Tula | Libra: The week brings mixed but manageable results, with earlier good efforts returning in your favour even as delays test your patience. Money transactions require extra care, while support from your spouse and close friends helps you stay steady. Family matters may bring happy news. **Watch out for:** Financial fraud, paperwork delays and breathing discomfort.



Vrishchika | Scorpio: As the week progresses, career matters can open promising opportunities and business decisions may become more rewarding. Income may slow briefly before recovering, while friends can offer practical support. Relationships improve when you explain yourself with patience rather than frustration. **Watch out for:** Family health concerns and overextending yourself professionally.



Dhanu | Sagittarius: The coming week supports business growth and profitable deals, especially through trusted connections. Professional dealings remain favourable, though income may feel less secure than expected. Siblings or friends can help with practical matters when pressure rises, and a short break may help you recharge. **Watch out for:** Loose talk in relationships and overwork.



Makara | Capricorn: This week looks eventful, with work progressing steadily and business matters showing encouraging movement. Your communication can help in negotiations and relationships, while a housing or property decision may also come into focus. Money needs careful handling despite positive momentum. **Watch out for:** Casual lending, delayed plans and back or abdominal discomfort.



Kumbha | Aquarius: Over the coming week, your focus shifts strongly towards self-improvement and professional progress. Career recognition and financial stability look favourable, while family support can guide you through a temporary setback. Old contacts may return with renewed interest and support. **Watch out for:** Relationship disappointment and ignoring useful advice from your partner.



Meena | Pisces: The week calls for patience, especially when making decisions about matters that have troubled you for some time. Work may face errors or missed opportunities, while finances need caution and less dependence on others. Differences within the family should be handled without haste. **Watch out for:** Rash decisions, careless speech, borrowing pressure and health concerns.



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The True Guru Is Within You

AMMA (SRI MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI DEVI)

Whether it is art, science, history or even tying a shoelace, one cannot learn anything without a teacher. Spirituality is a science-the science of dealing with the inner Self. If one needs a teacher for all material sciences, then what to say of spirituality, the most subtle science of all?

One does not really choose the guru. The relationship comes about spontaneously. However, for there to be a guru, there must first be a disciple. Once the disciple is ready, the guru appears.

A sadguru is someone completely devoid of ego. Having transcended the sense of a separate self and all likes and dislikes, the sadguru makes no claims. Such a guru sees only divinity-the self-luminous Self, pure awareness-in everything.

The sadguru is the epitome of pure love, compassion and self-sacrifice. He will be humbler than the humblest and simpler than the simplest. In fact, in a true guru-disciple relationship, due to the incredible humility of the guru, it will be difficult to tell the difference between the guru and the disciple.

One day Darkness approached God and said, "I've never done anything to hurt the Sun, but he goes on torturing me. Wherever I go, he soon comes and I have to run away. I cannot even rest. I don't want to complain, but enough is enough! How long is this going to go on?"

God immediately summoned the Sun and asked, "Why are you harassing poor Darkness?"

The Sun said, "What are you talking about? I've never met anyone called Darkness." Sure enough, God looked around and Darkness was no longer there. He had disappeared. The Sun continued, "Whenever you can manage to bring Darkness in front of me, I'm ready to apologise or do whatever you say. Perhaps, unknowingly, I have hurt



him." To this day, Darkness's case against the Sun is still lying there. God has yet to bring both sides together, and until both are present, the case cannot be tried. This is because it is impossible for Darkness to face the Sun. Darkness has no existence; it is just the absence of light. Ego, like Darkness, has no existence of its own. It simply cannot remain once the light of the guru dawns.

The role of the external guru is to help awaken the true guru within us, where the light of the divine eternally shines. The guru within and the guru without are one and the same. The entire universe is pervaded by that guru-tattvam, the guru principle. Once the guru within is awakened, everything becomes a guru.

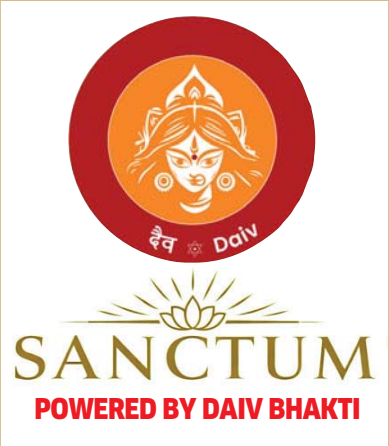
For such disciples, the whole world becomes a book from which they learn. They realise that life is an examination hall where every moment is precious and time must not be wasted. They speak only as much as necessary, eat only what is needed, and sleep only as much as required. Their choices are guided by necessity, not by desire.

A sense of gratitude, reverence and humility towards all things naturally

awakens. A stalk of paddy bends down towards the ground after it ripens. It symbolises the truth that humility comes with wisdom. Such a person develops a motherly tenderness and affection towards all.

True spiritual growth begins only when we learn to see God, or the guru, in everything. The guru-tattvam abides within every being as the antaryami, the indweller, ever waiting to illumine our hearts with the light of wisdom. The sadguru is the visible, living embodiment of that inner divine principle.

(Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi, known simply as Amma, is a spiritual master and humanitarian who has given her darshan in the form of a motherly embrace to more than 4 crore people. Listening to the cries of the suffering, Amma leads the Mata Amritanandamayi Math, an NGO that reaches across more than 50 countries, working in healthcare, disaster relief, education, gender equality, and environmental restoration)



The Essential Ingredient to be a Successful Leader

SADHGURU

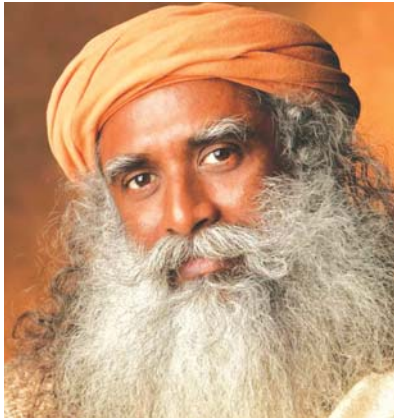
If one has to become a leader, he has to transform himself into a larger possibility. What was essentially individual concern becomes a little larger concern in some sense.

What is being looked forward to from a leader is that he should be able to see things that other people are not able to see. He need not be a super human being. He need not know everything. Most leaders do not know much, but they are able to see certain things that other people are missing and they are able to

put people together for a certain common purpose. That makes them leaders. Who you are - what your mind is, what your emotions are and how you are right now - will manifest in every action that you perform in the world. And once you are in the position of leadership, every thought and emotion that you generate, and every action that you

perform has an impact on many people - maybe a few hundred people or a thousand people or millions of people, depending on what type of leadership you are in. When this is so, it is extremely important that one who wishes to be a leader, in some way, focuses upon how he is within himself too, not just about how he performs in the world.

It would be irresponsible for a leader not to be constantly striving to transform himself first. Essentially leadership also means, either you are transforming people's lives directly, or you are trans-



forming situations which will in turn lead to transformation of life for other people. So transformation and leadership cannot be separated.

Our Common Aspiration
Whether you are leading a company, or a community, or a city or a country, leadership is the art of making people realize that somewhere, deep down, all our aspirations are the same.

The first time I was at the World Economic Forum, people looked at me very resentfully. Somebody said, "What is a mystic doing at an economic conference?" I thought I should speak their own language, so I asked, "What do you do? What is your business?" This person said, "Well, I am working for the second largest computer manufacturer." I said, "You are doing computers..." I pointed out someone who was in the automobile industry and I said, "He is making cars. Somebody there is making a safety pin. It does not matter whether you are making a computer, car, safety pin or spacecraft, what is the fundamental business?" He said, "What? My business is computer."

I said, "Your business is not computer. The fundamental business is human

wellbeing, isn't it? You might have forgotten why you are making a computer. Essentially, you are manufacturing computers to make human life better. Somebody is manufacturing a safety pin to make human life better. The essential business is human wellbeing, and that is my business too, so that is why I am here."

Integrity and Insight

What people expect from a leader is that, first of all, he is straight. People do not appreciate you manipulating them. You do not have to be brilliant or a genius or a super human to be a leader. You are straight - your integrity is always there - and you have some vision and insight into a few things. That makes you a leader.

When you are truly inclusive, you will naturally have an insight about everything. Then the right kind of people will naturally gather around you when they see a certain level of integrity in you, and things will happen, according to your capability, of course. You can never equate people's capabilities. People come with different capabilities, which is fine, but the question is just this: are you able to use yourself to the fullest extent or not?

If you yourself are an issue on a daily basis, you cannot handle issues on the outside. If you make yourself in such a way that you are not an issue anymore, now you can attend to the outside issues to the best of your capability, and your leadership will happen effortlessly, without being stressful to you, or to anyone for that matter. That is transformative leadership.

(Ranked amongst the fifty most influential people in India, Sadhguru is a Yogi, mystic, visionary and a New York Times bestselling author. Sadhguru has been conferred the Padma Vibhushan by the Government of India in 2017, the highest annual civilian award, accorded for exceptional and distinguished service. He is also the founder of the world's largest people's movement, Conscious Planet: Save Soil, which has touched over 4 billion people)

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Scan to Explore

Following Rules: The Key to a Happy Life

Rules may feel restrictive today, but they often protect us from regrets tomorrow. A code of conduct is the quiet guardian of a disciplined and dignified life

DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

The very mention of the word 'rule' often creates a sense of restriction. Yet rules are not made to bind us; they are made to protect us. Human nature naturally longs for freedom, and therefore rules can sometimes appear burdensome. But when we understand the purpose behind them, we realise that rules do not take away our freedom. Rather, they safeguard our well-being, security and success.

Traffic rules are perhaps the simplest example. Stopping at a red light, driving within the prescribed speed limit, staying in the designated lane and fastening a seatbelt may initially seem like restrictions. One may even wonder, "Why should I stop at a red light when the road is completely empty?" The answer is simple: rules are not designed according to an individual's convenience; they are designed for the safety of everyone.

If every driver started changing the rules according to personal convenience, roads would soon become chaotic rather than orderly. A helmet, too, may feel like an unnecessary burden, especially when the destination is only a few minutes away. But a single moment of an accident can make us realise the value of that small inconvenience. A helmet may not shorten the journey, but it can prevent life itself from being shortened.

Similarly, students are required to follow a fixed schedule, study a prescribed syllabus, maintain discipline in the examination hall and refrain from cheating. These rules are not intended to trouble students; they exist to assess their actual knowledge and ability. A student may secure the highest marks through cheating, but marks obtained without knowledge have little real value. If examination rules were removed, an examination would cease to be a fair competition and become a contest of deception.

Imagine a cricket match in which a bowler could deliver the ball from wherever he wished, a batsman could leave the pitch whenever he wanted to run, and a fielder could physically stop another player instead of stopping the ball. The game would descend into chaos within moments.

Cricket is exciting precisely because its freedom exists within a framework of rules. A batsman is free to play an extraordinary range of shots, but only within the boundaries of the game. A bowler has the freedom to use his skill and strategy, but within certain regulations. Similarly, in boxing, a fighter is permitted to use strength and skill, but not to strike an opponent wherever he wishes. Once the rules disappear, sport ceases to be a test of skill and becomes an act of violence. Thus, rules do not destroy freedom; they preserve the very character and purpose of the activity.

Life is no different. Success does not depend on talent alone; it also requires strength to abide by a set of principles. The discipline of time, restraint in speech, moderation in food and lifestyle, courtesy in behaviour and sincerity in fulfilling responsibilities; all these principles bring order to our lives. A life without rules or boundaries may appear free from the outside, but gradually it becomes a victim of disorder from within.

Our ancient shastras and tradition have prescribed appropriate disciplines and boundaries for both renunciants and householders according to their respective responsibilities and stages of life.

For a renunciant, the shastras prescribe a disciplined way of life centred on self-restraint, celibacy, non-possession, service, tapasya and spiritual practice. Mahant Swami Maharaj has cultivated these virtues since his childhood. He recalls how Guru Yogiji Maharaj inspired him to observe fasts and high spiritual discipline. Until the age of eighty,

Mahant Swami Maharaj observed seven nirjala (waterless) fasts each month, along with other prescribed observances during Chaturmas. Now, at the age of ninety-three, he continues to follow the spiritual disciplines prescribed by the shastras with the same devotion and steadfastness.

On the other hand, for a householder, there are responsibilities towards family and society, along with guidelines concerning food, conduct, relationships, devotion and spiritual association.

To an external observer, some of these disciplines may appear restrictive or orthodox. But in reality, they function as a protective shield. They protect an individual from impulses that may otherwise lead him away from his higher purpose.

Consider a river. It flows between its banks, and because of those boundaries, its water remains purposeful and beneficial. If the river were to abandon its banks, the same water that nourishes life could become a destructive flood. The banks do not prevent the river from flowing; they give it flow direction.

In the same way, rules and moral boundaries give direction to human freedom. They are not walls of a jail; they are signposts. They are not meant to stop our progress but to prevent us from moving in the wrong direction. True freedom is not the freedom to do whatever we want. It is the freedom to choose what is right and to have the discipline to live by that choice.

(Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

World Rivers Day Special

When nature is considered sacred, conservation comes naturally

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Water has a deep relation with life. Apart from making up nearly two thirds of our body, water is also required in the atmosphere for us to survive. It is present deep in the crevices of earth and far above up in the clouds.

The Sanskrit word for water is apa and the word apta means 'that which is born out of water'. Water symbolises love and apta also means 'the dearest one'. All the major ancient civilizations thrived on river banks, whether it was Ganga or Yamuna in India, Nile in Egypt or Amazon in South America. India has always had a strong cultural connection with its rivers. Lord Rama's life was spent around the Sarayuriver. Ganga is depicted as emerging from Lord Shiva. For thousands of years, saints and yogis have been meditating and doing their spiritual practices on Her banks. While Ganga represents knowledge, Yamuna stands for devotion. The love and devotion of the gopis towards Lord Krishna is immortalized on the banks of Yamuna. All the rivers in India feature in some story or the other in the ancient Purana texts reminding us of their spiritual significance.

Flowing water has a connection with the mind. It is also symbolic of the flow of life. A river does not stop when it encounters stones; it flows over or around them. Similarly, hurdles are inevitable in life; we don't stop moving because of them. When you keep flowing, you remain pure and when you keep brooding over past events, you stagnate. Clinging to the past and regretting it makes you feel heavy from inside. Watching the flow of water in a river can wash such feelings from your mind. It has been seen, when people contemplating suicide go to a river or water to jump into it, watching the water flow for a few minutes creates a shift inside them, it uplifts their energy and makes them change their mind.

Water also has the unique ability to hold feelings and vibrations, which has been proven today. This is why spiritual fairs like the Kumbh are visited by saints, so that they can share their positive vibrations and energy with others. Rivers not only support life; they also enrich it in so many ways. Unfortunately, we have neglected them for a long time. A lot of our rivers have dried up and the ones that remain have become extremely polluted. In a land where rivers were considered sacred, we've come along

way in the opposite direction.

Faith plays a very important role in motivating people to walk the path of righteousness and to care for the environment. We can have the best policies in place but to implement those policies you need the people at the grassroots to be more aware of what they are, and their significance and here faith-based organizations can make a big difference. Faith and spirituality can also help strengthen the mind and spirit. Any policy made without taking care of the mental health of people on the planet is going to be a waste. That's what we did in India. Taking along the people at the grassroots, we rejuvenated 75-odd rivers that existed only on revenue records. The dry river beds here were being exploited by the sand mafia; there was no water, crops wouldn't grow and farmers suffered immensely. The number of farmers taking their own lives rose every day.

So we went to the villages at the grassroots. We encouraged them and taught them meditation, breathing, yoga and other practices to be happy and strong from within. We worked with them to build thousands of ground recharge wells so the rainwater could start seeping in. There was a time when people brought in species like acacia or babool from other countries that were not suited for Indian soil and drained water. No doubt trees like acacia grew fast, and were green but not a bird would sit on them, rivers started drying out and no grass would grow under them. We took up reforestation initiatives, replacing species like acacia trees and planting indigenous trees like mango, peepal and others along the riverbeds.

In river rejuvenation, it is also important to see the path of the river is free from encroachments. Land is so valuable. What happens is when there is no river flowing for a decade or two, people start encroaching on the land. The next challenge is

dealing with the sand mafia. Sand is a commodity and people would come and take the sand away, a big task but something that we need to prevent.

The miracle was, after doing the land surveys, building the recharge structures, and replanting millions of right species of plants, we could see thousands of water bodies, ponds were rejuvenated and today 75 odd rivers are gushing with perennial water in many Indian states, the birds have started coming back, and so have the clouds. Development need not be at loggerheads with the preservation of nature. We can take our lessons in environmental preservation from nature itself. Nature digests waste materials and produces something beautiful every time.

All the ancient civilizations, in India, China, South America and elsewhere honored Nature; they worshiped mountains, rivers, trees, the sun and the moon. Their view was to see all of them as full of life, because they contribute to and sustain our life. We need to learn about conservation from the indigenous communities. I have travelled around the world and when I go into the tribal areas, whether it is in Africa, say the Maasai Mara community or Indian tribal villages or the aboriginal communities of Canada, I have found them to be the finest testimonies of how conservation should be done. They don't use plastic or litter. They are filled with a certain sense of sacredness for nature, a certain sense of ownership for natural resources, which seems to be amiss in urban cities. Similarly, if you observe the animals, they preserve the forest perfectly. You will not see animals litter the forest floor, and neither do people who are close to nature.

It's only when we start moving away from our connection to Nature, that we begin polluting and destroying the environment. In the last few years, however, there is more awareness about environmental issues. More people are learning about the need to save water and the importance of methods like rainwater harvesting in both rural and urban areas. The government and local bodies also have a critical role in spreading awareness and enforcing policies to this end.

The ancient view was to see all of Nature as an extension of one's Self. Having a sense of belongingness with Nature, one cannot but honor it. Skill is aligning with Nature outside and with one's own nature within and wisdom is in knowing that they are one and the same.